sonic yoga

TEACHER TRAINING PROGRAM

200 HR YOGA TEACHER TRAINING

MANUAL

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Namaste

I honor the place in you
In which the entire universe dwells.
I honor the place in you
Which is of love, of truth,
Of light and of peace.
When you are in that place in you,
And I'm in that place in me,
We are one.

TRADITIONAL YOGIC SALUTATION

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Introduction

Congratulations on beginning your journey into the world of teaching yoga. We are so excited and thankful to be able to share this adventure with you.

As we all know, the country is fast coming to realize the incredible benefits of this powerful practice.

Participation has grown by millions of students and with all of this demand comes a need for well-trained yoga teachers, guides and leaders in their communities. Our Yoga Alliance- accredited training and certification school came to life in 2001 and, since then, we are thrilled to have graduated hundreds of blossoming teachers.

Our mission is simple—to deliver an educational and transformational experience designed to foster a deeper knowledge of the practice and its traditions, a joyous, engaged heart, a stronger connection with the people and energies around you, as well as the fundamental skills and knowledge needed to safely and effectively begin your teaching journey.

This program will ask a lot of you. It is intense and emotions often emerge as layers of discovery are peeled away. We ask that you commit completely to the process and, in return, we will commit to delivering the most empowering, nurturing and safe environment possible to create a place for the seeds of your metamorphosis to blossom.

We feel incredibly blessed to be invited into your life and to have the opportunity to share our passion for teaching with you.

To the journey ahead!

Namaste,

Lauren & The Sonic Yoga Staff

PART 1

OVERVIEW, PHILOSOPHY & TEACHING METHODOLOGY

CORE PHILOSOPHY

Often, the press of life moves us away from our true nature or authentic self. Instead of creating a life of present joy, compassion, and vision, we live a punch-list life within a framework of frenzy. Sonic Yoga brings us back to the center and cultivates the confidence to live in harmony with our authentic, natural self. Rather than hopelessly chasing abundance, we awaken to the realization that abundance is all around us when we are true to our path and we drink in its offerings. We find ourselves, almost inadvertently, increasingly able to fully arrive in each moment and meet challenges with greater perspective and grace.

On a yogic, emotional, and spiritual level, the practice of Sonic Yoga encourages us to explore the following:

- **Grounding:** Taking a moment to stop and to be present in your life in the here and now, to slow down to evaluate what's immediately important to you, without looking back or forward.
- **Finding Flow:** Learning to move more smoothly through life, evaluating obstacles, finding solutions, taking charge, and acting with integrity.
- **Connecting to Power:** Discovering and cultivating the fortitude to take the risks that you need to take in life, digging deep down within and connecting to your own internal source of power—whatever that may be for you.
- **Opening the Heart:** Creating space for the sensations and emotions of life, joy, love, grief, etc, to blossom, embracing all the seasons of your experience, learning to give of yourself as well as to receive, cultivating a connection to community.
- **Expanding your Horizons:** Engaging in an exploration of life and a myriad of possibilities, thinking out of the box, creating your own future, visualizing and opening to your dreams, reaching beyond the mundane circumstances of your existence, learning to incorporate an element of spirit into your life. Creating a vision and believing in the manifestation of that dream.

On a more classical well-being or allopathic “show me the evidence” level, a regular Sonic Yoga practice cultivates a lightning and stillness of the mind we call the “relaxation response” state, associated with a lower heart rate, blood pressure and decreased levels of chronic stressor hormones. This physiological state is also associated with decreased risk for heart disease and stroke, improved mood, decreased anxiety, and increased mental alertness.

From a fitness standpoint, Sonic Yoga also provides a phenomenal full-body strength, flexibility and cardiovascular workout. It can literally transform your body and its abilities, improve your ability to live a more functional, pain-free life, and further reduce your risk of a wide array of life-limiting or ending diseases.

In addition, delivers you into a community and environment that inspires and challenges you, while also being forgiving, nurturing, accepting, lighthearted, and even humorous, for students at all levels.

THE ART OF TEACHING

“Teaching is a difficult art, but it is the best service you can do to humanity.”
B.K.S. Iyengar

ROLE OF THE TEACHER

1. Personal practice
2. Creation of a Safe Space
3. Teaching as Service
4. Internal Teacher

TEACHING METHODOLOGY

- Core Concerns
- Cultivating a Personal Teaching Philosophy
  - Who are you?
  - What are your spiritual practices and beliefs?
  - What overall message are you looking to bring to your students?
  - What overall energy?

QUALITIES OF THE TEACHER

Soul/Spirit
Authentic
Reflective
Sincere
Inspirational
Humorous
Motivating

Mind
Vibrant
Energetic
Confident
Articulate
Analytical
Logical
Creative

Heart
Compassionate
Sensitive
Friendly
Kind
Patient
Expressive
Respectful
Nurturing

CLASS PREPARATION

CREATING THE THEME/MESSAGE
CULTIVATING THE ENERGY/MOOD/BHAVA
CHOOSING THE LIVING YOGA CHAT CONTENT
CHOOSING RELEVANT READING
CHOOSING THE MUSIC
SETTING A CLASS INTENTION

MASSAGING ENERGY & FLOW

- Combine effort & surrender
- Pay attention to the beginning, middle, & end
- Cue breath before movement
- Use rhythm
- Create the vinyasa within the vinyasa
- Keep breath count consistent
- Work one element at a time for emphasis
- Work with pulsation
- Work with stillness
- Acknowledge the pause
- Use imagery and creative language
- Speak to the body, heart & soul, (not the mind)
- Learn how to encourage endurance, balance, relaxation
- Allow self-discovery
- Listen to the internal teacher
- Be mindful of pacing

- The Power of Language & Vocal Control
  - Voice Mechanics
  - Vocal presence
  - Tone & Modulation
  - Conscious Language

- The Power of PhysicalPresence
  - Pace
  - Carriage
  - Animation

- The Power of Touch
  - Therapeutic
  - Corrective
  - Nurturing
  - Inspiring
  - Deepening

- Challenging Scenarios:
  - Student Body Odor & “Emissions”
  - Eating disorders
  - Disrespectful behavior
  - Teacher Illness
  - Emotional Outbursts
  - Miscellaneous

- The Adult Learning Process
  - Modalities – visual, auditory, kinesthetic

- Cultivating Body Awareness
  - Giving opportunity to self-adjust
  - Exploring proprioception through closed eyes, movement, etc.

- Demonstrating & Multitasking

- Teaching to the Beginner

- Ethical Guidelines
  - Touch
  - Boundaries
  - Sexual relations
  - Respect
  - Compassion

- The Art of Effective Alignment Cueing
  - Accuracy/Clarity
  - Efficiency
  - Prioritizing Safety
  - Stacking to Build Foundation
  - Pacing & repetition
  - Information Overload

PART 2

YOGA FROM THE EAST

What is Yoga?

A SHORT HISTORY OF YOGA

By Georg Feuerstein

> “To be ignorant of what happened before one was born is to remain ever a child”
> — Marcus Tullius Cicero

HISTORY OF YOGINS AND YOGINIS

History of Yogins and Yoginis
In Yoga, theory and practice, as well as left brain and right brain, go hand in hand so to speak. Study (svādhyāya) is in fact an important aspect of many branches and schools of Yoga. This is another way in which Yoga’s balanced approach shows itself.

If you want to know where something is going, it is good to know where it came from. “To be ignorant of what happened before one was born,” said Cicero pointedly in his Orator, “is to remain ever a child.” History provides context and meaning, and Yoga is no exception to this rule. If you are fond of history, you’ll enjoy what follows. Many of the facts and ideas presented here have not yet found their way into the textbooks or even into most Yoga books. We put you in touch with the leading edge of knowledge in this area. If you are not a history buff, well, perhaps we can tempt you to suspend your preferences for a few minutes and read on anyway.

THE ORIGIN OF YOGA

Despite more than a century of research, we still don’t know much about the earliest beginnings of Yoga. We do know, though, that it originated in India 5,000 or more years ago. Until recently, many Western scholars thought that Yoga originated much later, maybe around 500 B.C., which is the time of Gautama the Buddha, the illustrious founder of Buddhism. But then, in the early 1920s, archeologists surprised the world with the discovery of the so-called Indus civilization—a culture that we now know extended over an area of roughly 300,000 square miles (the size of Texas and Ohio combined). This was in fact the largest civilization in early antiquity. In the ruins of the big cities of Mohenjo Daro and Harappa, excavators found depictions engraved on soapstone seals that strongly resemble yogi-like figures. Many other finds show the amazing continuity between that civilization and later Hindu society and culture.

That civilization's urbane population enjoyed multistory buildings, a sewage system unparalleled in the ancient world until the Roman empire, a huge public bath whose walls were water-proofed with bitumen, geometrically laid out brick roads, and standardized baked bricks for convenient construction. (We are so used to these technological achievements that we sometimes forget they had to be invented.) The Indus-Sarasvati people were a great maritime nation that exported a large variety of goods to Mesopotamia and other parts of the Middle East and Africa. Although only a few pieces of art have survived, some of them show exquisite craftsmanship.

For a long time, scholars thought that this magnificent civilization was abruptly destroyed by invaders from the northwest who called themselves Aryans (ārya meaning "noble" in the Sanskrit language). Some proposed that these warlike nomads invented Yoga, others credited the Indus people with its creation. Yet others took Yoga to be the joint creation of both races.

Nowadays, researchers increasingly favor a completely different picture of ancient Indian history. They are coming to the conclusion that there never was an Aryan invasion and that the decline of the Indus-Sarasvati cities was due to dramatic changes in climate.

These, in turn, appear to have been caused by a major tectonic catastrophe changing the course of rivers. In particular, it led to the drying up of what was once India's largest river, the Sarasvati, along whose banks flourished numerous towns and villages (some 2500 sites have been identified thus far). Today the dry river bed runs through the vast Thar Desert. If it were not for satellite photography, we would not have learned about those many settlements buried under the sand.

The drying up of the Sarasvati River, which was complete by around 1900 B.C., had far-reaching consequences. Just imagine the waters of the Mississippi running dry instead of flooding constantly. What havoc this would cause! The death of the Sarasvati River forced the population to migrate to more fertile parts of the country, especially east toward the Ganges (Ganga) River and south into Central India and Tamilnadu.

Why is this important for the history of Yoga, you might ask? The Sarasvati River happens to be the most celebrated river in the Rig-Veda, which is the oldest known text in any Indo-European language. It is composed in an archaic (and difficult) form of Sanskrit and was transmitted by word of mouth for numerous generations.

Sanskrit is the language in which most Yoga scriptures are written. It is related to languages like Greek, Latin, French, German, Spanish, and not least English. You can see this family relationship in the example of the word yoga itself, which corresponds to *zugos, iugum, joug, Joch, yugo,* and *yoke* in these languages. Sanskrit is like an older brother to the other Indo-European languages.

Now, if the Sarasvati River dried up around or before 1900 B.C., the Rig-Veda must be earlier than that benchmark date. If that is so, then the composers of this collection of hymns must have been contemporaneous with the people of the Indus civilization, which flourished between circa 3000-1900 B.C. Indeed, astronomical references in the Rig-Veda suggest that at least some of its 1,028 hymns were composed in the third or even fourth millennium B.C.

Thus, the Sanskrit-speaking Aryans, who created the Rig-Veda, did not come from outside India to destroy the Indus-Sarasvati civilization. They had been there all along. What, then, was their relationship with the Indus-Sarasvati people? Here opinions still differ, but there is a growing understanding that the Aryans and the Indus-Sarasvati people were one and the same. There is nothing in the Rig-Veda to suggest otherwise.

In fact, the Rig-Veda and the other archaic Sanskrit texts appear to be the "missing" literature of the Indus civilization. Conversely, the archeological artifacts of the Indus valley and adjoining areas give us the "missing" material base of the early Sanskrit literature—an elegant solution to a problem that has long vexed researchers.

Yoga and the Indus-Sarasvati Civilization

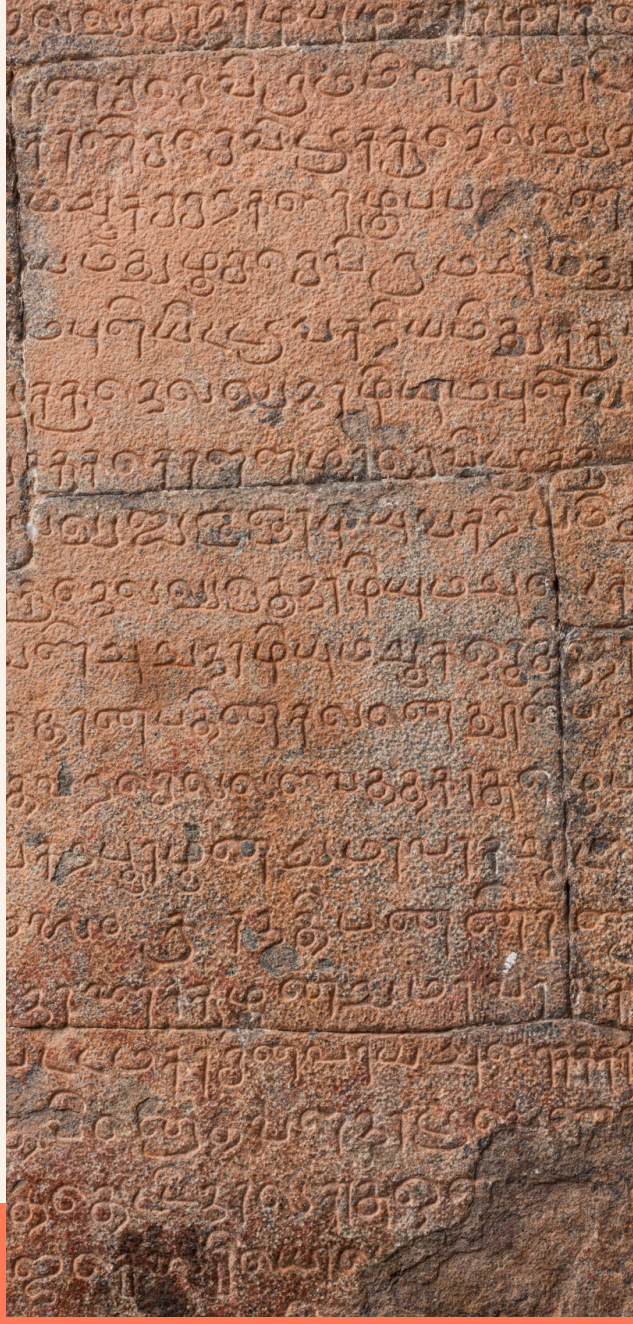
This means that Yoga is the product of a mature civilization that was unparalleled in the ancient world. Think of it! As a Yoga practitioner, you are part of an ancient and honorable stream of tradition, which makes you a descendant of that civilization at least at the level of the heart. Many of the inventions credited to Sumer rightfully belong to what is now known as the Indus-Sarasvati civilization, which evolved out of a cultural tradition that has reliably been dated back to the seventh millennium B.C. In turn, it gave rise to the great religious and cultural tradition of Hinduism, but indirectly also to Buddhism and Jainism.

India's civilization can claim to be the oldest enduring civilization in the world. Its present-day problems should not blind us to its glorious past and the lessons we can learn from it. Yoga practitioners in particular can benefit from India's protracted experimentation with life, especially its explorations of the mysteries of the mind. The Indian civilization has produced great philosophical and spiritual geniuses who between them have covered every conceivable answer to the big questions, which are as relevant today as they were thousands of years ago.

THE BIG QUESTIONS

Traditional Yoga seeks to provide plausible answers to such profound questions as, “Who am I?”, “Whence do I come?”, “Whither do I go?,” and “What must I do?” These are the sorts of questions that, sooner or later, we all end up asking ourselves. Or at least, we have our own implicit answers to them, though may not get around to consciously formulating them. Deep down, we all are philosophers, because we all need to make sense of our life. Some of us postpone thinking about these questions, but they don’t ever go away. We quickly learn this when we lose a loved one or face a serious health crisis.

So, we might as well ponder these questions while we are in good shape. And don’t think you have to feel morose to do so. Yoga doesn’t champion dark moods, but it is definitely in favor of awareness in all its forms, including self-awareness. If we know the stuff we are made of, we can function a lot better in the world. At the very least, our self-knowledge will give us the opportunity to make conscious and better choices.



THE HISTORY OF YOGA

I can provide here only the merest thumbnail sketch and, if you wish to inform yourself more about the long history of Yoga, recommend that you study my book The Yoga Tradition. This is the most comprehensive historical overview available anywhere.

But be prepared for challenging reading and a fairly large tome. The history of Yoga can conveniently be divided into the following four broad categories:

- Vedic Yoga
- Preclassical Yoga
- Classical Yoga
- Postclassical Yoga

These categories are like static snapshots of something that is in actuality in continuous motion—the “march of history.”

VEDIC YOGA

Now we are entering a somewhat more technical territory, and I will have to use and explain a number of Sanskrit terms. The yogic teachings found in the above-mentioned Rig-Veda and the other three ancient hymnodies are known as Vedic Yoga. The Sanskrit word *Veda* means "knowledge," while the Sanskrit term *rig* (from ric) means "praise." Thus the sacred Rig-Veda is a collection of hymns that are in praise of a higher power. This collection is in fact the fountainhead of Hinduism, which has around one billion adherents today. You could say that the Rig-Veda is to Hinduism what the Book of Genesis is to Christianity.

The other three Vedic hymnodies are the Yajur-Veda ("Knowledge of Sacrifice"), Sama-Veda ("Knowledge of Chants"), and Atharva-Veda ("Knowledge of Atharvan"). The first collection contains the sacrificial formulas used by the Vedic priests. The second text contains the chants accompanying the sacrifices. The third hymnody is filled with magical incantations for all occasions but also includes a number of very powerful philosophical hymns. It is connected with Atharvan, a famous fire priest who is remembered as having been a master of magical rituals. These hymnodies can be compared to the various books of the Old Testament.

It is clear from what has been said thus far that Vedic Yoga—which could also be called Archaic Yoga—was intimately connected with the ritual life of the ancient Indians. It revolved around the idea of sacrifice as a means of joining the material world with the invisible world of the spirit. In order to perform the exacting rituals successfully, the sacrificers had to be able to focus their mind for a prolonged period of time. Such inner focusing for the sake of transcending the limitations of the ordinary mind is the root of Yoga.

When successful, the Vedic yogi was graced with a "vision" or experience of the transcendental reality. A great master of Vedic Yoga was called a "seer"—in Sanskrit rishi. The Vedic seers were able to see the very fabric of existence, and their hymns speak of their marvelous intuitions, which can still inspire us today.

PRE-CLASSICAL YOGA

This category covers an extensive period of approximately 2,000 years until the second century A.D. Preclassical Yoga comes in various forms and guises. The earliest manifestations were still closely associated with the Vedic sacrificial culture, as developed in the Brāhmanas and Āranyakas. The Brāhmanas are Sanskrit texts explaining the Vedic hymns and the rituals behind them. The Āranyakas are ritual texts specific to those who chose to live in seclusion in a forest hermitage.

Yoga came into its own with the Upanishads, which are gnostic texts expounding the hidden teaching about the ultimate unity of all things. There are over 200 of these scriptures, though only a handful of them was composed in the period prior to Gautama the Buddha (fifth century B.C.). These works can be likened to the New Testament, which rests on the Old Testament but at the same time goes beyond it. One of the most remarkable Yoga scriptures is the Bhagavad-Gītā ("Lord's Song"), of which the great social reformer Mahatma Gandhi spoke as follows:

When disappointment stares me in the face and all alone I see not one ray of light, I go back to the Bhagavad-Gītā. I find a verse here and a verse there and I immediately begin to smile in the midst of overwhelming tragedies—and my life has been full of external tragedies—and if they have left no visible, no indelible scar on me, I owe it all to the teachings of the Bhagavad-Gītā. (Young India, 1925, pp. 1078-79)

In its significance, this work of only 700 verses perhaps is to Hindus what Jesus' Sermon on the Mount is to Christians. Its message, however, is not to turn the other cheek but to actively oppose evil in the world. In its present form, the Bhagavad-Gītā (Gītā for short) was composed around 500 B.C. and since then has been a daily inspiration to millions of Hindus. Its central teaching is to the point: To be alive means to be active and, if we want to avoid difficulties for ourselves and others, our actions must be benign and also go beyond the grip of the ego. A simple matter, really, but how difficult to accomplish in daily life!

Preclassical Yoga also comprises the many schools whose teachings can be found in India's two great national epics, the Râmâyana and the Mahābhārata (in which the Bhagavad-Gītā is embedded and which is seven times the size of the Iliad and Odyssey combined). These various preclassical schools developed all kinds of techniques for achieving deep meditation through which yogis and yoginis can transcend the body and mind and discover their true nature.

CLASSICAL YOGA

This label applies to the eightfold Yoga —also known as Rāja-Yoga—taught by Patanjali in his Yoga-Sūtra. This Sanskrit text is composed of just under 200 aphoristic statements, which have been commented on over and over again through the centuries. Sooner or later all serious Yoga students discover this work and have to grapple with its terse statements. The word *sūtra* (which is related to Latin suture) means literally "thread." Here it conveys a thread of memory, an aid to memorization for students eager to retain Patanjali's knowledge and wisdom.

The *Yoga-Sūtra* was probably written sometime in the second century A.D. The earliest available Sanskrit commentary on it is the *Yoga-Bhāshya* ("Speech on Yoga") attributed to Vyāsa. It was authored in the fifth century A.D. and furnishes fundamental explanations of Patanjali's often cryptic statements.

Beyond a few legends, nothing is known about either Patanjali or Vyāsa. This is a problem with most ancient Yoga adepts and even with many more recent ones. Often all we have are their teachings, but this is of course more important than any historical information we could dig up about their personal lives.

Patanjali, who is by the way often wrongly called the "father of Yoga," believed that each individual is a composite of matter (Prakriti) and spirit (Purusha). He understood the process of Yoga to bring about their separation, thereby restoring the spirit in its absolute purity. His formulation is generally characterized as philosophical dualism. This is an important point because most of India's philosophical systems favor one or the other kind of nondualism: The countless aspects or forms of the empirical world are in the last analysis the same "thing"—pure formless but conscious existence.

POSTCLASSICAL YOGA

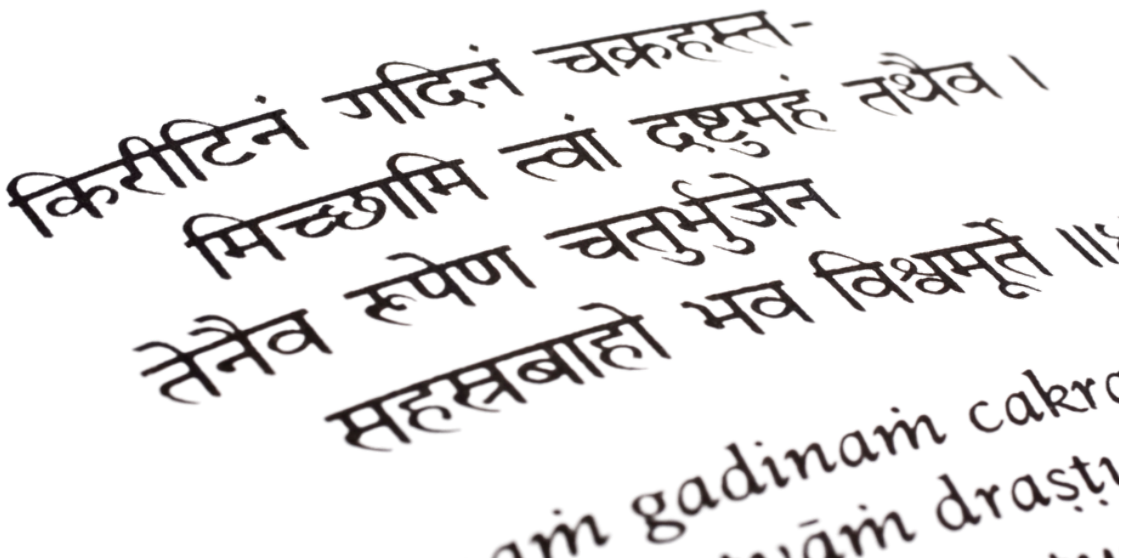
This is again a very comprehensive category, which refers to all those many types and schools of Yoga that have sprung up in the period after Patanjali's Yoga-Sūtra and that are independent of this seminal work. In contrast to classical Yoga, postclassical Yoga affirms the ultimate unity of everything. This is the core teaching of Vedânta, the philosophical system based on the teachings of the Upanishads.

In a way, the dualism of classical Yoga can be seen as a brief but powerful interlude in a stream of nondualist teachings going back to ancient Vedic times. According to these teachings, you, we, and everyone or everything else is an aspect or expression of one and the same reality. In Sanskrit that singular reality is called brahman (meaning "that which has grown expansive") or âtman (the transcendental Self as opposed to the limited ego-self).

A few centuries after Patanjali, the evolution of Yoga took an interesting turn. Now some great adepts were beginning to probe the hidden potential of the body. Previous generations of yogis and yoginis had paid no particular attention to the body. They had been more interested in contemplation to the point where they could exit the body consciously. Their goal had been to leave the world behind and merge with the formless reality, the spirit.

Under the influence of alchemy—the spiritual forerunner of chemistry—the new breed of Yoga masters created a system of practices designed to rejuvenate the body and prolong its life. They regarded the body as a temple of the immortal spirit, not merely as a container to be discarded at the first opportunity. They even explored through advanced yogic techniques the possibility of energizing the physical body to such a degree that its biochemistry is changed and even its basic matter is reorganized to render it immortal.

This preoccupation of theirs led to the creation of Hatha-Yoga, an amateur version of which is today widely practiced throughout the world. It also led to the various branches and schools of Tantra-Yoga, of which Hatha-Yoga is just one approach.



MODERN YOGA

The history of modern Yoga is widely thought to begin with the Parliament of Religions held in Chicago in 1893. It was at that congress that the young Swami Vivekananda—swami (svāmin) means “master”—made a big and lasting impression on the American public. At the behest of his teacher, the saintly Ramakrishna, he had found his way to the States where he didn’t know a soul. Thanks to some well-wishers who recognized the inner greatness of this adept of Jnāna-Yoga (the Yoga of discernment), he was invited to the Parliament and ended up being its most popular diplomat. In the following years, he traveled widely attracting many students to Yoga and Vedânta. His various books on Yoga are still useful and enjoyable to read.

Before Swami Vivekananda a few other Yoga masters had crossed the ocean to visit Europe, but their influence had remained local and ephemeral. Vivekananda’s immense success opened a sluice gate for other adepts from India, and the stream of Eastern gurus has not ceased.

After Swami Vivekananda, the most popular teacher in the early years of the Western Yoga movement was Paramahansa Yogananda, who arrived in Boston in 1920. Five years later, he established the Self-Realization Fellowship, which still has its headquarters in Los Angeles. Although he left his body (as yogins call it) in 1952 at the age of fifty-nine, he continues to have a worldwide following. His Autobiography of a Yogi makes for fascinating reading, but be prepared to suspend any materialistic bias you may have! As with some other yogis and Christian or Muslim saints, after his death, Yogananda’s body showed no signs of decay for a full twenty days.

Of more limited appeal was Swami Rama Tirtha, a former mathematics teacher who preferred spiritual life to academia and who came to the United States in 1902 and founded a retreat center on Mount Shasta in California. He stayed for only two years and drowned in the Ganges (Ganga) River in 1906 at the young age of thirty-three. Some of his inspirational talks were gathered into the five volumes of In Woods of God-Realization, which are still worth dipping into.

In 1919, Yogendra Mastamani arrived in Long Island and for nearly three years demonstrated to astounded Americans the power and elegance of Hatha Yoga. Before returning to India, he founded the American branch of Kaivalyadhama, an Indian organization created by the late Swami Kuvalayananda, which has contributed greatly to the scientific study of Yoga.

A very popular figure for several decades after the 1920s was Ramacharaka, whose books can still be found in used bookstores. What few readers know, however, is that this Ramacharaka was apparently not an actual person. The name was the pseudonym of two people—William Walker Atkinson, who had left his law practice in Chicago to practice Yoga, and his teacher Baba Bharata.

Paul Brunton, a former journalist, and editor, burst on the scene of Yoga in 1934 with his book A Search in Secret India, which introduced the great sage Ramana Maharshi to Western seekers. Many more works flowed from his pen over the phone the following eighteen years, until the publication of The Spiritual Crisis of Man. Then, in the 1980s, his notebooks were published posthumously in sixteen volumes—a treasure trove for serious Yoga students.

From the early 1930s until his death in 1986, Jiddu Krishnamurti delighted or perplexed thousands of philosophically minded Westerners with his eloquent talks. He had been groomed by the Theosophical Society as the coming world leader but had rejected this mission, which surely is too big and burdensome for any one person, however great. He demonstrated the wisdom of Jnāna-Yoga (the Yoga of discernment), and drew large crowds of listeners and readers. Among his close circle of friends were the likes of Aldous Huxley, Christopher Isherwood, Charles Chaplin, and Greta Garbo. Bernard Shaw described Krishnamurti as the most beautiful human being he ever saw.

Yoga, in the form of Hatha-Yoga, entered mainstream America when the Russian-born yoginī Indra Devi, who has been called the “First Lady of Yoga,” opened her Yoga studio in Hollywood in 1947. She taught stars like Gloria Swanson, Jennifer Jones, and Robert Ryan, and trained hundreds of teachers. Now in her nineties and living in Buenos Aires, she is still an influential voice for Yoga.

In the 1950s, one of the most prominent Yoga teachers was Selvarajan Yesudian whose book Sport and Yoga has been translated into fourteen or so languages, with more than 500,000 copies sold. Today, as we mentioned before, many athletes have adopted yogic exercises into their training program because . . . it works. Among them are the Chicago Bulls. Just picture these champion basketball players stretching out on extra-long Yoga mats under the watchful eye of Yoga teacher Paula Kout! In the early 1950s, Shri Yogendra of the Yoga Institute of Santa Cruz in India visited the United States. He pioneered medical research on Yoga as early as 1918, and his son Jayadev Yogendra is continuing his valuable work, which demonstrates the efficacy of Yoga as a therapeutic tool.

In 1961, Richard Hittleman brought Hatha-Yoga to American television, and his book The Twenty-Eight-Day Yoga Plan sold millions of copies. In the mid-1960s, the Western Yoga movement received a big boost through Maharishi Mahesh Yogi, largely because of his brief association with the Beatles. He popularized yogic contemplation in the form of Transcendental Meditation (TM), which still has tens of thousands of practitioners around the world. TM practitioners also introduced meditation and Yoga into the corporate world. It, moreover, stimulated medical research on Yoga at various American universities.

In 1965, the then sixty-nine-year-old Shrila Prabhupada arrived in New York with a suitcase full of books and $8 in his pockets. Six years later he founded the International Society for Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON), and by the time of his death in 1977, he had created a worldwide spiritual movement based on Bhakti Yoga (the Yoga of devotion).

Also in the 1960s and 1970s, many swamis trained by the Himalayan master Swami Sivananda, a former physician who became a doctor of the soul, opened their schools in Europe and the two Americas. Most of them are still active today, and among them are Swami Vishnudevananda (author of the widely read Complete Illustrated Book of Yoga), Swami Satchitananda (well-known to Woodstock participants), Swami Sivananda Radha (a woman-swami who pioneered the link between Yoga spirituality and psychology), Swami Satyananda (about whom we will say more shortly), and Swami Chidananda (a saintly figure who directed the Sivananda Ashram in Rishikesh, India). The last-mentioned master's best-known American student is the gentle Lilias Folan, made famous by her PBS television series Lilias, Yoga & You, broadcast between 1970 and 1979.

In 1969, Yogi Bhajan caused an uproar among the traditional Sikh community (an offshoot of Hinduism) when he broke with tradition and began to teach Kundalini Yoga to his Western students. Today his Healthy, Happy, Holy Organization—better known as 3HO—has more than 200 centers around the world.

A more controversial but wildly popular guru in the 1970 and 1980s was Bhagavan Rajneesh (now known as Osho), whose followers constantly made the headlines for their sexual orgies and other excesses. Rajneesh, a former philosophy professor, drew his teachings from authentic Yoga sources, mixed with his own personal experiences. His numerous books line the shelves of many second-hand bookstores. Rajneesh allowed his students to act out their repressed fantasies, notably of the sexual variety, in the hope that this would free them up for the deeper processes of Yoga. Many of them, however, got trapped in a mystically tinged hedonism, which proves the common-sense rule that too much of a good thing can be bad for you. Even though many of his disciples felt bitterly disappointed by him and the sad events surrounding his organization in the years immediately preceding his death in 1990, just as many still regard him as a genuine Yoga master. His life illustrates that Yoga adepts come in all shapes and sizes and that, to coin a phrase, one person's guru is another person's *uru*. (The Sanskrit word *uru* denotes "empty space.") Another maxim that applies here is caveat emptor, "buyer beware."

Other renowned modern Yoga adepts of Indian origin are Sri Aurobindo (the father of Integral Yoga), Ramana Maharshi (an unparalleled master of Jnana-Yoga), Papa Ramdas (who lived and breathed Mantra-Yoga, the Yoga of transformative sound), Swami Nityananda (a miracle-working master of Siddha-Yoga), and his disciple Swami Muktananda (a powerful yogi who put Siddha-Yoga, which is a Tantric Yoga, on the map for Western seekers). All these teachers are no longer among us.

The great exponent in modern times of Hatha-Yoga was Sri Krishnamacharya, who died in 1989 at the ripe old age of 101. He practiced and taught the Viniyoga system of Hatha-Yoga until his last days. His son T. K. V. Desikachar continues his saintly father's teachings and taught Yoga, among others, to the famous Jiddu Krishnamurti. Another well-known student of Sri Krishnamacharya and a master in his own right is Desikachar's uncle B. K. S. Iyengar, who has taught tens of thousands of students, including the world-famous violinist Jehudi Menuhin.

Mention must also be made of Pattabhi Jois and Indra Devi, both of whom studied with Krishnamacharya in their early years and have since then inspired thousands of Westerners.

Of living Yoga masters from India, I can mention Sri Chinmoy and Swami Satyananda (a Tantra master who established the well-known Bihar School of Yoga, has authored numerous books, and has disciples around the world). There are of course many other great Yoga adepts, both well known and more hidden, who represent Yoga in one form or another, but I leave it up to you to discover them.

Until modern times, the overwhelming majority of Yoga practitioners have been men, yogins. But there have also always been great female adepts, yoginīs. Happily, in recent years, a few woman saints—representing Bhakti-Yoga (Yoga of devotion)—have come to the West to bring their gospel of love to open-hearted seekers. Yoga embraces so many diverse approaches that anyone can find a home in it.

An exceptional woman teacher from India who fits none of the yogic stereotypes is Meera Ma ("Mother Meera"). She doesn't teach in words but communicates in silence through her simple presence. Of all places, she has made her home in the middle of a quaint German village in the Black Forest, and every year attracts thousands of people from all over the world.

Since Yoga is not restricted to Hinduism, we may also mention here the Dalai Lama, champion of nonviolence and winner of the Nobel Peace Prize. He is unquestionably one of the truly great yogis of modern Tibet, who, above all, demonstrates that the principles of Yoga can fruitfully be brought not only into a busy daily life but also into the arena of politics. Today Tibetan Buddhism (which is a form of Tantra-Yoga) is extremely popular among Westerners, and there are many *lamas* (spiritual teachers) who are willing to share with sincere seekers the secrets of their hitherto well-guarded tradition.

If you are curious about Westerners who have made a name for themselves as teachers in the modern Yoga movement (understood in the broadest terms), you may want to consult the encyclopedic work The Book of Enlightened Masters by Andrew Rawlinson. His book includes both genuine masters (like the Bulgarian teacher Omraam Mikhaël Aïvanhov on whom I have written a book—The Mystery of Light) and a galaxy of would-be masters.

THE FIVE PERIODS OF YOGA

01

Vedic
(1700 - 600 B.C.E.)

Time of The Vedas and the appearance of sanskrit.

02

Pre-Classical
(600 - 200 B.C.E.)

The rise of dharmic religions. Bhagavad-Gita is written.

03

Classical
(200 B.C.E. - 500 C.E.)

Yoga-Sutras by Patanjali was the first systematic recording of yoga as a practice, yet characterized by meditation, not asana.

04

Post-Classical
(500 - 1800 C.E.)

During this time, teaching yoga evolved from oral tradition to more standardized teachings, such as Hatha and Tantra Yoga.

05

Modern
(1800 - Present Day)

Teachers such as Vivekananda and Yogananda bring yogic ideas to the west. Yoga become synonymous with asana.

HISTORY OF YOGA

Vedic Period

By Linda Sparrowe
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The actual word "yoga" surfaced around 1500 B.C.E., just as the Harappan civilization began to decline. The Harrapans' rather rapid demise was helped along, some scholars believe, by an invasion of Aryan barbarians. These nomadic invaders had no use for the sophisticated urban civilization the Harappans had built and took little time destroying it. They brought with them Brahmanism, a complex religious tradition based on sacrifice and ritual that formed the basis of modern-day Hinduism, and introduced the concept of yoga. The sacred scriptures of Brahmanism, known as the *Vedas*, contain a mixture of incantations and instructions in both poetry and prose. The first three books, *Rig Veda, Sama Veda*, and *Yajur Veda*, were used exclusively by the priestly class of Brahmins; a later, the fourth book called *Atharva Veda* provided householders with spells and incantations for everyday living.

Scholars have a hard time pinpointing the inception of the *Vedas*, but they generally agree that the scriptures date back at least 3,500 years. The word yoga has its first mention in the *Rig Veda*, the oldest of the sacred texts. This Vedic book, a collection of hymns or mantras, defines yoga as "yoking" or "discipline," but offers no accompanying systematic practice. The term yoga turns up again in the *Atharva Veda*, most particularly in the fifteenth book (*Vratya Kanda*). Again it refers only to a means of harnessing or yoking. But this time it's the breath that needs controlling. The *Vratya Kanda* introduces a group of men, the *vratyas*, quite possibly fertility priests, who worshipped Rudra, the god of the wind. Considered horrible outcasts by traditional Brahmins, these *vratyas* composed and performed songs and melodies. They found they could sing their songs a lot better—and probably hold the notes longer—if they practiced what they called pranayama, a type of breath control. This, then, is the very beginning of yoga as we know it, the first mention of physical action as part of a discipline or practice. Roughly 800 years will pass before history yields more information on yoga's development.

Pre-classical Yoga

Little more than a noun and a nascent discipline in the *Vedas*, yoga played a more prominent role in the *Upanishads*, the sacred revelations of ancient Hinduism. The earliest of these teachings date back to at least 800 to 500 B.C.E. The word Upanishads combines the verb "shad," which means to sit, with "upa" meaning near, and "ni" meaning down, which suggests that the only way a student could learn the truths hidden in these revelations was to sit at the foot of his guru or teacher. The *Upanishads* contained little that we would call yoga asana practice. Instead, yoga referred in a more general way to a discipline used or path taken to achieve liberation from suffering. Two yoga disciplines in particular gained prominence during this time: *karma yoga*, the path of action or ritual, and *jnana yoga*, the path of knowledge or intense study of scripture. Both paths led to liberation or enlightenment.

The secret teachings of the *Upanishads* differ in important ways from their Vedic parent texts. The *Vedas* taught the fine art of sacrifice—external offerings to the gods in exchange for a peaceful and fruitful life. This form of *karma yoga* included specific rituals and sacrifices humans had to perform in order to appease the gods and be free from suffering. The *Upanishads* also espoused sacrifice as a means to liberation but chose an internal, more mystical expression of that sacrifice. Gurus taught that the Self or ego (not an animal or crops) must be sacrificed in order to attain liberation. The means to do that, these revelations showed, came not through action or ritual, but through knowledge and wisdom (*jnana yoga*). The *Upanishads*, as a whole, concentrated on these basic truths:

- Your true essence (the Self with a capital "S") is the same as the essence of the universe or brahman. That essence—what we might think of as the soul—is called *Atman*.
- Everyone is subject to birth, death, and rebirth.
- Your actions in this life determine the nature of your rebirth (the doctrine of karma). This understanding of karma says that if you perform good deeds throughout your life, you'll be reborn into the womb of a woman from a high caste; if you do evil, you're likely to find yourself in the lowly womb of a pig, or a dog, or, perhaps worse, an outcast.
- You can reverse the effects of bad karma through specific spiritual practices (i.e., internal sacrifices) like meditation and renunciation. Renunciation allows you to offer up the fruits of your actions and to renounce any actions fueled by desire or passion. In much later *Upanishads*, yoga became known as the path of renunciation (*samnyasa*).

One of the earliest Upanishads to teach specific yoga meditation practices was the Maitrayaniya Upanishad from the second or third century B.C.E. This Upanishad defined yoga as a means of binding the breath and the mind using the syllable Om.

According to its author, "The oneness of the breath and mind, and likewise of the senses, and the relinquishment of all conditions of existence—this is designated as yoga." The *Maitrayaniya* took the concept of yoga a step further by presenting an actual method or discipline for joining or yoking the universal brahman with the Atman within all beings. This six-fold yoga path includes controlling the breath (*pranayama*), withdrawing the senses (*pratyahara*), meditation (*dhyana*), concentration (*dharana*), contemplation (*tarka*), and absorption (*samadhi*). Elements of this six-fold path expanded somewhat and would resurface in the second century C.E., in Patanjali's *Yoga Sutra*.

The vibrational power of sound, as exemplified in the primordial word Om, came to signify the inner meaning of a yogi's actions, and speech-enabled the yogi to express that meaning. Today, as in the days of the *Upanishads*, the guru's words impart wisdom to his students and, for the more devotionally adept, chanting the name of a god or goddess remains a powerful vehicle for transformation.

The Bhagavad Gita

The most famous—and most beloved—of all yoga texts, the *Bhagavad Gita* ("The Lord's Song") has its roots in the mystical, revelatory literature of the *Upanishads*. No one knows for sure how old this scripture is—it quite possibly dates from the third century B.C.E.—but we do know that it provides the most comprehensive description of yoga at that time. Later folded into the canon of the Mahabharata, India's well-known epic tale, the Gita brought together moral teachings and mystical lore as Lord Krishna instructed his pupil Arjuna on the ways of the world. While the Maitrayaniya Upanishad outlined a six-fold path to liberation, the *Gita* advocated a three-pronged approach: karma yoga, the path of service; jnana yoga, the path of wisdom or knowledge; and *bhakti yoga*, the path of devotion.

In the Bhagavad Gita, jnana yoga signified meditation, or the path of wisdom, much as it did in the *Upanishads*. Using this type of yoga, a practitioner would try to discriminate between real and unreal, in an attempt to separate the Self from the non-Self. Karma yoga of the *Gita* was still a yogi's path of action, what Krishna called Arjuna's *sva-dharma*. As a warrior, Arjuna's obligation (his dharma) is to fight against the forces of evil, no matter what. And if he were to decide he doesn't like fighting, could he sell his wares in the marketplace instead? He can't, Krishna tells him. He's not a member of the merchant class, and he has no right to perform someone else's duties. In fact, doing one's duty poorly accumulates better karma than doing someone else's well. What if Arjuna knows the battle he's engaged in is wrong? It doesn't matter, says Krishna. The outcome of the battle makes no difference; it's Arjuna's duty to fight no matter what. He must practice what the *Gita* called *buddhi yoga*.

Buddhi yoga, the *Bhagavad Gita*'s melding of karma (action) and jnana (knowledge) yoga principles, taught that the yogi must never be attached to the outcome of his actions. What mattered was not whether Arjuna won or lost in battle, only that he perform his duty (his *sva-dharma*) and then offer up the fruits of his actions to Krishna, his Lord. In this way, Arjuna's sva-dharma became a form of internal sacrifice.

The *Gita* dedicated most of its later chapters to bhakti yoga, the path of devotion, most particularly devotion to Krishna himself. While a yogi could achieve liberation through what the *Gita* called "disinterested action," he attained an even higher state of awakening by worshipping Krishna.

The *Upanishads,* the concept of universal consciousness, or brahman, developed out of the metaphysical teachings of the *Upanishads*. Yoga has lots of names for it: Atman, the transcendental Self, the Divine, *isvara*, *Purusha*, pure awareness, the seer, the witness, and the knower are but a few of the more popular ones. At this point in preclassical yoga, everything resided within this consciousness and nothing existed outside of it. It was both the seer and the seen, and even the act of seeing. Purusha, the *Upanishads* taught, was all-knowing, pure, male, and infinite. Some schools of yoga and Hindu philosophy taught that this universal consciousness manifested itself in everything, beginning with the grossest, most visible realm of the five *bhutas* (air, fire, water, earth, and ether) and moving into the subtlest realm of the soul or Atman.

Toward the middle of the preclassical period, a rather radical metaphysical school called Samkhya surfaced. Although not a school of yogic thought, per se, this parallel tradition—which existed anywhere between 400 and 200 B.C.E. and owed its teachings to an obscure sage named Kapila—developed the basis for a more modern yogic worldview. What made Samkhya so radical? Certainly not its tenet that yogis must renounce the world in order to transcend it and be relieved of their suffering.

The concept of *samnyasa* (renunciation) is as ancient as the earliest *Upanishads*. By the time Samkhya elevated this well-established concept, mainstream yoga philosophy felt that renunciation alone was not enough. Yogis had to practice karma yoga (the path of action) and jnana yoga (knowledge or meditation) to achieve true liberation. Samkhya became radical when it taught that the visible world was not a manifestation of the Divine. According to Kapila, nature and, in fact, all of creation were separate and distinct from the universal consciousness, although the manifest world could be illuminated by *Purusha*.

Suffering, according to the Samkhya tradition, occurred when the yogi became attached to things that were not the Self, and when he mistakenly identified those things with pure consciousness (*Purusha*). Although this dualistic, rather heretical teaching failed the test of time, the Samkhya tradition created a sophisticated cosmology that explains the difference between the seer (*Purusha*) and that which is seen. Subsequent schools of yoga rejected the Samkhyan's dualistic view of suffering, but borrowed its larger world view, which goes something like this:

There are two separate forms of reality or existence—Purusha (the pure, transcendental spirit, which is male) and Prakriti (matter or nature, which is female). Purusha is all-knowing, without beginning and without end. It has no characteristics and is completely immobile. It simply exists as pure consciousness. It is the seer. Prakriti, on the other hand, is in constant motion, creative, active, distinct, but unconscious. She is all that is seen. She has, in fact, created everything in the universe by manifesting herself in three ways: *sattva*, *rajas*, and *tamas*. These three manifestations of her nature are called *gunas*. They exist simultaneously, but in varying degrees of prominence, in everything in the cosmos. Prakriti dynamically creates these phenomena; Purusha passively illuminates them.

Sattva – the *guna* of the mind and the cognitive senses (eyes, ears, nose, tongue, and skin). The mind coordinates all biological and psychic activities and the cognitive senses keep us connected to the external world.

Rajas – the guna of gross motor responses and physical experience. When this guna predominates, the senses of yearning—the voice, hands, feet, anus, and genitals - become active. Rajas makes physical experience possible and control the activity of the body.

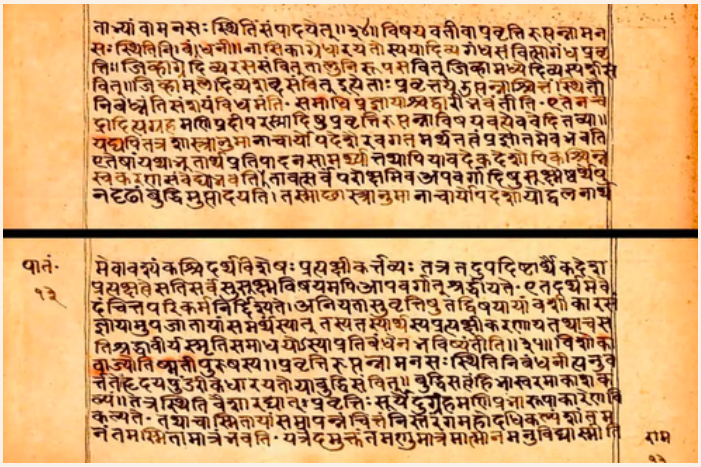
Tamas – the guna of darkness and inertia. When this guna predominates, the five subtle elements become active —these are the potential of sight, sound, smell, taste, and touch, which give rise to the structure of existence.

In the early Samkhya system, the gunas were neutral manifestations of Prakriti; only later did they become aligned with certain qualities. The *Bhagavad Gita* also taught that the gunas came from nature, but believed that their existence bound humans to a particular body. Sattva, for example, denoted goodness and pure essence. The *Bhagavad Gita* taught that a sattvic nature was illuminating and "immaculate." The downside of having a sattvic nature was that a yogi could too easily become attached to the joyful feelings it produced. Being rajasic, in the *Gita*, meant he was bound by and attached to action. Rajas energy is dynamic, and passionate. Later *Upanishads* translated rajas to mean greed, lustfulness, desire, possessiveness, passion and clinging to material goods. Tamas became known as an obstacle that would bind a yogi to a life of sloth, heedlessness, and despondency. Its energy is heavy, slow, and thick. These gunas appear later on in Patanjali's *Yoga Sutra*.

Samkyhan philosophers believed that the only way out of this erroneous attachment to objects and desires was for the yogi to renounce the world completely. Through renunciation, the yogi could experience universal consciousness (Purusha) and forswear the natural world.

CLASSICAL YOGA

Patanjali's *Yoga Sutra*



The most famous proponent of the Samkhya world view was an enigmatic philosopher/writer known only as Patanjali. Nearly every yoga teacher today is familiar with his treatise, the *Yoga Sutra*, which is considered to be the first systematic presentation of yoga, and reveres its author as the father of modern yoga. Actually, no one really knows who Patanjali was, although speculation varies widely. Was he a simple grammarian, a teacher of Samkhya philosophy, or an incarnation of Shesha, the thousand-headed ruler of serpents? Whoever else he was and whatever else he did, Patanjali clearly succeeded in codifying the concepts of an ancient, oral tradition. His collection of 195 sutras (aphorisms or "terse statements") compiled most probably in the second-century c.e., provides the first practical treatise on daily living, beginning with how to conduct oneself in society and culminating in the act of final liberation or enlightenment. Because Patanjali believed one could attain final liberation only with the help of a guru, these aphorisms are not really a self-help guide. They exist to assist the guru in his teachings.

Like the followers of Samkhya before him, Patanjali embraced a dualistic view of existence. On the one hand, he taught, there is Purusha, the all-present, all-knowing ethereal consciousness, made up of countless Atmans, who watch as the cosmos unfolds before them. Male, formless and unmanifest, Purusha attaches to nothing; immobile yet pervasive, he simply sees all and knows all. Prakriti, on the other hand, is nature incarnate. Female, visible, and dynamic, Prakriti constantly moves, creating and changing as she goes. She is all that is manifest in the world. Existing only to serve Purusha, Prakriti is unconscious and insentient. Nature exists, according to Patanjali and the Samkhyan philosophers, through a complex interplay among the three gunas — sattva, rajas, and tamas—which are visible aspects of her character. Much like in the *Bhagavad Gita*, Patanjali aligned these gunas with specific characteristics in humans.

When the element sattva presents itself, according to this philosophy, the energy is light, clear, and joyous; a predominance of rajas produces passionate feelings, desire, and even greed, as one becomes attached to worldly goods; when tamas gets the upper hand, it brings energy that is slow, heavy, and thick, and can bind a person to a life of sloth and despondency.

Like the Samkhya philosophers, Patanjali believed suffering resulted when humans become attached to external phenomena, when they hold on to the fruits of their actions or when their desires (all the shoulds, wants, and needs in life) pull them away from their connection to a higher consciousness. Patanjali thought that conflict among the three gunas, each vying for dominance, was at the heart of human suffering. Sattva may bring feelings of joyfulness, he reasoned, but being attached to those feelings is no better than holding on to the greed of rajas or being stuck in the despondency of tamas. Much like the *Bhagavad Gita*—and diametrically opposed to the renunciation espoused in Samkhya—Patanjali wrote that only hard work (karma yoga) and deep meditation (*jnana yoga*) could relieve human suffering and lead to liberation. In fact, only through strict adherence to his eight-limbed path of yoga (*ashtanga yoga*) could a yogi tame the gunas and bring them back into balance, as they existed in primordial nature. Ultimately, said Patanjali, by releasing attachments to the natural world, a yogi could allow the transcendental quality of Purusha to shine through his true Self.

Although yogis eventually rejected Patanjali's dualism entirely, they continued to use and expand upon his eight-limbed yoga path. This combination of practices still serves as a blueprint for living in the world and as a means of attaining enlightenment, although modern-day teachers no longer believe students must master the limbs in succession.

Patanjali's *Kriya Yoga*

Although he is best known as the chronicler of the eight-limbed yoga path, Patanjali also presented a version of *kriya yoga*, the path of transmutative action (i.e., the act of changing into a higher form) in his *Yoga Sutra*. Kriya yoga can best be described as a form of internal karma yoga. That is, by perfecting the niyamas or self-disciplines of Patanjali's eight-limbed path, particularly tapas (austerity), svadhyaya (self-study), and isvara pranidhana (devotion to the Lord), a yogi erases *samskara* (subliminal activators) from his subconscious. Samskara are like karma scars that result from good or bad behavior. They are indelible memories, imprinted on the subconscious, that propel the conscious mind to act; they are what dictate a person's birth, life experiences, and death. These activators cause the constant chatter or fluctuations in the mind that separates a person from Purusha and make it impossible for him to experience it. An individual has good kinds of samskara and bad kinds, according to the *Yoga Sutra*. The bad kind keep the conscious mind actively seeking experience outside itself, regardless of whether that experience is pleasurable or painful. The good kind stop the conscious mind from seeking and attaching itself to external objects and senses. The resultant cessation (*nirodhah*) of vritti (fluctuations) and samskara brings true liberation.

Post-Classical Era of Yoga

Patanjali's Yoga Sutra defined yoga practice in the early part of the first millennium, and his eight-limbed millennium and his eight-limbed path became a central aspect of the yoga systems that followed. The Yoga Sutra, however, was firmly rooted in the dualism of Samkhya philosophy, a school of thought that existed alongside the non-dualistic Vedic and *Gita* traditions without ever supplanting them. Putting a precise date on the decline of classical yoga, as represented by Patanjali, and the subsequent start of the post-classical period is impossible because the boundaries separating schools of yogic thought were remarkably fluid. Certain concepts and tenets from Patanjali and the early *Upanishads* continue unchanged or only slightly modified throughout the post-classical period as part of what might be called mainstream yoga. Upstart schools such as tantra or hatha yoga, which took exception to or radically departed from many of these older tenets, expanded the practice of yoga in often radical ways. The one thing both mainstream and new-age post-classical philosophers had in common was their rejection of Patanjali's dualistic world view. That marked the close of one era and the beginning of a new one.

Understanding the concepts of duality (*dvaita*) and nonduality (*advaita*) is no easy task, especially since they seem to have a lot in common. Both schools of thought believed in a universal consciousness that is formless, omnipresent, and immortal. Judeo-Christians call this the soul; for Patanjali it was Purusha, and the nondualistic tradition of Advaita Vedanta called it Atman or Self. Although this Atman resides in each one of us, he (Purusha may be formless, but he's still considered to be male) cannot be understood by the senses—he can't be seen, heard, smelled, touched, or tasted. Both schools understood that humans suffer when they become disconnected from this higher Self, and both believed that liberation comes when humans realize their true, transcendental Self.

For the dualist in pre-classical and classical yoga, this suffering occurred when someone held onto and became subsumed by everything that was not the Self—in other words, when he came to believe that all he did, all his relationships, actions, feelings, thoughts, or motives made up his true Self. A person could free himself from suffering only when he let go of his attachments to such things and realized—not with the intellect, but with the heart—that the transcendental Self resided within and that the Self was the ultimate reality. For the nondualist in pre- and post-classical yoga, suffering began when an individual tried to make a distinction between Self and no-Self; when he failed to understand that he was a small part of something much larger than himself; when he forgot that everything he did, all that he sensed, was simply a manifestation of the transcendental Atman or Purusha. A nondualist released himself from suffering when he came to understand that his Self was not separate, but an integral part of the transcendental Self or Atman. Today, it might be easy to understand the difference between these philosophies if we paraphrase Shakespeare.

For the dualist, "all the world's a stage" and the play Prakriti (nature, primordial matter) puts on is for the benefit of Purusha (universal consciousness, transcendental Self). The story is make-believe; the parts the actors play are not the same as the lives they lead; and the roles they take on are separate from who they really are. Obviously, to mistake the action on stage for real life would be confusing at best; knowing that the actor who plays Hamlet is in fact not Hamlet makes a world of difference.

The world's stage, for the nondualist, looks quite different. The play, while different than real life, is not separate from it. The play can't exist without the actors, who are real people, but playacting is only one aspect of who the actors are. The actors are real people; the roles they play, the script, the music are all contained within real life. Anyone who views the play as its own reality, separate from everything else, will get terribly confused.

It's somewhat easier to see the Divine in the mundane when you take the nondualistic view of reality because the Divine is everywhere and in everything. When Atman or Purusha is separate, how can anyone glimpse its luminous nature in everyday life? Patanjali never really answered that question, but later commentators explained that by practicing yoga (the eight-limbed path), the yogi attains the highest level of existence. At this point, Prakriti becomes so transparent and illuminating (sattvic) that Purusha, the transcendental Self, shines through and reveals himself. The path toward true liberation lies in experiencing (not just believing) the universe as one. This combination of jnana yoga (yoga of wisdom and knowledge) and karma yoga (yoga of taking action) is similar to the ideas espoused in the *Bhagavad Gita*.

History of Tantra Yoga

Tantra emerged early in the post-classical period, around the fourth-century C.E., but didn't reach its full flowering until 500 to 600 years later. This school represents a rather radical departure for yoga philosophy. In what could only have been understood as heresy, tantra rejected the *Vedas* (the most sacred texts of Hinduism since at least 1500 B.C.E.) as irrelevant. It refuted the notion that liberation could be attained only through rigorous asceticism and meditation, and it dismissed the Samkhyan precept that a yogi must renounce the world in order to free himself from it. Tantra also eschewed karma yoga (the path of action or service), choosing instead to focus on devotion (bhakti), most particularly worship of the Goddess. In teaching about the causes of suffering and the path to liberation, tantra shares common ground with its ancestors. Like the nondualistic authors of the early Upanishads, tantric yogis believed that human suffering comes from the illusion of opposites, from the mistaken notion that the Self is somehow separate from the objects it desires. Being good nondualists, tantrikas (tantric yogis) see all possible sets of opposites, all dualities (good and evil, hot and cold, hard and soft, male and female) contained within the universal consciousness. The only way a yogi can liberate himself from suffering, according to tantra, is to unite all the opposites or dualities in his own body. Like Patanjali, tantrikas believe in the need to have a strong, pure physical body.

While Patanjali may have acknowledged the need to strengthen and purify the body, he ultimately believed that the body was defiled and that a truly iberated yogi would shun the company of others for fear of becoming contaminated. Tantrika, on the other hand, celebrated the physical body, which they considered

to be a sacred temple of the Divine, as a means to conquer death.

The body became the vehicle for attaining liberation. In tantric yoga, the universal consciousness, which earlier philosophers called Purusha, became Shiva and resided within the body. The principle of nature or creation called Prakriti in earlier yogic thought became shakti and lived at the base of the spine. The ultimate unity—the male energy of Shiva with the feminine principle of shakti—took place internally and led to final liberation or samadhi. Unlike the more traditional nondualists, however, tantrikas believed that the whole world was not an illusion, but a manifestation of the Divine and that all experience brought the practitioner closer to his or her own divinity. Most Westerners equate tantra with kinky sex practices, and in one particular school of tantra uniting the male energy of Shiva with the feminine principle of shakti actually does lead to unusual sexual positions and wild orgiastic practices. The *vamamarga*, or left-handed path of tantra, employed traditionally forbidden pleasures, including sexual intercourse, to achieve samadhi.

After all, they reasoned, how can an individual know what to transcend if he doesn't experience it first? The more conservative, right-handed tantrikas, on the other hand, weren't quite so literal. In fact *vamamarga* practices horrified them. They considered these practices dangerous and preferred more symbolic means of uniting male and female energies. The right-handed tantrikas relied on arduous practices of asana, pranayama, mudras, and bandhas to awaken the female energy (shakti), draw it up through the body, and unite it with the male Shiva at the crown of the head. Both types of tantra respected women far more than their yogic predecessors and most of their contemporaries and revered the feminine deity (Shakti) as the necessary, active

Not everything in tantra broke with yogic tradition. Before a yogi could even begin tantric practices, he had to adhere strictly to the yamas and niyamas (ethical standards and moral disciplines) and the asanas and pranayamas as outlined in Patanjali's eight-limbed path in the Yoga Sutra. From there, the adept learned to concentrate (pratyahara) on a single point (*ekagraha*); for a tantrika, this point was an icon of a deity. Once he mastered pratyahara, he was ready to study visualization, which included feeling the deity's presence and summoning the sacred force of the deity in order to experience its divinity.

Similarly, tantra's use of mantras (sacred sounds) is as old as the Rig Veda, but tantrikas employed these sounds in a very different way. Each letter of the mantra (given to the student by his guru) corresponded to a place in the body and each place in the body represented a force in the universe. By chanting the mantra, the yogi could awaken the body and its corresponding universal forces. In order to practice this form of mantra meditation, the body must be pure and strong and the mind clear and alert.

Tantric yogis liked to use visual aids, such as mandalas, in their meditations. Generally made of wood, paper, or cloth, tantric mandalas were drawings of circles and geometric designs. Regardless of how simple or complex these drawings were, they always contained a seed or bindu at the center, which represented the union of the cosmos and the mind; concentric circles, which represented the various levels of existence; and a square "fence" around the circles, with open gates, to protect the sacred space. Ultimately, by meditating and visualizing, the tantrika entered into the mandala and realized that the unity of all things resided in him and that there was no separation between him and the Divine.

Hatha Yoga

Hatha yoga, out of which came the physical postures the Western world now embraces, first appeared in the ninth or tenth century. Despite its rather detailed and complex philosophic underpinnings, it was little more than a small and somewhat radical sect during the post-classical period. In fact, among some Hindus of the period, hatha yoga had the reputation of being nothing short of heretical in its focus on the physical and in its fascination with magical powers. Hatha yoga's principles arose from tantra, and incorporated elements of Buddhism, alchemy, and Shaivism (worship of the transcendental Shiva).

Like tantrikas, hatha yogis believed that creating polarities (male vs. female, hot vs. cold, happy vs. sad) caused suffering and brought about disease, delusion, and pain. The very name hatha yoga, a combination of "ha," meaning sun, and "tha," meaning moon, denotes the union of opposites. Hatha also means a force or determined effort, and yoga, of course, translates as yoke or joining together. Therefore, hatha yoga implies that it takes a lot of strength, discipline, and effort to unify opposing forces and to bring together the body and the mind. The biggest obstacles to practice for the hatha yogi include greed, hatred, delusion, egoism, and attachment.

Interested less in the sexual union of opposites than tantrikas, hatha yogis strove to transform the physical body into the subtle, divine body and thereby attain enlightenment. The transformed body was said to be impervious to disease, void of any defects, eternally youthful, and the bearer of paranormal, magical powers. Before hatha yoga students could ever hope to accomplish such transformation, however, they had to learn the intricate physiology of the body, including the muscles, organs, chakras (energy channels), and tissues, and the gods that govern each. Hatha yogis also had to perform intense purification rituals before they could begin asana and pranayama practices. As with all yoga practices at the time, yoga students received instruction from their gurus.

Even though hatha yoga remained a somewhat marginal sect during the post-classical period, it produced an impressive number of treatises and prescriptive manuals. The first and primary text was written by a yogi named Goraksha, the person most often deemed the father of hatha yoga.

Like most early gurus, Goraksha was a rather elusive figure. Quite possibly a member of the weaver caste in the Punjab, he probably lived in the ninth or tenth-century c.e., although later hatha yoga texts also place him in the twelfth or thirteenth century.

Goraksha founded the Natha sect of yogis and was considered by some to be a

miracle worker, saint, and revered teacher. His earliest writing, the Siddha Siddhanta Paddhati, introduces several important elements of hatha yoga, including the idea that the physical body is only one level of embodiment. There are five others, moving from the grossest (garbha or physical) body to the subtlest (para or transcendental) body. He also delineates nine energy channels or chakras, three signs or lakshya (literally, visions), and 16 props or adhara, upon which a yogi focuses attention (the ankle, the thumb, the thighs, the navel, etc.).

Svatmarama Yogin, who called himself a disciple of Goraksha (even though he came a few centuries later), wrote a second treatise, the Hatha Yoga Pradipika, probably during the mid-fourteenth century. This text describes sixteen postures, most of which are variations of Padmasana (the cross-legged Lotus pose), several purification rituals, eight pranayama techniques (primarily to retain the breath), and ten seals (mudras) with specific bandhas, or locks to constrict the flow of prana or life force. As Svatmarama explained, before the mind can even hope to control the senses, the breath must neutralize the mind. Steady, rhythmic breathing calms the mind, freeing it from external distractions; a calm mind in turn reins in the senses. Although decidedly nondualistic in nature, Svatmarama's six-limbed yoga path was exclusively for the attainment of samadhi through the practice of raja yoga (the yoga of Patanjali).

The Gheranda Samhita, a late-seventeenth-century manual based on the Hatha Yoga Pradipika, offers seven niyamas, or disciplines necessary for yoga practice: cleanliness, firmness, stability, constancy, lightness, perception, and nondefilement. The manual's author, the sage Gheranda, prescribes 32 asanas and 25 mudras. He also outlines an intricate purification system. But despite this emphasis on the physical body, Gheranda believed that a yogi attains liberation or ecstasy ultimately through the kindness of his guru.

Perhaps the most comprehensive—and the most democratic—treatise on hatha yoga, the Shiva Samhita may have been written toward the end of the post-classical period, as late as the early eighteenth century. It emphasizes that even a common householder (a common male householder, that is) can practice yoga and reap its benefits—a concept that would have startled earlier proponents of yoga. The Shiva Samhita outlines the intricacies of esoteric physiology, names 84 different asanas—the most wide-ranging list to date—and describes five specific types of prana (or life force), providing explicit techniques to regulate them. Unfortunately, only four of the asanas are described in detail. Just like all hatha yoga philosophy, the Shiva Samhita postulates that performing asanas will cure a yogi of all diseases and bestow upon him magical, superhuman powers.

The Yoga Upanishads

Despite their overriding popularity in the West today, both tantra and hatha yoga were considered radical departures from mainstream yoga, which was far more widespread and popular throughout the post-classical period. This more conservative strain of yoga incorporated much of preclassical yogic thought as well as Patanjali's eight-limbed yoga path, without, of course, his dualistic worldview. Roughly two-thirds of the way through the post-classical period, a group of 21 secret teachings called the Yoga Upanishads surfaced. Most likely written between the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries c.e., these sacred texts elaborated on particular practices of yoga, including a few asanas and some of the pranayama and mudras Western practitioners know today. Their emphasis, decidedly nondualistic in flavor, remained focused on the proper way to achieve liberation. Instructions on how to recite the sound Om show up in several of these texts; others demonstrate an elaborate means of breath control (pranayama); still others teach the student how to use inner sound (hamsa) to transport the self toward liberation.

One of the Yoga Upanishads, Tejo Bindu Upanishad, grafts seven new limbs onto Patanjali's eight-limbed yoga path. To the precepts and disciplines (yamas and niyamas), asana, pranayama, withdrawal (pratyahara), intense concentration (dharana), meditation (dhyana), and liberation (samadhi) of the *Yoga Sutra,* the Tejo Bindu adds mula bandha (root locks), equilibrium, steadiness of vision, *tyaga* (abandonment), mauna (silence), *desha* (place), and *kala* (time). In a similar vein, other Upanishads offer additional yamas, niyamas, and asanas, provide *bhutas* or elements upon which to concentrate in pratyahara, and outline new methods to control the breath. The Tri Shikhi Brahmana Upanishad actually mentions 17 different asanas and details practices for purifying the channels (nadis) of the inner body, and for proper breath control (pranayama).

Much like Patanjali, the authors of the Yoga Upanishads saw many obstacles to practice, which could prevent a yogi from achieving samadhi. One text (the Yoga Tattva Upanishad) lists laziness, boastfulness, and sexual fantasies as impediments to liberation. It deems keeping bad company and becoming attached to the fruits of one's practice (i.e., enjoying the magical powers one attains) equally bad. The author of the Tejo Bindu Upanishad concurs, but can't help adding excessive sweating, absentmindedness, stupor, and being distracted to the list.

Yoga Comes West

The American brand of yoga we love today focuses primarily on the physical poses called asanas and is thus clearly an offshoot of hatha yoga, even though jnana yoga (the path of knowledge) and the raja yoga of Patanjali's *Yoga Sutra* were the first to gain currency in the West. Like Indian yogis, the first Westerners to encounter yoga were more interested in—and fascinated by— methods and practices that took them out of their bodies, transcending the physical to put them in closer touch with the absolute. According to yoga scholar Georg Feuerstein, the Western love affair with all things Eastern began in the third-century b.c.e., once Alexander the Great's conquests opened up Persia and India. Even before that, Plato and Aristotle paid homage to Eastern philosophy in their writings.

Nearly 50 years before yoga landed on American shores, a group of Englishmen formed the Asiatic Society of Bengal (in Calcutta) and took it upon themselves to study all things Indian. Their research and translations included essays on the Vedas, yoga, and the poetry of Shankara (800 c.e.). Society member Sir Charles Wilkins published the first English-language translation of the *Bhagavad Gita* in 1785, his colleague Sir William Jones weighed in with his own translations of the Isha Upanishad and a collection of hymns from the Vedas, and Henry Thomas Colebrooke wrote essays on the Vedas and on yoga, most particularly the Samkhya Karika, Ishvara Krishna's commentary on Samkhya.

The contemplative paths of yoga also resonated with a group of American intellectuals and self-described transcendentalists that included Henry David Thoreau and Ralph Waldo Emerson and that drew inspiration from the *Bhagavad Gita*. Fifty years later, Madame Blavatsky, a Russian immigrant, occultist, and student of ancient India, established the Theosophical Society in New York City and in Europe. Her writings, most particularly Isis Unveiled (1877) and The Secret Doctrine (1888), captivated her audience with the secrets of the ancient Vedas.

By 1893 Americans were sufficiently smitten by yoga exotica to embrace Swami Vivekananda, the first Indian spiritual teacher (and perhaps the first East Indian) they had ever seen. Vivekananda spoke passionately about raja yoga at the first Parliament of World Religions held that year in Chicago, and the crowd went wild. He lectured extensively for another two years before moving on to European cities and then returning to India. When he came back to the United States in 1899, he set up the New York Vedanta Society, a still-thriving community dedicated to four branches of yoga practice: bhakti (devotion), karma (service), jnana (knowledge), and raja (the eight-limbed path of Patanjali's *Yoga Sutra*).

About the same time, the Germans discovered the beauty of the Sanskrit language and the mystery of the Vedas. Although several scholars of the Romantic era welcomed the rich literature of India, Max Muller, comparative religions pioneer, most influenced Vedic scholarship and helped birth the flurry of European translations of ancient Indian texts that continued throughout the nineteenth and into the twentieth century. Among the greatest of these was the work of Johann Wilhelm Hauer, who, according to Feuerstein, was the first to study the vast history of the Vedas. He produced a translation of Patanjali's *Yoga Sutra* as well. Of course the English and the Germans weren't the only Europeans to gravitate toward yoga research. Feuerstein mentions Poul Tuxen, a Dutch scholar, who wrote a history of the yoga tradition in 1911. Twenty years later, Swedish researcher Sigurd Lindquist published two books on yoga, focusing on its psychological aspects, and by the 1940s, the Frenchman Jean Filliozat had added his translations of several works, and Italian scholar Giulio Cesare Evola his own writings on tantra yoga.

Yoga asanas gained a little more prominence in America around the turn of the twentieth century when hatha yoga adherents began to look more seriously at the physical benefits of their practice. Back in India, partly in an attempt to shore up hatha yoga's sagging popularity, Paramahansa Madhavadasaji encouraged local scientists and medical doctors to explore the physiological aspects of asana practice. One of his students, Kuvalayananda, established the first institute devoted solely to such exploration—the Kaivalyadhama Ashram and Research Institute in Pune, India. Madhavadasaji sent another of his adepts, Yogendra Mastamani, to the United States to set up the first American branch of the institute. Mastamani's connections with the Eclectic Physicians and Benedict Lust, the founder of naturopathy, gave yoga a foothold in the burgeoning holistic medicine practice of the day.

Up through the mid-1920s, Americans embraced a steady stream of Indian swamis coming to the West. But then in 1924, the federal government imposed a quota on Indian immigration. No longer able to bring their gurus stateside, Americans traveled to India to find them. Paul Brunton, a former writer and editor, discovered one of yoga's greatest teachers, Ramana Maharshi, and wrote A Search in Secret India in 1934, to introduce him to the world. Brunton went on to become one of the most prolific yoga chroniclers of his time.

J. Krishnamurti, an Indian philosopher, drew huge numbers of followers, beginning in the early 1930s and culminating at his death in 1986. For many baby boomers (as well as their parents), Krishnamurti epitomized the beauty and wisdom of jnana yoga, about which he so eloquently spoke, and his life and teachings influenced thousands of educators, philosophers, and laypeople. Besides embracing the spiritual side of yoga, Krishnamurti became an enthusiastic student of yoga asanas, spending many summers in Gstaad, Switzerland, with yoga master B.K.S. Iyengar and, later, with yogi T.K.V. Desikachar.

In 1947, Theos Bernard, another passionate student who studied in India for many years, wrote Hatha Yoga: The Report of a Personal Experience, one of the first guidebooks to yoga asanas.

Indra Devi, after studying with yoga master T. Krishnamacharya in India, wrote how-to manuals and had scores of Americans bending and stretching to her guru's yoga. In 1950, Richard Hittleman, a spiritual disciple of Ramana Maharshi, began teaching the physical aspects of hatha yoga in New York City. By 1961, thanks to the power of television, Americans everywhere were learning a non-religious, decidedly unspiritual form of yoga exercise. The teacher was the same Hittleman, who hoped to convince these new converts that yoga meditation and philosophy could forever change their lives. His books, including The Twenty-Eight-Day Yoga Plan, sold millions of copies and put hatha yoga on the American map. Ten years later, yoga teacher Lilias Folan consummated America's love of this gentle physical form of yoga in her PBS-TV series "Stretching with Lilias." Her openhearted, energetic manner convinced millions more that anyone could and should practice yoga. Today she has produced 11 yoga videos, which have sold more than 700,000 copies, and she continues to teach and lead workshops all over the world.

While America's World War II generation moved and stretched to the yoga of Richard and Lilias, the postwar baby boomers there and abroad yearned for a more spiritual awakening. These young college-age kids turned on and tuned in to Eastern spirituality in general and yoga principles in particular through Autobiography of a Yogi, by Paramahansa Yogananda. Although written in 1946, this introduction to the power of yoga spoke to a generation of young people in the 1960s and '70s who wanted more spiritual and transcendental experiences than they could get in their local churches or synagogues. Many of these seekers incorporated asanas into their yoga practice, but their primary goal was enlightenment, not perfect alignment in Downward-Facing Dog. Many of these same novices embraced the teachings of another bhakti yogi, Maharishi Mahesh Yogi, whose Transcendental Meditation enticed everyone from college freshmen to the Beatles, with its offer of experiences even more awesome than drug-enhanced trips.

Richard Alpert, a Harvard professor fired for his psychedelic experiments, found that a spiritual lifestyle could be even more powerful and life affirming than all his past acid-trips. He left for India in the late '60s and returned to America as Ram Dass, adept of Neem Karoli Baba. His book, Be Here Now, opened the eyes and hearts of many thousands of Western students.

Ashrams and spiritual communities burgeoned during the '60s and '70s, and while some taught aspects of yoga asana and pranayama, the other paths—bhakti, jnana, and karma yoga—prevailed.

A Modern Spin on an Ancient Tradition

So how did yoga become the bending, stretching, and twisting discipline we see today in yoga rooms and recreation centers around the world? How did the yoga canon expand from fewer than 100 postures—most of them variations on the seated lotus pose (Padmasana)—to more than a thousand, and come to include inversions, backbends, arm balances, and twists named after animals, gods, and myriad shapes? How did the ancient yogi's need to strengthen and purify his body translates to a current obsession with flat abdominals, toned biceps, and the latest in workout wear?

Ironically enough, three Indian swamis in the early part of the twentieth century inadvertently fed this modern fascination with physical prowess by independently studying and expanding the hatha yoga repertoire and presenting it not only to the uninitiated layman but to women as well. Swami Kuvalayananda focused primarily on the health benefits of practicing yoga; Swami Sivananda in Rishikesh and T. Krishnamacharya of Mysore concentrated on developing a richer, more varied system of asanas and pranayama techniques. Most scholars would agree that the hatha yoga Westerners enjoy today developed out of the work of these men.

T. Krishnamacharya

The man who deserves the most credit for creating, or at least influencing, the type of physical yoga that Americans, Western Europeans, and many Asians embrace today actually never set foot on Western soil. Sometime in the early 1930s, this young Indian man, Tirumalai Krishnamacharya, took it upon himself to champion the beauty and the benefits of yoga asana, lifting it up from relative obscurity and placing it alongside its bhakti, karma, and jnana yoga siblings. (In a biography, Krishnamacharya says asana practice was so little known in India that he had to go all the way to Tibet to find a guru to teach him.) Of course, like all serious yogis, his training began with Patanjali's *Yoga Sutra*, not with the study of postures; but then, he was only five years old when his father began teaching him in 1893.

No one really knows Krishnamacharya's true yoga journey, not even his family. Indeed his life remains shrouded in a fog of myth, fable, fact, and contradictory memories. Whatever the historical details, Krishnamacharya has become the undisputed father of modern-day hatha yoga. Since much of the Indian spiritual tradition has been handed down from guru to student for millennia, it's understandable that hatha yogis who teach the physical postures would want a similarly unbroken lineage.

Unfortunately, no such lineage appears to exist. Whether it came from the Yogarahasya, an ancient text forever lost that appeared to Krishnamacharya in a dream, or from a palm-leaf manuscript called the Yoga Korunta, which was supposedly devoured by ants, or from an ingenious and dynamic blend of asana, pranayama, Indian wrestling, and British gymnastics techniques, Krishnamacharya's yoga represents a uniquely twentieth-century incarnation of a rich and ever-evolving tradition, the underlying tenets of which have wavered little since the time of the ancient Upanishads.

We benefit from his knowledge every time we step onto a yoga mat in an Ashtanga, Iyengar, Bikram, or Viniyoga class (or just about any hybrid of them). One old yoga text does appear to have influenced Krishnamacharya. The Sritattvanidhi has fairly recently emerged from the private library of the Maharaja of Mysore, India, where Krishnamacharya lived and taught. This treatise, which hails from the early nineteenth century, offers the first manual devoted entirely to the physical aspect of yoga. You'll find no breathing techniques, no bandhas or mudras to perform, no chakras to open, and no cleansing rituals to enact. With its 122 postures illustrated and named, the Sritattvanidhi expands the repertoire to include poses we've all grown to love—handstands, arm balances, ashtanga foot-behind-the-head poses, and even rope hangings—and could very well be the proof yogis are looking for that a well-developed asana practice flourished prior to the twentieth century. That well-developed practice, however, incorporated much more than just traditional asanas. According to Norman Sjoman, Sanskrit scholar and author of The Yoga Tradition of the Mysore Palace (Adhinav, 1999), the Sritattvanidhi appears to have borrowed heavily from an assorted array of gymnastics moves, wrestling exercises, push-ups, and rope tricks, as well as yoga asanas. Sjoman says this eclecticism inspired and informed Krishnamacharya's teaching.

Krishnamacharya's work began in earnest in the 1930s when he received the financial backing of the Maharaja of Mysore, whose own ill health drew him to yoga. Krishnamacharya set up classes in a gymnasium at the Sanskrit College with the goal of introducing the power of yoga to as many students as possible. Like so many of today's yoga students, however, Krishnamacharya's students—mostly able-bodied, athletic, young men—were more interested in building strength and fitness and performing near-impossible feats than in any spiritual dimensions of practice. So Krishnamacharya created sequences that focused on athleticism by incorporating the power of the breath and the element of meditative gaze (Drishti) in a dynamic flow of poses called vinyasa, using all the props and disciplines at his disposal. To keep his students challenged and focused, Krishnamacharya developed increasingly more difficult sequences, allowing his students to progress to the next level only after they had mastered the first one.

Three of Krishnamacharya's most famous pupils emerged from his years in Mysore—Pattabhi Jois, who went on to develop the school of Ashtanga vinyasa yoga, Indra Devi who became known as the "First Lady of Yoga" in America, and B.K.S. Iyengar, who created his own unique brand of asana practice, which is known for its attention to body alignment and for its extensive use of props.

Pattabhi Jois, who still teaches and practices in Mysore, was just a young boy when he met Krishnamacharya at one of his yoga demonstrations. Jois studied with Krishnamacharya for several years before leaving for college. Guru and student reunited in Mysore at the Sanskrit College, and Jois became a faithful follower of Krishnamacharya's methods. Jois credits his teacher with perfecting the Ashtanga vinyasa system, a tradition that he says draws inspiration from the classics—the Yoga Sutra, the Bhagavad Gita, and the Hatha Yoga Pradipika—as well as from modern Western disciplines. This rigorous system of asana flow (vinyasa)—perhaps the most physically demanding sadhana in the West—resonates with Western practitioners who "go for the burn." At least initially, many embrace Ashtanga's emphasis on strength, flexibility, and stamina, and pay little attention to its other benefits.

Just as Krishnamacharya did in Mysore, Pattabhi Jois and his disciples continue to teach a set sequence of poses (linked by the breath), the purpose of which is to create tapas, or heat in the body, in order to cleanse and purify. Many teachers in the United States and Europe, who receive inspiration and teachings from Pattabhi Jois, travel frequently to India for further study with him. Although very few teachers receive actual certification from Jois, many of them reap the benefits of his legacy. Ashtanga-style classes vary from first-series, the beginning level, which focuses on forward bends, to second, third, or fourth-series classes, which offer increasingly more difficult backbends, standing poses, twists, and arm balances. All classes include a vinyasa of Sun Salutations (Surya Namaskar), in which students jump from one pose to the next as a way of linking a variety of asanas together. Just like in the practice of yoga in Patanjali's *Yoga Sutra*, combining the physical poses with attention to the breath brings the modern-day ashtangi steadiness and ease in the body, increased awareness in the mind, and more openness in the heart.

Indra Devi. In keeping with the long-standing yoga tradition of teaching only the initiated, Krishnamacharya never thought to include women or foreigners in his classes. Unfortunately for him, the Mysore royal family insisted that he teach a dear friend of the court, Zhenia Lubunskaia, known today as Indra Devi, who was both a woman and a Latvian. Reluctantly, Krishnamacharya agreed. He figured he would just need to push her beyond her capabilities and break her resolve, and then she'd go away. But Lubunskaia persisted, and eventually, she not only became an accomplished yoga teacher, but a good friend as well. As Indra Devi, she introduced yoga to the Soviet Union and, in 1947, arrived in Hollywood where she taught such celebrities as Gloria Swanson, Greta Garbo, Marilyn Monroe, and Robert Ryan. Mataji, as her followers affectionately call her, culled a gentler system of yoga from her studies with Krishnamacharya. Her Sai Yoga is not a vinyasa flow. She still used the breath to move within the pose and between poses, but her characteristic trademark is more devotional in flavor. She added chanting and meditation or prayer during each class and offered a central asana on which to focus. Mataji, who has six yoga schools in Buenos Aires, Argentina, stopped teaching just a few years before her death in 2002. She was 102. Her yoga method continues to be a strong influence on yoga students throughout the world. She has trained literally hundreds of teachers through her four-year, college-level course of study.

B.K.S. Iyengar did not have an easy time being Krishnamacharya's disciple, although he continues to revere his guru. Unlike Pattabhi Jois and Indra Devi, Iyengar didn't exactly seek out Krishnamacharya as a teacher, nor does he look back on his student days with much affection. Iyengar grew up in Krishnamacharya's household as his brother-in-law-a scrawny, sickly child who, by all odds, had very little chance of ever becoming a yogi. Instead, his duties were relegated to tending the gardens and performing the chores Krishnamacharya assigned to him. When Krishnamacharya's star pupil vanished from the household only days before an important asana demonstration, Krishnamacharya had no choice but to teach this puny pupil in hopes he would rise to the occasion. And rise he did—Iyengar not only performed very difficult asanas admirably at the demonstration, but he went on to assist

Krishnamacharya in his classes and other demonstrations throughout the area. His brief tenure with this "harsh taskmaster" ended when Krishnamacharya asked him to take over a women-only class in the northern province of Karnataka Pradesh—not exactly a plum assignment—which Iyengar agreed to do. From that point on he remained, happily it seems, hundreds of miles away from his guru.

Partly because of this distance, Iyengar had to explore Krishnamacharya's poses on his own. He used his own body as his laboratory, concentrating on precision and internal and external alignment, as he tried to figure out what effects a pose had on the internal organs as well as the skeletal system. Once Iyengar clearly understood the way an asana worked, he would then modify it to fit his students' bodies and health concerns. Just as Krishnamacharya adapted his sequences to the competitive nature of his able-bodied young athletes, Iyengar customized the poses and even offered props for his less flexible, older clientele. And, as the aged and infirmed among them began seeking help for their maladies, Iyengar rose to the challenge, creating healing, therapeutic sequences.

This emphasis on the physical body became a signature of Iyengar Yoga, and Iyengar's intuitive, almost uncanny ability to heal through asana practice has become legendary. He views the body as a finely tuned, highly sensitive instrument whose vibrations, he says, "express the harmony or dissonance within it." Asanas, he believes, help the body create or re-create its innate harmony. When performed correctly, asana practice synchronizes the rhythms of the body's physical, physiological, psychological, and spiritual components. Unlike Krishnamacharya, Pattabhi Jois, and Indra Devi, Iyengar waits until the practitioner has mastered asanas before incorporating pranayama into his method. Nor does he link the poses together in the same way. He chooses poses that work together, but his concern is how they achieve balance within the body rather than how they link together. Iyengar continues to teach, along with his daughter Geeta and son Prasant, at his center in Pune, India. His followers have spread Iyengar Yoga all over the planet, creating the most well-known style in the world. Even those who teach other methods often credit the Iyengar method with instilling in them an understanding of the body, the architecture of the poses, and the means to modify asanas when necessary.

Each of Krishnamacharya's star pupils took from him important, but very different lessons. Pattabhi Jois received the vinyasa teachings and went on to spread the word, almost verbatim; Indra Devi gravitated toward his style of sequencing and enhanced those teachings with a more developed sense of devotion and meditation; and Iyengar learned the power of adapting and improvising to meet the needs of his students, a practice he continues today. But a fourth disciple experienced Krishnamacharya's teachings in a much different way. Krishnamacharya was older, more patient, and had continued to evolve his understanding of yoga asanas when his son T.K.V. Desikachar began to express interest in learning.

By the time Desikachar asked his father to teach him, Krishnamacharya's own work had changed, in much the same way as Iyengar's had. Yoga was no longer reserved only for the select few who were strong and flexible enough to withstand its challenges, or spiritually attuned enough to understand them. To survive as a teacher, Krishnamacharya found he had to open his doors to all kinds of students, including those with physical limitations and even non-Hindus. And then he needed to figure out how to teach them. Working one-on-one, Krishnamacharya devised specific practices for each student. Sometimes he varied the pose sequence, or the length and frequency of the breath; other times he modified or simplified the poses to achieve particular goals. As the student reached those benchmarks, Krishnamacharya would alter his or her "prescription" to enable the student to grow further in the practice and to introduce the spiritual aspects of the tradition. This technique laid the groundwork for Desikachar's own interpretation of Krishnamacharya's work, which he called Viniyoga.

Desikachar was already a grown man, having finished college with an engineering degree when he decided to devote his life to studying yoga. Apparently, he saw his father—the ever-proper Brahmin—hug a woman who had come to thank him for curing her insomnia. Whether Desikachar was more shocked by the woman's response or intrigued by his father's ability to heal her, he knew he wanted to learn more. Krishnamacharya's response to his son's change of heart echoed his reaction to Indra Devi and Iyengar's desire to learn—it annoyed him more than it pleased him. To test Desikachar's resolve, his father began his lessons at 3:30 a.m. seven days a week. He agreed to focus only on asanas and pranayama since Desikachar disavowed any interest in God. Desikachar continued his yoga studies for 28 years, finally understanding, and incorporating, yoga's inherent spiritual dimension.

While he was teaching his son, Krishnamacharya continued to refine his system and developed it into an individualized program of asana, pranayama, and devotional chanting. He created programs for the young, the middle-aged, and the elderly. Your youth, Krishnamacharya reasoned, is the time to strengthen your muscles and enhance your flexibility through increasingly challenging yoga sequences; as you mature into your career and family years, your yoga should keep you healthy and stress-free. In your later years, as your focus becomes more internal and your thoughts turn to God, your yoga should have a more spiritual dimension.

Desikachar has devoted his life to spreading Krishnamacharya's message of yoga to the West and increasing its connection to science and medicine. Like Iyengar, Desikachar's Viniyoga concentrates on tailoring the yoga sequences to the needs of the individual, and, like Pattabhi Jois, he emphasizes the power of the breath. However, Viniyoga's focus lies somewhere between Iyengar's precision and Pattabhi Jois's vigorous movements. A Viniyoga class is slower than Ashtanga, though it coordinates the breath with the movement. Like Iyengar Yoga, it is known for its therapeutic applications, though Viniyoga concentrates less on alignment and more on varying the length and tempo of the inhalations and exhalations. Although not yet as popular in the United States as Iyengar and Ashtanga Yoga, Viniyoga has touched the lives of countless practitioners all over the world.

PATHS OF YOGA

Karma Yoga
The Path of Service

Bhakti Yoga
The Yoga of Devotion

Jnana Yoga
Focus on Philosophy and Intellect

Raja Yoga
Based on Patanjali's Ashtanga
Focus on Wisdom Mind

Hatha Yoga
Focus on Two Polarities of Energies:
Sun & Moon

Tantra Yoga
Focus on Tradition of Goddess

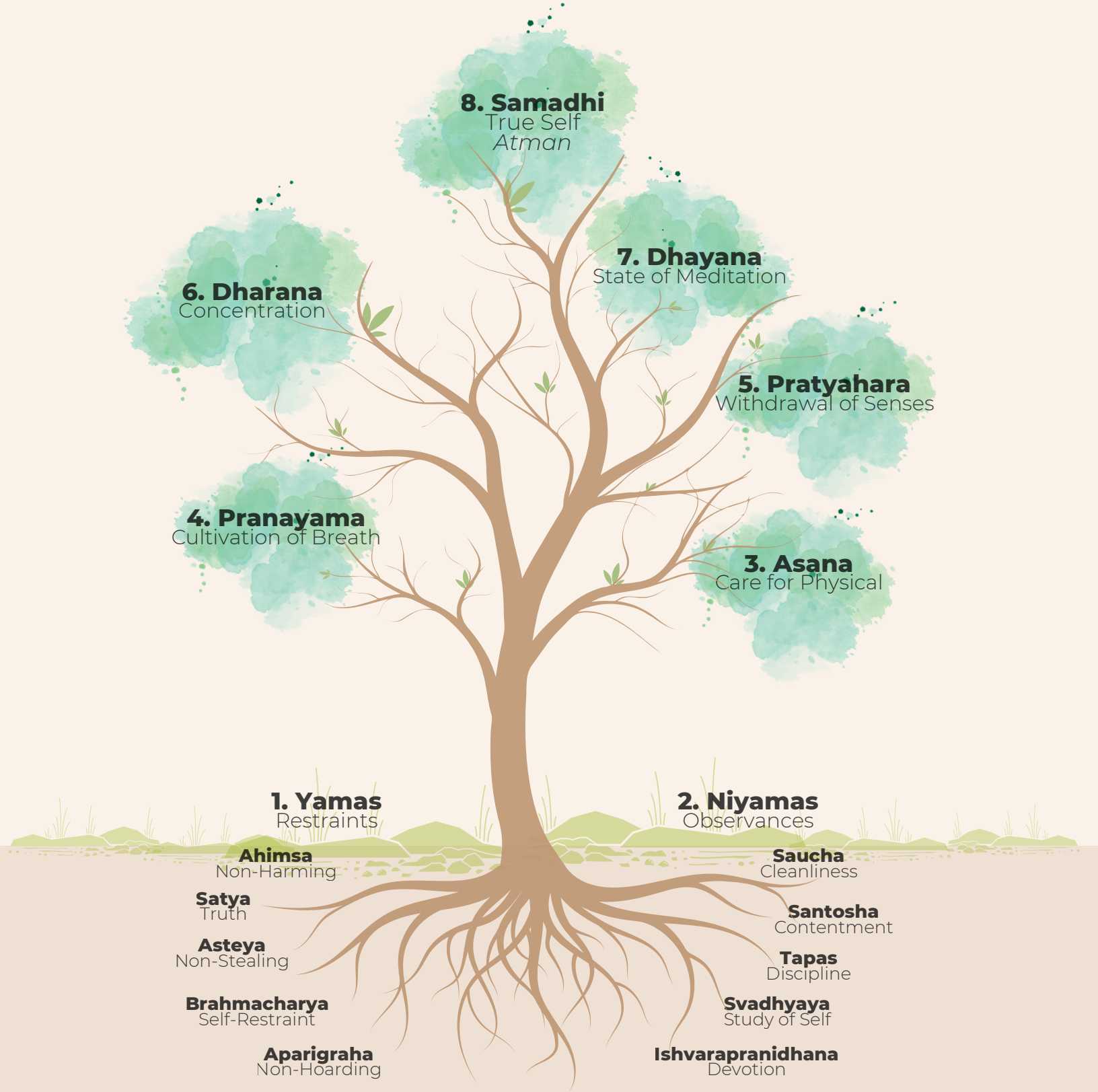
Other Styles of Yoga

Several other yoga styles at least indirectly owe their allegiance to Krishnamacharya's legacy. The increasingly popular Bikram Yoga, created by Bikram Choudhury, the self-proclaimed "Yogi to the Stars," incorporates two pranayama techniques and 24 asanas, including backbends, standing poses, one-legged balances, and twists. A 100-degree, humid room—the signature trademark of Bikram Yoga—makes this style particularly challenging. Kripalu Yoga, originally developed by Amrit Desai, a disciple of Indian master Kripalvananda, a Kundalini yogi, shares its asana repertoire, breath work, and flowing style with Krishnamacharya's vinyasa system. Kripalu encourages its students to discover their own strengths and weaknesses and to "play with their edges," coming into and out of the poses as they need to. Once students become more advanced and learn to hold poses longer and longer, Kripalu Yoga encourages them to allow the poses to arise spontaneously as they work with their life force (prana) and create their own, unique practice.

Yogi Bhajan, a Sikh who immigrated to the United States in the 1960s, broke with tradition and introduced Kundalini Yoga to the masses. His type of Kundalini Yoga combines asana with breathwork, chanting, and meditation to awaken the Divine energy coiled at the base of the spine. His Healthy, Happy, Holy Organization (3HO), established in 1969 and headquartered in New Mexico, focuses on karma yoga (the path of service to the community) as much as on education, a vegetarian lifestyle, and the therapeutic applications of yoga and Ayurveda. Students who study Kundalini Yoga learn specific pranayama techniques designed to clear the nadis and energize the system.

Vanda Scaravelli, creator of the Scaravelli Method, discovered yoga rather late in life, after the sudden death of her husband. At 45 years of age, she plunged headlong into daily classes with Iyengar, who taught her for many years, and later with T.K.V. Desikachar who introduced the power of the breath. Her method of yoga, which she taught in Italy until she was well into her 80s, teaches the power of gravity and the freedom of the breath in asana. The popularity of her book, Awakening the Spine, and the hundreds of students currently trained in the Scaravelli method have allowed her style of yoga to live on in Europe, Canada, and America.

PATANJALI'S ASHTANGA
(EIGHT LIMBS) OF CLASSICAL YOGA

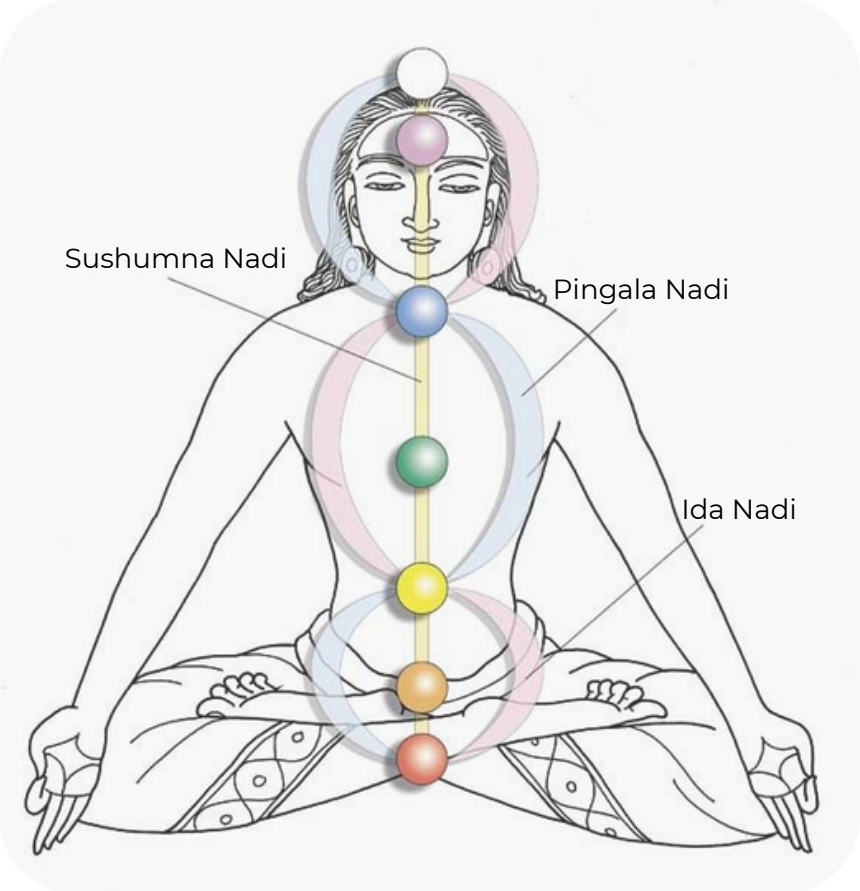


THE SUBTLE BODY
NADIS, MARMAS & CHAKRAS

5 Pancha KOSHAS

Pancha = five; *Maya* = illusion; *Kosha* = sheath; *Anna* = food; *Prana* = life energy; *Mano* = mind, mental, manas; *Vijnana* = knowledge, vidya; *Ananda* = bliss

Nadis



There are over 72,000 nadis; of which 14 are major ones and three primary nadis:

- **Sushumna nadi**—spinal chord
- **Pingala nadi**—(right, solar) sun (*ha*); fire, masculine (*yang*)
- **Ida nadi**—(left-lunar) moon (*tha*); water, feminine, (*yin*)

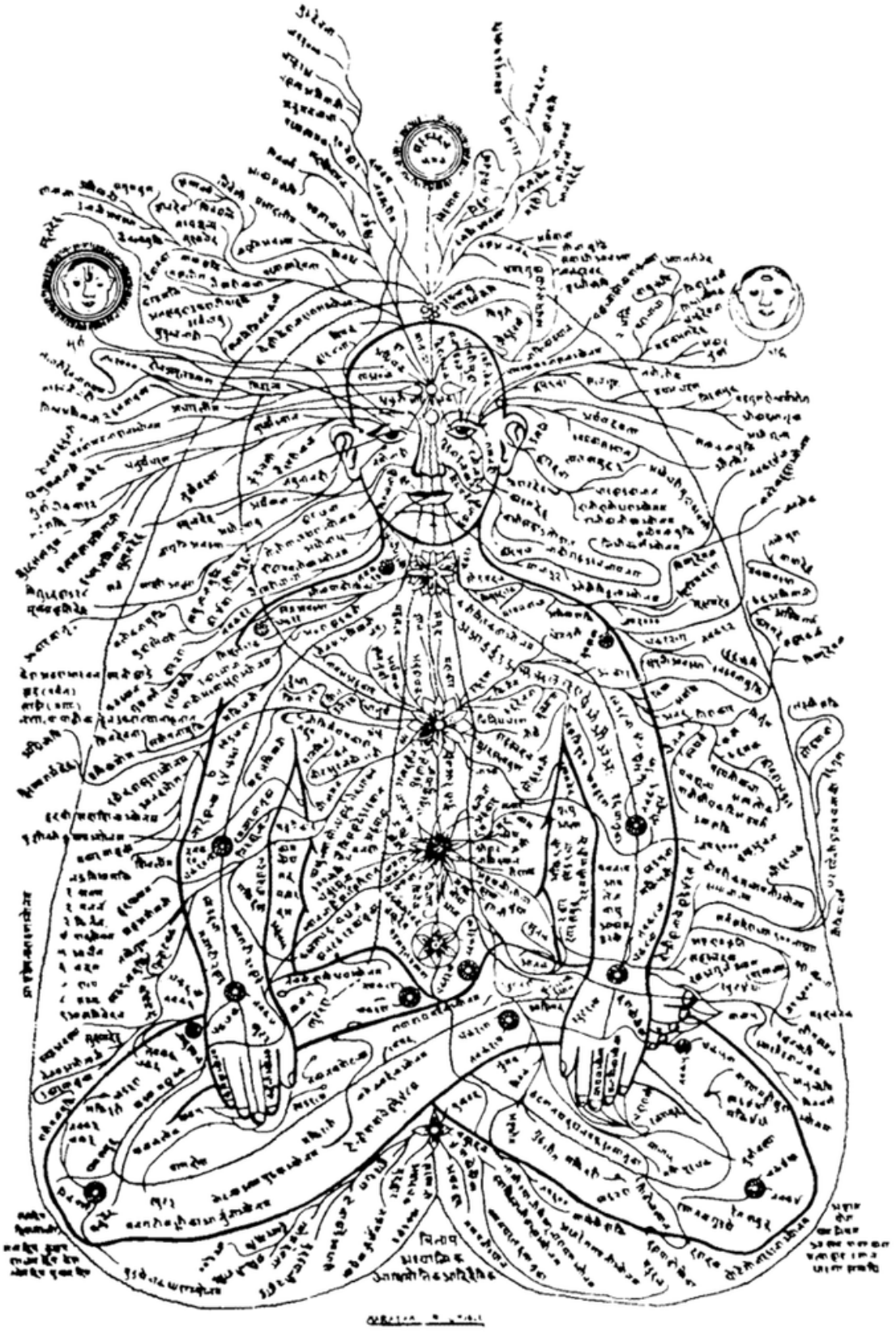
Kundalini

Dormant or static cosmic energy, depicted as a coiled snake lying at the base of the sushumna nadi, at the Muladhara chakra. It is awakened by pranayama and other practices.

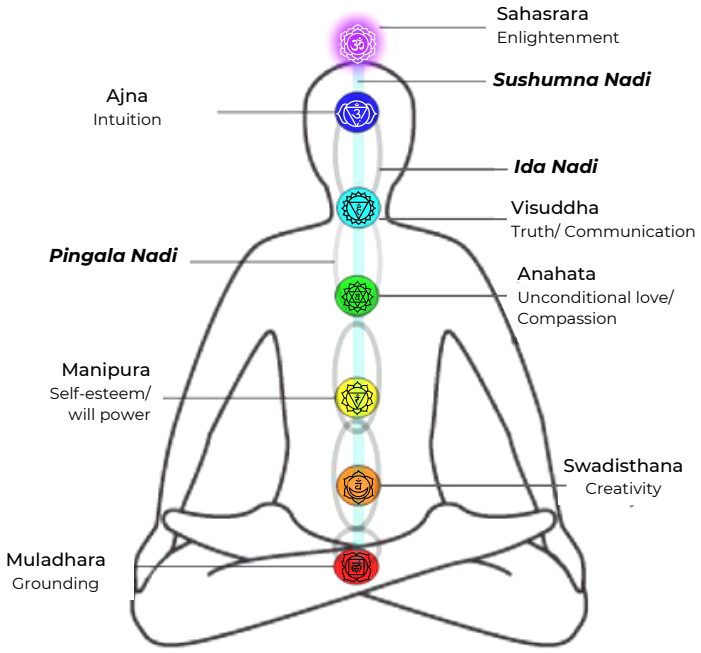
Marmas: 108 points (107 + skin)

Energy amplification points lie along the nadis, and work like capacitors to boost the flow of prana, thus increasing vitality. Can cause death if traumatized, or cure any disease if the affected marma is known and treated. Marmas are directly connected to the Chakra system to facilitate the circulation of vital force energy all over the body.

Nadis



Chakras



Chakra Symbol	Chakra Name	Chakra Sanskrit Name	Chakra Location	Chakra Color	Chakra Seed Sound	Chakra Element
	1. Root Chakra	*Muladhara*	Perineum	Red	LAM	Earth
	2. Sacral Chakra	*Svadhishthana*	Sacrum	Orange	VAM	Water
	3. Solar Plexus Chakra	*Manipura*	Solar Plexus	Yellow	RAM	Fire
	4. Heart Chakra	*Anahata*	Heart	Green	YAM	Air
	5. Throat Chakra	*Vishuddha*	Throat	Light Blue	HAM	Space
	6. Third Eye Chakra	*Ajna*	Third Eye	Indigo	Om (voiced)	Space
	7. Crown Chakra	*Sahasrara*	Crown of the head	Violet	Om (silent)	Space

SEVEN CHAKRAS

Muladhara |root or source of support | perineum| earth |

1st Chakra: Known as the seat of security, it supplies us with our most basic and instinctual survival skills, also the earthly desire to possess, to acquire, to hoard, and to compete. Our most basic fears and insecurities stem from this chakra. When balanced we feel secure, calm, and connected to the earth.

ASANA/PRANAYAMA:

Swadhisthana | your own dwelling place | genitals/navel |water |

2nd Chakra: Symbolizes our creative energy, and is the source of our physical, creative, and sexual energy. It is the place of our physical energy and the animation behind our urge to reproduce. This center gives rise to jealousy, anger, promiscuity, and co-dependency. When the center is flowing there is unlimited creativity and love.

ASANA/PRANAYAMA:

Manipura | the place where the jewels are kept | solar plexus | fire

3rd Chakra: The center of power, expression and expansion. Tuning into this center, the yogis say you begin to break the constricting nature of ego and experience a deepening communion with your true nature. It is also the storehouse of prana life source and of emotions.

ASANA/PRANAYAMA:

Anahata |that which is self-sustaining | heart | air |

4th Chakra: This is the center of compassion and unconditional love. According to the yogis, when you connect to life around you through the heart center, your love will flow like air. Both in reverence toward those who have realized their perfection more fully than you have, and in benevolent service to your fellow beings who are in need of a path of life.

ASANA/PRANAYAMA:

Vishuddha |pure amidst purity | throat | ether/space |

5th Chakra: The center of abundance and the great doorway to liberation. As we let go of all impure elements—all resentments, anger, and bitterness—we are set free to enjoy the boundless reaches of space. Our speech is pure and we become masterful teachers according to yogic thought.

ASANA/PRANAYAMA:

Ajna | third eye/space between the eyebrows | ether/mind & thought

6th Chakra: The eye of inner awareness. It controls both incoming and outgoing thoughts. It is the vertical eye of wisdom and that which takes us from our physical or horizontal reality and connects us to the vertical plane of divinity.

ASANA/PRANAYAMA:

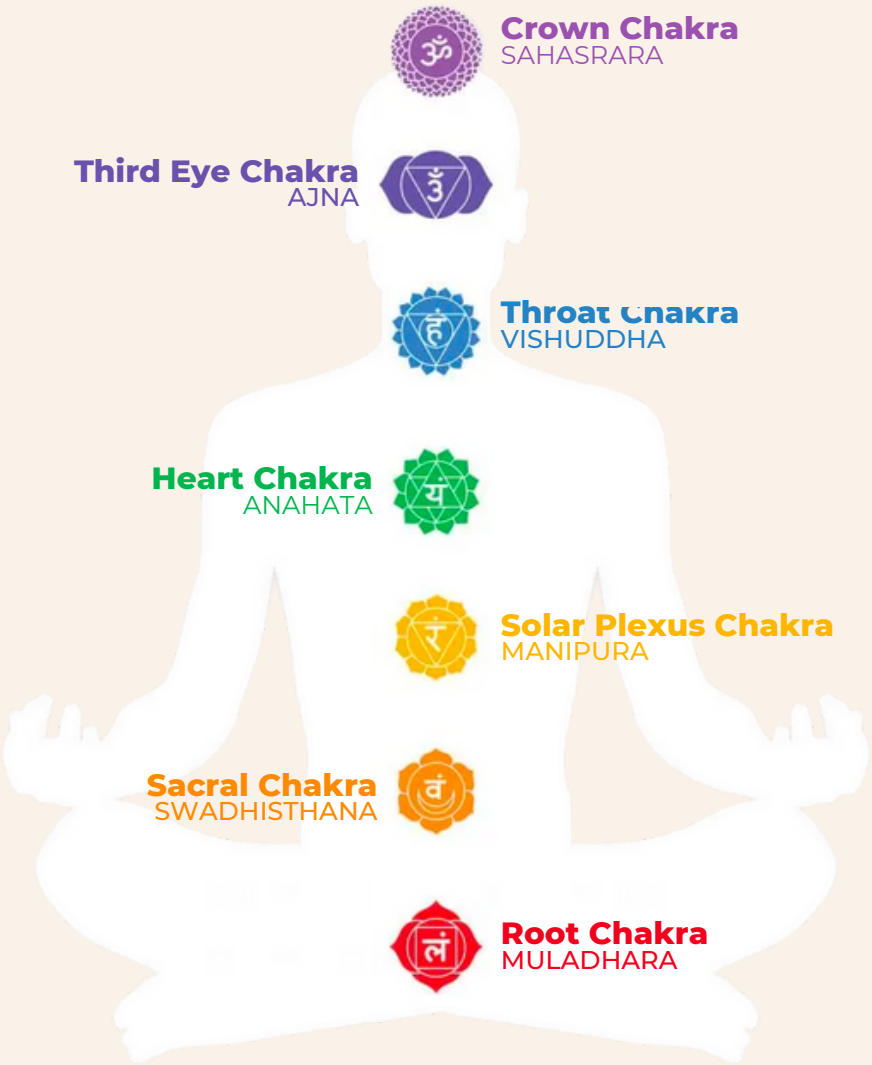
Sahasrara | a thousand petals/lotus flower | crown of the head/ether

7th Chakra: The highest chakra in terms of location and consciousness. Symbolically there are a thousand rays of light emanating from the center of this chakra, like spokes radiating from a wheel. Meditating on this center, one experiences duality and merging into oneness with a universal life force. There is no longer separation between “me” and “everything else,” or between “I” and “thou”; There is only oneness.

ASANA/PRANAYAMA:

Additional Notes

LOCATION OF THE CHAKRAS



NADIS: RIVERS OF LIFE ENERGY

By James Bailey

There is an entire universe within the breath. To understand this and the transformative nature of Yoga, we need to look deeply into the mysteries, and subtleties, of mind and body. We owe it to Tantra and its early practitioners who pioneered the inner landscape of the subtle body. There, they revealed the many wonders of our life energy. From that discovery arose the many energetic practices of Yoga employed to awaken the most vital life force, Kundalini Shakti, lying dormant within us, which connects us to the source.

In a way, we are all looking for the source of our life energy. The word itself, Yoga, means “to join” or “to yoke”, the essence of which evokes an integration of the many fragmented aspects of our life into a unified and conscious whole. Similarly, within the subtle energetic field of our bodies, a vast network of streaming channels, known as nadis, course their way quietly, integrating the vast spaces of the body, unifying them into one conscious and vital whole. It begins with the breath and it ends with the breath. This is the playing field of Yoga.

The Sanskrit word nadi derives from the root nad meaning “flow”, “motion” or “vibration”, suggesting that the essential nature of the nadi is to flow as do the currents of water in a stream or river, finding the path of least resistance, nourishing everything in its path. Nadis are our supply lines of prana, serving to both integrate and nourish the body's field of life energy. In essence, they are what make us alive.

Two types of vital energy are said to flow through the nadis: prana shakti, or vital force, and manas shakti, or mental force, suggesting the nadis to be channels of consciousness as well as energy. Together the two forces are generically referred to in English as simply the life force, and in Sanskrit as prana.

Asana and pranayama are effective Hatha Yoga practices because they serve two purposes: to nourish the prana, and to gently invigorate the current, freeing the nadis and the subtle body of obstructions, or knots in the body-mind that would hinder our growth. Such openings are cleansing to the nadis (nadishodhana) and eventually affect the physical body, resulting in greater flexibility and peace of mind. But why stop there?

Some schools traditionally describe the nadis as channels for the flow of consciousness distinct from the nervous system, while others would include the nervous system as the most subtle aspect of the physical body and a part of the nadi system. But if the nadis were simply the subjective sensation of the nervous system, then what neurophysiologic change due to the practice of Yoga would explain the experience of liberation (moksha)?

Some of the more esoteric teachings of the Vedas suggest that channels of energy are not unique to human life.

From his well-known title, “Yoga and Ayurveda”, Vedic scholar Dr. David Frawley expounds that, “Vayu, the great cosmic air force, creates all the channels, which hold all things in the universe like gemson a string. Just as there are channels in the body, so external nature is filled with various channels – from rivers and streams to currents of energy in intergalactic space.” One of the functions of the nadis is to receive and circulate Mahaprana, or the cosmic prana that exists in the world around us. The nadis allow Mahaprana to penetrate deep within the body through the breath to nourish and stimulate us. It could be said, then, that the raison d’etre for the practice of Hatha Yoga is to more efficiently connect with, acquire and organize Mahaprana into ourselves.

Congested or weak in prana, the nadis stagnate, and the aspirant would struggle with the distractions of poor health. And there are plenty of possible distractions. The nadis, and prana in general, may have long been dismissed by medical science as metaphor, searched for under microscopes and in pathology exams to no avail, but traditionalists believe that the nadis and the prana that runs through them are more relevant than ever, and equally as important as the alignment and anatomy that predominates the physical culture of Yoga today. The inner, subtle world of our life energy may seem an endangered paradigm among western practitioners of Yoga, but the knowledge has not been lost.

Ayurveda and the Anatomy of a Yogi

Much of what Ayurveda knows about the nadis is borrowed from Tantra Yoga. But Ayurveda has contributed much to the health and maintenance of the subtle body through several healing modalities such as marma point therapy, mantra, Ayurvedic massage, panchakarma detoxification therapies, herbal therapies, and essential oils. Both Ayurveda and Chinese Medicine recognize fourteen major nadirs or meridians in the human body. Three are primary to the practice of yoga, which we will review later.

To put the nadis into proper perspective, we need to review the anatomy of the yogic body. Ayurveda and Tantra Yoga share the view that the human being is composed of three bodies: the gross physical body, the subtle or vital body, and the causal body. The physical body (*sthula sharira*) is made of all things material, the physical body as we know it. It is composed of the five elements (earth, water, fire, air and ether). The main energetic forces of the physical body are the doshas Vata, Pitta and Kapha, which are in constant flux in attempt to maintain equilibrium. The physical body is created by and maintained by food.

The subtle or vital body (*sukshma sharira*) is made up of the network of nadis, the chakras with the latent Kundalini energy at the base, and the primary elements of the mind-prana field: the ego (ahamkara), intelligence (buddhi), and consciousness (*chitta*). The association of the subconscious mind with the chakras is popular and not unrealistic. The nadis and the chakras are said to be found where psyche and soma meet, where consciousness and form find one another. There they are the most tangible and palpable. These psychic points are linked together by the nadis, similar to the acupoints of Chinese medicine. In Ayurveda they are known as marma points. This is the subtle body in its purest energetic form.

The causal body (*karana sharira*) is even more subtle than the vital body. It is composed primarily of the three gunas (Sattva, Rajas, and Tamas) or causal elements, as well as the causal forms of seeing (drishti) and hearing (shruti). It is centered in the spiritual heart (not the heart chakra or the physical heart) and is the source of our highest spiritual creativity.

Ayurveda and Chinese medicine understand that the key to a vital healthy life is to maintain a fluid flow of energy within the channels. But, as with any stream or flow of energy, the nadis are prone to imbalance. Certain nadis may have an excess of prana in their flow while others may be deficient. Nadis may become blocked or even flow out of their proper channels. Therapies address the nature of the imbalance as well as the location, often associated with one of the apertures or orifices of the body. Ultimately, the best medicine for the health of the nadis is exercise, including daily practice of Hatha Yoga.

The Primary Channels

The Yoga Tantras mention 72,000 nadis in the body. The number may be relative, but there would have to be an extraordinary number of them in order to feed prana to each cell in the body. Both Ayurveda and Chinese acupuncturists recognize fourteen major channels. Three of which, however, are considered primary to the practices of Yoga.

The size of the nadis is said to vary, some like super highways running from coast to coast, head to toe, others smaller like residential streets or urban alleys. Were just the nadis visible to the eye, the shape or form of the human body would appear pretty much the same.

The three primary channels are Subhuman nadi, Ida nadi and Pingala nadi. They are the superhighways of nadis and run vertically along the spine. The Subhuman, known as the central channel, originates below the Muladhara (root) chakra at the base of the spine, and flows through the spinal cord to Ajna chakra at the third eye. It governs all functions of the subtle and physical body. The chakras are found along the spine on this great channel. Sushumna nadi is said to be blue in color, a reference to its vibrational quality as used in tantric visualization practices than to actual visible color.

There are said to be three nadis within the Sushumna, like multiple currents of water within the same stream. Each is progressively more subtle than the other. They are known as Vajrini, Chitrini, and Brahmani. It is through Brahmani nadi that the Kundalini, and the higher spiritual consciousness it creates, is said to ascend to its true home in the Sahasrara (crown) chakra. Otherwise, until the Kundalini is awakened, the Sushumna nadi remains closed.

Ida and Pingala nadis flank the Sushumna, running along either side of the spinal column. Both Ida and Pingala spiral over the Sushumna nadi, forming an intensified energetic field, or chakra where they cross. The image of the caduceus, the iconographic symbol of modern medicine, or the spiraling double helix of our DNA, helps to visualize the Ida and Pingala. Eventually, Ida and Pingala meet each other and the Sushumna at Ajna chakra midway between the eyebrows.

Generally stated, Ida nadi flows to the left of Sushumna. It is known as the “lunar” nadi, being cool, Yin and nurturing by nature. Ida nadi is said to be white in color, control all mental processes and oversee the more feminine aspects of our personality. Pingala nadi flows to the right of Sushumna. It is the “solar” nadi, being warm, Yang and stimulating by nature. Pingala nadi is said to be red in color, control all vital somatic processes and oversee the more masculine aspects of our personality.

Ida and Pingala are significant in that they contain within them the dualistic energies of prana and chitta, vital power and consciousness, intuition and rationality, right brain and left brain. They are said to operate alternately, each being dominant for a period of time, followed by the other. In most cases one of the two is dominant for longer periods than the other, thus we tend to see trends in personality, behavior and health that are Pingala-like or Ida-like by characteristic.

Ida-like individuals will have the lunar or nurturing qualities of Ida, but may lack the verve to sustain advanced Yoga practices. They are full of potential, but never manifest fully in the world or spiritually. Pingala-like individuals will have solar, type-A or highly creative and vital qualities, but may lack the quietude, introspection or receptive nature needed to yield to the grace of spiritual awakening.

Conventionally speaking, this is where the rubber hits the road. For as long as one of the two dualistic nadis are in control the Sushumna is said to stay closed and the Kundalini asleep at the base or, we might say, asleep at the wheel.

Nadis and Yoga

Early Tantric masters termed the practice “Hatha Yoga” for good reason. The Sanskrit word Hatha is composed of a combination of two *bija* mantras, *ha* and *tha*. The *bija* mantra *ha* represents the mind and the lunar qualities of the Ida nadi. The *bija* mantra *tha* represents the vital prana and the solar qualities of the Pingala nadi. Hatha Yoga is then the practice of unifying the pranic and mental forces of Ida and Pingala, prana shakti and manas shakti, sun and moon, Yang and Yin. When this union occurs, dualities within our subtle body and consciousness disappear and very interesting things begin to occur, much of which could fill many pages.

In short, with Ida and Pingala nadis in balance, the central Sushumna nadi comes to life. The union begins the awakening of higher consciousness created by an awakening Kundalini energy found at the Muladhara (root) chakra.

Returning to the breath, pulmonary physiologists tell us that breathing accounts for up to 80% of our moment-to-moment energy. Less than 20% come from our foods. The normal breath is adequate to provide Mahaprana to the subtle body, but not deep or vigorous enough to reach the Kundalini. The traditional asana and pranayama breathing practices of Hatha and Kundalini Yoga focus on this point. The deep intensified breathing of pranayama has a pulsing effect upon the sleeping Kundalini Shakti, causing her to awake and ascend the Sushumna to the Sahasrara (crown) chakra, the seat of Shiva. There Shiva and Shakti unite to complete the yogic journey.

Ajit Mookerjee, in his epic "Kundalini: The Arousal of the Inner Energy" describes the effects of the ascending Kundalini as a gradual "untying of the psychic knots that manifest along the Sushumna, and that which binds the individual to the common order of knowledge and action are severed in the ascent to truth."

In Closing

The great Indian poet, Kabir was once asked by one of his students, "Kabir, where is God?" His final reply was, "he is the breath within the breath." The more we explore the nadis and the quietness of the subtle body, the more it seems to draw us in, as if it were informing us of what to do in our practice, rather than us telling our bodies what to do. When we breathe or chant or meditate, we are more than just calming our nervous system, we are nourishing and soothing the pranic field. Distinctions between the physical and the subtle begin to fade, and we begin to hear the gentle streams of life energy that feed us, that connects us to the source, that makes the awakening possible.

Pranayama

Pranayama is a conscious practice of the control of breath to direct energy or the life force. It is listed as one of eight limbs in Patanjali's Yoga Sutras and is one of four chapters of the Hatha Yoga Pradipika. No matter the source, it is revered as a critical component in the practice of yoga and considered by some to be a science by itself.

PRANAYAMA VOCABULARY

prana: vital energy, life breath, life-force
pranayama: breath control; directing vital energy or life force
pra: first
na: smallest or most basic unit of measured energy
vayu: that which flows
ayama: to lengthen, extend
yama: to restrain or direct
shakti: power (feminine)
pranashakti: vital energy, intelligence with/in the breath
rechaka: exhale
pooraka: inhale
kumbhaka: period between incoming and outgoing breathing
antara kumbhaka: holding the breath in (retention)
bahya kumbhaka: holding the breath out (tension)
samavritti: equal breathing ratio; or same or identical, straight, entire, whole and complete.
visamavritti: unequal breathing ratio; or irregular or difficult.
brahmana: lengthening or exploring inhalation
langhana: lengthening or exploring exhalation

BREATH FOCUS

	Breath Type	Energetic Effect	Practice
1	**Abdominal Breath:** Abdominal Breath: use of the range of abdominal muscles to focus on breathing.		
2	**Diaphragmatic Breath:** version of abdominal breathing but includes use of the diaphragm and application of bandha.		
3	**Thoracic Breath:** control of abdominal and diaphragm to allow breath to move directly into rib cage on all sides.		
4	**Clavicular Breath:** control of abdominal, diaphragm and thoracic breaths to allow upper ribs and collarbone direction of breathing.		
5	**Yogic Breath:** controlled combination of abdominal, thoracic and clavicular breathing in unison.		

PRANAYAMA TECHNIQUES

	Pranayama Type	Energetic Effect	Practice
1	**Surya Bhedana:** to pass through or strike the solar channel.		
2	**Ujjayi:** victorious or psychic breathing. 'Uj' means upward or superiority in rank and Jaya —conquest, success or victory.		
3	**Sitali:** means “cool.” Practiced through a rolled tongue on inhalation through the mouth and exhaled without sound through the nose when tongue is retracted.		
4	**Sitkari:** also causes cold. Practiced through place the teeth together on inhalation through the mouth and exhaled without sound through the nose when tongue is retracted. Similar to Sitali, both techniques should be sucked in producing a sound on the inhalation but are soundless on the exhalation.		
5	**Bhastrika:** bellows breath.		

PRANAYAMA TECHNIQUES

	Pranayama Type	Energetic Effect	Practice
6	**Bhramari:** hummingbird/ bee sound is produced on exhalation; some yogis practice plugging the ears, eyes, etc., with a particular mudra. Also, some practice the inhalation with a sound, as well.		
7	**Kapalabhati:** breath of fire.		
8	**Simhasana:** Lion's breath		
9	**Surya Bhedana: to pass through or strike the solar channel.**		
10	**Chandra Bhedana:** to pass through or strike the lunar channel.		
11	**Nadi Shodhana:** alternate nostril using the practice of bandha and a particular ratio.		

Pancha Vayus

Vayu	Direction	Location	Chakra	Element	Asana Pranayama	Additional Notes
Prana Vayu	Upward					
Apana Vayu	Downward					
Vyana Vayu	Circulation					
Samana Vayu	Inward Circulation					
Udana Vayu	Outward					

The five directions of vayu as it circulates through the body are:

1. Prana vayu: heart, red, right, respiration, autonomic nervous system. Pranic absorption takes place on a large scale in the thoracic regions this is the function of prana vayu. Circulates from the diaphragm to the base of the throat (upward movement).

2. Apana vayu: anus, white, excretion, elimination takes place largely through the urinary/excretory and reproductive organs and is powered by apana. Vital energy functioning in excretion. Circulates downward from the navel to the feet (downward movement).

3. Vyana vayu: all-pervading, circulation. Circulation is powered by vyana. All-pervading prana, it circulates in all directions to each cell.

4. Samana vayu: navel, digestion, milky. In between prana and apana, in the stomach region, is the area of assimilation. circulates from the navel to the diaphragm (center circulation).

5. Udana vayu: throat, swallowing, white. Movement in the throat and fascial expression are due to udana. vital force near the throat. Circulates from the base of the throat to the top of the head.

Bandha

Bandha means bondage, joining together, or catching hold of. This can best be seen as a restraint or a method of regulating or capturing the energy of the chakras. Without the use of bandha, the prana generated from pranayama is unguided. There are three main bandhas:

1. *Uddiyana:* means flying up;
2. *Moola:* root, source, origin or cause, basis or foundation.
3. *Jalandhara:* jala means a net, web, lattice or a mesh
4. *Maha:* often translated as great or superior; this is a combination of all three previously mentioned bandhas.

Additionally, there are bandhas located in the hands, feet, thigh, and other parts of the body responsible for various movements of the anatomy and physiology of the body. Primarily, the bandha captures the energy of the chakras and delivers it up and down the spine. It also correlates with the pacha vayus within the pranamaya kosha; however, bandha is mostly elaborated on in the science involving chakra and nadis.

Drishti

To direct gaze at specific points, so as to direct focus inwards. This enhances concentration and awareness into the movement. The gaze is usually a soft gaze.

Nava Drishti: In Yoga, the following are the most prominent gaze points:

- *Nasagrai:* gazing to the space just beyond the tip of the nose. This is the primary drishti in the sitting postures.
- *Ajna:* gazing at the space between the eyebrows, like in Purvottanasana.
- Nabi: gazing at thenavel center,like in Adho Mukhasavasana/Downward-Facing Dog
- *Hastagrai:* gazing at the hand, like in Trikonasana/Triangle pose.
- *Padhayoragrai:* gazing at toes, like in Savangasna/ Shoulderstand.
- *Parsvadrishti:* gazing far to the right, like in Supta Padagusthasana/Reclining big toe position.
- *Parsva drishti:* gazing far to the left, like in Marichyasna.
- *Angusta Ma dyai:* gazing at the thumb, like in Urdhva Hastasana.
- *Urdhva drishti/ Antara Drishti:* gazing up to the sky, like in Viparita Virbhadrasna/ Reverse Warrior pose.

MEDITATION

Meditation Posture

TYPES OF MEDITATIONS

BREATH FOCUS
Counting your breath (1 for inhalation, 2 for exhalation) up to 10. If your mind wanders, go back to 1

CIRCULAR BREATHING
Inhale from the base of your spine up to the base of your neck. Exhale down the back of your spine.

TRANSCENDENTAL (TM)
Counting your breath (1 for inhalation, 2 for exhalation) up to 10. If your mind wanders, go back to 1

MANTRA REPETITION
Chant a single rhythmical phrase over and over again like "Om", "So hum", "Satnam", "Shanti".

KUNDALINI/ CHAKRA FOCUS
Inhale from the base of your spine up to the base of your neck. Exhale down the back of your spine.

MINDFULNESS (BUDDHISM)
Watch your thoughts; let them come and go, without reacting, judging or holding on.

BELLY
Focus on the sensation of the breath in the belly as it rises and falls.

JAPA MEDITATION
Concentrate on chanting a mantra (repetitively) using a *Mala* (chant mantra to each bead).

LOVING KINDNESS FOR SELF/METTA (BUDDHISM)
Acknowledge whatever you are feeling. Playfully extend loving kindness to yourself by silently expressing feelings like: "May I be happy/ healthy/ loved" etc. Maintain this flow of intention.

LOVING-KINDNESS FOR OTHERS/METTA (BUDDHISM)
Picture someone you respect and love. Send a stream of metta (loving-kindness) towards them using silent, suitable words. If a feeling of happiness arises, absorb yourself into it.

ANALYTICAL (TIBETAN BUDDHISM)
Sit with a deep question in your mind. Like "Who am I?" Explore who is thinking, hearing, seeing, wondering. What happens in the immediate moment as you ask this question?

WALKING (BUDDHISM)
Acknowledge whatever you are feeling. Playfully extend loving kindness to yourself by silently expressing feelings like: "May I be happy/ healthy/ loved" etc. Maintain this flow of intention.

SENSING LOOP/ BODY SCAN (SUFISM)
Feel into the sensations in your right foot and then work up around each segment of your body—lower leg, knee, thigh, hip, hand, arm, shoulder—in a loop.

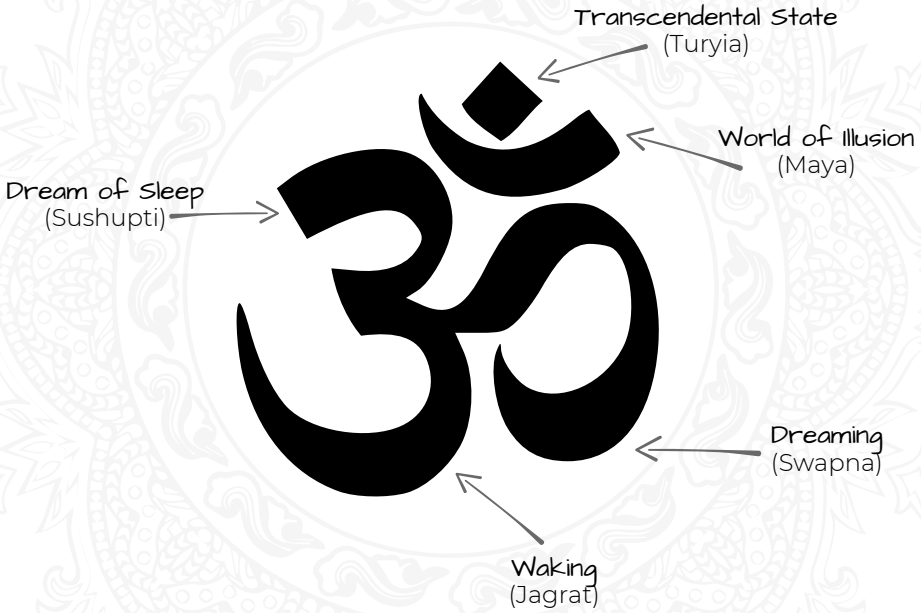
TRATAKA – CANDLE GAZING
Sit a foot away from a lit candle and concentrate on the flame. Think of the qualities you want to focus on and bring out from within. Once your eyes start to water, close them and bring your focus to your *Third Eye*. Repeat 3x and then lay in *Savasana* for a few minutes.

EATING
Take twenty minutes to eat three raisins. Savor every detail: the look, the anticipation, the chew, the taste, the swallow.

SILENT GRATITUDE/ VISUALIZATION (BUDDHISM)
Imagine the face of someone you feel grateful to in great detail and silently thank them. Repeat for 4–5 people.

ATTENDING (BUDDHISM)
Concentrate while carefully naming thoughts, sensations and other mental processes and distractions.

the Om symbol break down



तस्य वाचकः प्रणवः ॥२७॥

His word is **Om**.
— Yogasutra 1.27
(Ref: *The Yogasutras of Patanjali* Charles Johnston)

I am the Father of this world, Mother, Ordainer, Grandfather, the Thing to be known, the Purifier, the syllable **Om**, Rik, Saman and also Yajus.
— *Krishna to Arjuna, Bhagavad Gita 9.17*

Therefore, uttering **Om**, the acts of yajna (fire ritual), dāna (charity) and tapas (austerity) as enjoined in the scriptures, are always begun by those who study the Brahman.
— *Bhagavad Gita 17.24*
(Ref: Jeaneane D. Fowler (2012), The Bhagavad Gita: A Text and Commentary for Students, Sussex Academic Press)

Mantras for Meditation

- **AUM:** Om, the Pranava, the name of the divine universe
- **SAT NAM:** Truth is my identity and I call upon the eternal Truth that resides in all of us
- **SO HUM:** I am all that is
- **OM NAMA SHIVAYA:** I bow to Lord Shiva
- **OM SHANTI:** Infinite Peace

The Meditation Practice

1. Set aside a special place
Let the atmosphere be peaceful and quiet

2. Sit in a comfortable position with the spine straight
Padmasana, cross legs, in a chair, or lying on the back.

3. Choose a time when your mind is free of everyday concerns
Dawn/morning and dusk/evening are ideal times.

4. Try to practice at the same time and place each day
Using the same conditions allows the mind to come to stillness more quickly.

5. Sit in meditation for a minimum of 5–15 minutes daily
Dedication, commitment, and patience are required.

6. Consciously instruct your mind to prepare for meditation
Allow the mind to quiet as it enters into the meditation practice; create a ritual opening.

7. Regulate your breathing
Bring your attention to your breath, breathe slowly. Observe.

8. Establish a rhythmic breathing pattern
Count the beats of the breath to balance inhale and exhale.

9. At first let the mind wander purposefully
The mind may resist the practice at first so allow it to flow for a short time.

10. Bring the mind to rest on the focal point of your choice
Anahata Chakra (heart) or Ajna Chakra (third eye) are good places.

11. Apply your chosen technique and hold your concentration throughout the session

12. Consciously bring the meditation practice to an end
Do not let the mind wander to everyday thoughts and stop. Create a ritual ending.

~Shri Dharma Mittra

Create an Altar

Make your meditation spot sacred by creating an altar. You may place any statues, images of inspiration, flowers, plants, candle, incense, or any other objects that you cherish.

Meditation Point of Entry

by Swami Durgananda
(Excerpted from The Heart of Meditation: Pathways to a Deeper Experience)

Finding the right concentration technique for your meditation practice means opening as many doors as possible.

In my early years of meditation, I wasted countless hours wondering which technique to use. The teachers of my lineage offered several basic methods: repeating a mantra, focusing on the space between breaths, and witnessing the thoughts. But an early mentor had told me to decide on one technique and stick with it, and I reasoned that if I had to choose one practice, it had better be the right one.

So I worried. I worried about which mantra to use, about whether to meditate on the Witness—the observing awareness that remains ever-present through all the fluctuations of our moods and mental states—or follow my breath. I worried about when it was permissible to leave the technique behind and just relax. It wasn't until I stopped making techniques into icons that I began to discover how liberating it can be to work with different practices at different times.

We use techniques in meditation for a very simple reason: Most of us, at least when we begin meditation, need support for the mind. A technique provides a place for the mind to rest while it settles back down into its essential nature. That's all it is really, a kind of cushion. No technique is an end in itself, and no matter which one people use, it will eventually dissolve when their meditation deepens.

I like to think of meditation methods as portals, entry points into the spaciousness that underlies the mind. The inner spaciousness is always there, with its clarity, love, and innate goodness. It is like the sky that suddenly appears over our heads when we step out of the kitchen door after a harried morning and glance upward. The Self, like the sky, is ever present yet hidden by the ceiling and walls of our minds. In approaching the Self, it helps to have a doorway we can comfortably walk through, rather than having to break through the wall of thoughts separating us from our inner space.

Most of us already know which modes of meditation feel most natural. Some people naturally have a visual bent and respond well to practices that work with inner "sights." Others are more kinesthetic, attuned to sensations of energy. There are auditory people, whose inner world opens in response to sound, and people whose practice is kindled by an insight or a feeling.

Once we become aware of how we respond to different perceptual modes, we can often adjust a practice so it works for us. Someone who has a hard time visualizing can work with an image by "feeling" it as energy or as an inner sensation, rather than trying to see it as an object.

A highly visual person might get bored with mantra repetition when he focuses on sounding the syllables, but feel the mantra's impact if he visualizes the letters on his inner screen. One person might experience great love when repeating a mantra with a devotional feeling, while a friend's meditation only takes off once she lets go of all props and meditates on pure Awareness. Each person needs to find his or her own way.

Perhaps the most important thing to remember about any practice is to keep looking for its subtle essence. Every technique has its own unique feeling, which creates an energy space inside. For example, when repeating a mantra with the breath, a person might feel a sensation of prana (vital force) moving between the throat and the heart, as well as a subtle feeling of expansion or pulsation in the heart space when the mantra syllables "strike" it.

Focusing on the space between the breaths, one might begin to feel the breath moving in and out of the heart and notice a subtle expansion of the heart space. One might notice that certain parts of the inner body are activated by a particular practice; the space between the eyebrows, for example, might begin to pulsate when one imagines a flame there. Following the rhythm of the breath might make a person especially aware of the currents of energy flowing through the body.

That energy sensation, or feeling sense, is the subtle effect of the method and its real essence. It is the feeling sense a technique creates—rather than the technique itself — that opens the door into the Self. For this reason, one effective way of going deeper in meditation is to keep one's awareness moving "into" the feeling-space created by the practice: into the sensation created by the mantra as its syllables drop into one's consciousness, into the sensation of the breath as it pauses between the inhalation and the exhalation, or into the vividness of the object being visualized.

As we do this, we automatically release ourselves into a subtler level of our being. This release will happen more easily if we can allow ourselves to give up any feeling of separation from the technique. Nearly always, when people have difficulties going deeper into meditation, it is because they are keeping some sort of separation between themselves and their method and between themselves and the goal.

The antidote for nearly every problem that arises in meditation is to remember that the meditator, the technique of meditation, and the goal of meditation are one: that within the inner field of Awareness, everything is simply Awareness itself.

Another reason to experiment with techniques is to keep from being stuck in a particular method. Some people can take a single technique and continue with it for a lifetime, going deeper and deeper. Others, however, find that the original practice

they learned stops being effective after a time. Some people stick with a practice they learned years ago, even when it no longer helps them go deeper.

After a while, when the practice doesn't seem to work for them, they come to feel that they aren't good meditators, or that meditation is just too hard or boring, or even that it comes so easily they miss a feeling of growth. Often their only problem is trying to enter meditation through the wrong doorway or a door that once opened easily but is now stiff on its hinges.

Ultimately no meditation practice is going to work unless you like doing it. This piece of wisdom comes from no less an authority than Patanjali's Yoga Sutra, a text so fundamental that every yogic tradition in India makes it the basis for meditation practice. After listing a string of practices for focusing the mind, Patanjali ended his chapter on concentration by saying, "Concentrate wherever the mind finds satisfaction."

How do meditators know the mind is finding satisfaction in a technique? First, they should enjoy it and be able to relax within it. It should give them a feeling of peace.

Once they've become familiar with it, the practice should feel natural. If they have to work too hard at it that may be a sign it is the wrong practice.

Meditators who have received practices through a lineage of enlightened teachers usually find that these practices are especially empowered—infused with an energy that yields relatively quick results as they work with them. Those without a lineage teacher find that the sages of meditation have offered us countless techniques—such as mantras, visualizations, and practices of awareness—that open up into the Self as one explores them.

I suggest spending some time experimenting with a particular practice; work with it long enough to get a sense of its subtleties and see how it affects meditation over time. When we clearly understand that a technique is not an end in itself but simply the doorway into the greater Awareness, we can begin to sense which doorway is going to open most easily at a particular moment. Some techniques energize while others kindle love or help quiet an agitated mind.

Of course, we don't want to become technique junkies, flitting from one method to another and never going deeply into any single method; However, playing with different practices helps us get to know ourselves and discover what works best.

Everyone's road is unique, and ultimately no one else can tell a person what he or she needs. That's why there aren't any rules about the "best" way to meditate, except that a practice should soothe the restlessness of the mind and make it easier to enter the interior silence. This is discovered only through practice.

MUDRA

Seal, mark or gesture

Mudras are positions of the body that have some kind of influence on the energies of the body, or your mood. Mostly the hands and fingers are held in some position, but the whole body may be part of the mudra as well. The most well-known mudras are probably the ones performed while meditating.

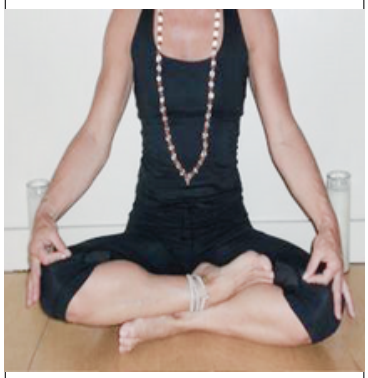
Hasta Mudras

Hand Mudras

Vishnu

Alternate nostril, hand position

Jnana



Pointer to touch thumb. Palms down (meditation)

Nasagra

Alternate nostril, touch third eye

Anjali

Palms touch at heart

Chin

Pointer to touch thumb. Palms up (meditation)

Jaya

Palms overhead. Victory

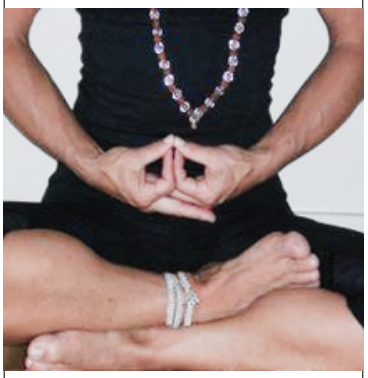
Samkalpa

Left hand holds right for union of active/receptive energy

Hasta

Palms up in receptivity

Dhyana



Right hand in left and thumbs touch (meditation)

Prana

Palms raise. Balance

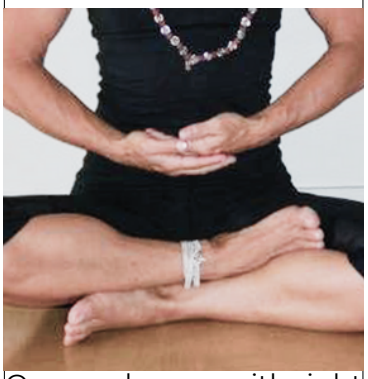
Yoni

Interlace middle, ring & pinky fingers. Let pointer & thumb touch to form womb. Fertility

Vira

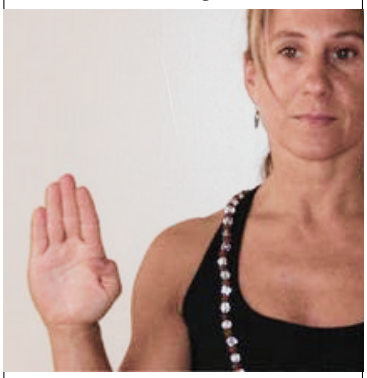
Make fists with thumbs up for both hand and raise them overhead. Solar

Bhairava



Open palms up with right hands resting on the left. Union w/ supreme consciousness

Abhiya



Palm faces out, thumb down. Have no fear

Hridiya

Touch middle & ring fingers to thumb. Increases prana to heart

Garuda

Link thumbs and spread fingers. Freedom

Ganapati

Interlace fingers and pull fists. Removes obstacles

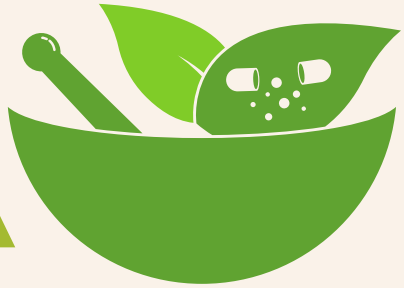
Padma

Touch base of palms and form petals with fingers. Transformation

Shankara Conch

Make L w/ left hand and wrap right hand. Left middle touches right thumb. Protection

AYURVEDA



"He, being established in Self, who has balanced doshas (the principles of physiology), balanced appetite and digestion, balanced tissues and body systems, proper elimination of wastes, balanced body processes and whose mind, soul and senses are full of bliss is known as a healthy person."

PRINCIPLES OF AYURVEDA

In our world today the definition of health is freedom from disease and injury; However, for over 5,000 years the above definition has existed in Ayurveda, the ancient medical science of India. The depth of this most basic sutra tells so much about the richness, complexity, and total harmony of living Ayurveda.

Definition: The science of life, the oldest healing science.

Prakriti: One's true nature or constitution.

Vikriti: The nature of the imbalance.

SIX PRIMARY CYCLES

1. Digestive
2. Day – 24 hours
3. Lunar – monthly
4. Seasonal
5. Annual
6. Life cycle

THE THREE *GUNAS*

Qualities of energy in the un-manifested universe:

1. ***Sattva:*** Purity

2. ***Rajas:*** Activity, passion, the process of change

3. ***Tamas***: Darkness, inertia

THE FIVE ELEMENTS

(From most dense to most subtle)

1. Earth: ***Prithivi***

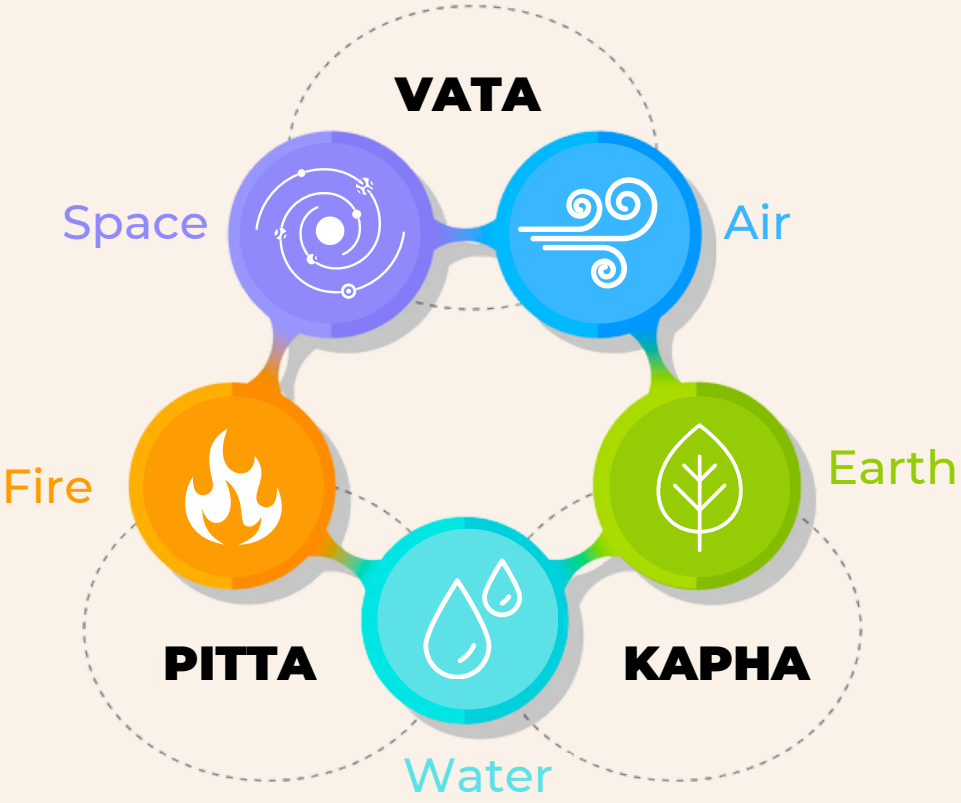
2. Water: ***Apas***

3. Fire: ***Agni***

4. Air/Wind: ***Vayu***

5. Space/Ether: ***Akasha***

THE DOSHAS



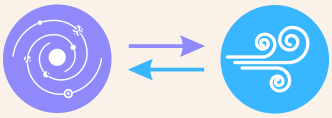
Sama dosha samagni ca sama dhatu mala kriya
*prasannatmendriya manah svastha ityabhidiyate**

~ Sushruta Samhita 15.38

*This can be translated as: One with balanced doshas, proper digestion, well-formed tissues, proper waste elimination, smooth bodily functions, presence of bliss in soul, mind and senses; one who is seated at ease in their self; this is a healthy person.

VATA DOSHA

Space and Air



Characteristics:

Prominent physical features:

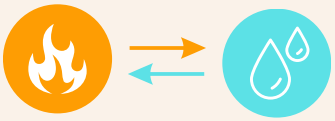
Energy attributes:

General guidelines:

Suggested asana/pranayama:

PITTA DOSHA

Fire and Water



Characteristics:

Prominent physical features:

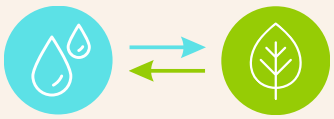
Energy attributes:

General guidelines:

Suggested asana/pranayama:

KAPHA DOSHA

Water and Earth



Characteristics:

Prominent physical features:

Energy attributes:

General guidelines:

Suggested asana/pranayama:

Ayurvedic healing methods used to heal patients

- Diet & Nutrition
- Herbs
- Massage/Marma Point Therapy
- Asana/Pranayama
- Lifestyle Changes
- Mantra
- Meditation
- Purification/Fasting

Ayurveda: A Brief Introduction and Guide to the Three Doshas

Dr. Vasant Lad, the Ayurvedic Institute, 1996

Ayurveda is considered by many scholars to be the oldest healing science. Ayurveda is a Sanskrit word which means “The Science of Life.” Ayurvedic knowledge originated in India more than 5,000 years ago and is often called the “Mother of All Healing”. It stems from the ancient Vedic culture and was taught for many thousands of years in an oral tradition from accomplished masters to their disciples. Some of this knowledge was set to print a few thousand years ago, but much of it is inaccessible. The principles of many, if not all, natural healing systems now familiar in the West, such as Homeopathy and Polarity Therapy, have their roots in Ayurveda.

Ayurveda places great emphasis on prevention and encourages maintaining health by paying close attention to balance in one’s life through right thinking, diet, lifestyle and herbs. Knowledge of Ayurveda enables one to understand how to create the balance of body, mind, and consciousness according to one’s own individual constitution and how to make lifestyle changes to bring about and maintain this balance.

Just as everyone has an individual face or thumb print, according to Ayurveda, each person has a particular pattern of energy–an individual combination of physical, mental and emotional characteristics–which is his or her constitution.

This constitution is determined at conception by a number of factors and is the same throughout one's life. Many factors, both internal and external, act upon us to disturb this balance and are reflected as a change in one's constitution from the balanced state. Examples of some of these emotional and physical stresses are: one's emotional state, diet and food choices, seasons and weather, physical trauma, work, and family relationships. Once these factors that can cause imbalance are understood, one can take appropriate actions to nullify or minimize their effects or eliminate the causes, and re-establish one's original constitution. Balance is the natural order; imbalance is disorder. Health is order; disease is disorder. Within the body, there is a constant interaction between order and disorder. Once one understands the nature and structure of disorder, one can re-establish order. Ayurveda identifies three basic types of energy (doshas) or functional principles that are present in everybody and everything.

There are no single words in English to describe these principles, so we use the original Sanskrit words Vata, Pitta, and Kapha. Energy is required to create movement so that fluids and nutrients get to the cells, enabling the body to function. Energy is also required to metabolize the nutrients in the cells and is called for to lubricate and maintain cellular structure. Vata is the energy of movement, Pitta the energy of digestion or metabolism and Kapha is the energy of lubrication and structure.

All people have Vata, Pitta and Kapha, but one is usually primary, one secondary and the third least prominent. The cause of disease in Ayurveda is viewed as the lack of proper cellular function because of an excess or deficiency of Vata, Pitta or Kapha and/or the presence of toxins. In Ayurveda, body, mind, and consciousness work together in maintaining balance. They are simply viewed as different facets of one's being.

Learning how to balance the body, mind, and consciousness then requires an understanding of how Vata, Pitta and Kapha work together. According to Ayurvedic philosophy, the entire cosmos is an interplay of the energies of the five great elements–Space, Air, Fire, Water and Earth. Vata, Pitta and Kapha are combinations and permutations of these five elements that manifest as patterns present in all creation.

In the physical body, Vata–composed of Space and Air–is the subtle energy associated with movement. It governs breathing, blinking, muscle, and tissue movement, pulsation of the heart, and all movements in the cytoplasm and cell membranes. In balance, Vata promotes creativity and flexibility. Out of balance, Vata produces fear and anxiety.

Pitta, made up of Fire and Water, expresses as the body's metabolic system. It governs digestion, absorption, assimilation, nutrition, metabolism and body temperature. In balance, pitta promotes understanding and intelligence. Out of balance, pitta arouses anger, hatred and jealousy.

Kapha is formed from Earth and Water and is the energy that forms the body's structure–bones, muscles, tendons–and provides the "glue" that holds the cells together. Kapha supplies the water for all bodily parts and systems. It lubricates joints, moisturizes the skin, and maintains immunity. In balance, Kapha is expressed as love, calmness and forgiveness. Out of balance, it leads to attachment, greed and envy.

Life presents us with many challenges and opportunities. Although there is much over which we have little control, we do have the power to decide about some things, like our diet and lifestyle. To maintain balance and health, it is important to pay attention to these decisions. Diet and lifestyle appropriate to one's individual constitution strengthen the body, mind and consciousness.

The basic difference between Ayurveda and Western allopathic medicine is important to understand. Western allopathic medicine currently tends to focus on symptomatology and disease, and primarily uses drugs and surgery to rid the body of pathogens or diseased tissue. Many lives have been saved by this approach. In fact, surgery is encompassed by Ayurveda. However, drugs, because of their toxicity, often weaken the body. Ayurveda does not focus on disease. Rather, Ayurveda maintains that all life must be supported by energy in balance. When there is minimal stress and the flow of energy within a person is balanced, the body's natural defense systems will be strong and can more easily defend against disease.

It must be emphasized that Ayurveda is not a substitute for Western allopathic medicine. There are many instances when the disease process and acute conditions can best be treated with drugs or surgery. Ayurveda can be used in conjunction with Western medicine to make a person stronger and less likely to be afflicted with disease and/or to rebuild the body after being treated with drugs or surgery.

We all have times when we don't feel well and recognize that we're out of balance. Sometimes we go to the doctor only to be told there is nothing wrong. What is actually occurring is that this imbalance has not yet become recognizable as a disease. Yet it is serious enough to make us notice our discomfort. We may start to wonder if it is just our imagination. We may also begin to consider alternative measures and actively seek to create balance in our body, mind and consciousness.

Ayurveda encompasses various techniques for assessing health. It assesses prodromal symptoms, cardinal signs and symptoms, and one's suitability for treatment to help determine the etiology and pathogenesis of an imbalance. Various methods are utilized to help acquire information during an assessment with a client. These methods include questioning, observation, palpation, direct perception, and inference. Techniques such as taking the pulse; observing the tongue, eyes and physical form; and listening to the tone of the voice are employed during an assessment. Palliative and cleansing measures, if appropriate, can be used to help eliminate an imbalance along with suggestions for eliminating or managing the causes of the imbalance.

Recommendations may include the implementation of lifestyle changes; starting and maintaining a suggested diet; and the use of herbs. In some cases, participating in a cleansing program, called panchakarma, is suggested to help the body rid itself of accumulated toxins so it can gain more benefit from various suggested measures of treatment.

In summary, Ayurveda addresses all aspects of life–the body, mind, and spirit. It recognizes that each of us is unique, each responds differently to the many aspects of life, each possesses different strengths and weaknesses. Through insight, understanding and experience Ayurveda presents a vast "database" of the relationships between causes and their affects, both immediate and subtle, for each unique individual.

Vata: The Energy of Movement

A person with Vata predominant is blessed with a quick mind, flexibility, and creativity. Vata provides essential motion for all bodily processes and is extremely vital for health. One purpose of lifestyle considerations is to “ground” or stabilize this motion. On an annual basis, Vata is most prominent in the fall and at the change of seasons, and these are the most important times to be careful of diet and lifestyle. Routine is very useful in assisting the Vata individual to effectively ground all this moving energy.

Vata types have variable appetite and digestion. They are often attracted to astringent foods like salad and vegetables, but their constitution is balanced by sweet, sour and salty tastes. Vata people tend to produce little urine and their feces are hard, dry, and small in size and quantity. Mentally, Vata people usually grasp things quickly but then forget them quickly. They are alert, restless and very active. They walk, talk and think fast, but are easily fatigued. They have less willpower and often feel unstable and ungrounded. They have less tolerance, confidence, and boldness. When unbalanced, Vata types have a tendency to become fearful and nervous, and may experience high anxiety. In the external world, Vata types tend to earn money quickly and spend it quickly. They are not good planners and as a consequence may suffer economic hardship. Vata resides in the colon, as well as the brain, ears, bones, joints, skin, and thighs. Vata people are more susceptible to diseases involving the air principle, such as emphysema, pneumonia, and arthritis. Other common Vata disorders include flatulence, tics, twitches, aching joints, dry skin and hair, nerve disorders, constipation, and mental confusion. Vata tends to increase with age as is indicated by drying and wrinkling of the skin.

Since the attributes of Vata are dry, light, cold, rough, subtle, mobile, clear, and dispersing, any of these qualities in excess can cause imbalance. Frantic travel, especially by plane, loud noises, continual stimulation, drugs, sugar, and alcohol all derange Vata, as does exposure to cold and cold foods. Like the wind, Vata types have a hard time becoming and staying grounded. Routine is difficult but essential if Vata is to be lowered and controlled. In general, people with excessive Vata respond most rapidly to warm, moist, slightly oily, heavy foods. Steam baths, humidifiers, and moisture, in general, are helpful.

Dietary guidelines for decreasing Vata

- 50% whole grains: whole grain cooked cereals, some bread, and crackers
- 20% protein: eggs, high-quality dairy products, poultry, fish, seafood, beef, tofu, black and red lentils
- 20-30% fresh vegetables with an optional 10% for fresh fruits

General Guidelines for balancing Vata

Pitta: The Energy of Digestion and Metabolism

Pitta people have many of the qualities of fire. Fire is hot, penetrating, sharp, and agitating. Similarly, pitta people have warm bodies, penetrating ideas, and sharp intelligence. But they can also become very agitated and short-tempered. The pitta body type is one of medium height and build, with ruddy or coppery skin. They may have many moles and freckles. Their skin is warm and less wrinkled than Vata's skin. Their hair tends to be silky and they often experience premature graying or hair loss. Their eyes are of medium size and the conjunctiva is moist. The nose is sharp and the tip tends to be reddish.

Pitta people have a strong metabolism, good digestion, and strong appetites. They like plenty of food and liquids. They tend to love hot spices and cold drinks. However, their constitution is balanced by sweet, bitter, and astringent tastes. Pitta people sleep well and of medium duration. They produce large quantities of urine and feces, which tend to be yellowish, soft, and plentiful. They easily perspire. Hands and feet stay warm. Pitta people have a lower tolerance for sunlight, heat or hard physical work.

Mentally, pitta types are alert and intelligent and have good powers of comprehension. However, they are easily agitated and aggressive and tend toward hate, anger, and jealousy when imbalanced. In the external world, pitta people like to be leaders and planners and seek material prosperity. They like to exhibit their wealth and possessions. Pitta people tend to have diseases involving the fire principle such as fevers, inflammatory diseases, and jaundice. Common symptoms include skin rashes, burning sensation, ulceration, fever, inflammations, or irritations such as conjunctivitis, colitis, or sore throats.

Since the attributes of pitta are oily, hot, light, mobile, and liquid, an excess of any of these qualities aggravates pitta. Summer is a time of heat, the pitta season. Sunburn, poison ivy, prickly heat, and short tempers are common. These kinds of pitta disorders tend to calm down as the weather gets cooler. The diet and lifestyle changes emphasize coolness-cool foods, avoidance of chilies and spices (especially difficult for New Mexicans), and cool climates. People with excessive pitta need to exercise in the coolest part of the day.

Dietary guidelines for Pitta

- 50% whole grains–whole grain bread, cereals, cooked grains
- 20% protein–beans (except lentils), tofu, tempeh, cottage cheese, ricotta cheese, raw milk, egg white, chicken and turkey (white meat), shrimp, rabbit, venison
- 20-30% vegetables with an optional 10% for fresh fruits

General Guidelines for balancing Pitta

- Avoid excessive heat
- Avoid excessive oil
- Avoid excessive steam
- Limit salt intake
- Eat cooling, non-spicy foods
- Exercise during the cooler part of the day

Kapha: The Energy of Lubrication

Kapha people are blessed with strength, endurance, and stamina. They have sweet, loving dispositions and are stable and grounded. Their skin is oily and smooth.

Physically, Kapha people tend to gain weight and have a slow metabolism. They shun exercise. They have thick skin and their bodies and muscles are well-developed. Their eyes are large, dark, and attractive with thick, long lashes and brows. Kapha people evacuate slowly and feces tend to be soft, pale, and oily. Perspiration is moderate.

Sleep is deep and prolonged. Kapha types are attracted to sweet, salty, and oily foods, but their constitutions are most balanced by bitter, astringent, and pungent tastes.

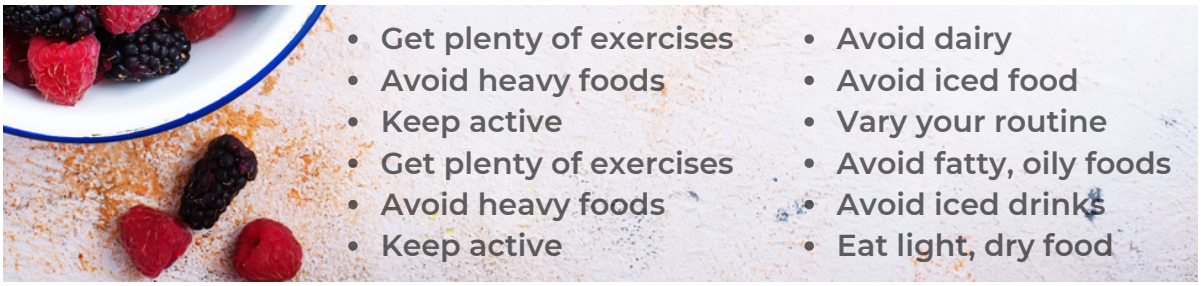
Psychologically, Kapha people tend to be calm, tolerant, and forgiving. However, they may become lethargic. While they may be slow to comprehend, their long-term memory is excellent. When out of balance, Kaphas tend to experience greed, envy, attachment, and possessiveness. In the external world, Kapha tendencies toward groundedness, stability, and attachment help them to earn and hold onto money.

They tend to have diseases connected to the water principle such as flu, sinus congestion, and other diseases involving mucous. Sluggishness, excess weight, diabetes, water retention, and headaches are also common. Kapha can become more aggravated as the moon gets full because, as biologists have discovered, there is a tendency for water retention at that time. Winter is the time of greatest Kapha accumulation and following the dietary and lifestyle changes are most important during that season.

Dietary guidelines for Kapha

- 30-40% whole grains: rye crackers, dry cereals, and cooked grains
- 20% protein: chicken, turkey, boiled and poached eggs, rabbit, a small amount of goat milk, and most beans (including garbanzos, adukis, pintos, black beans, red lentils, navy and white beans, split peas, and black eye peas)
- 40-50% fresh vegetables with an optional 10% for fresh or dried fruits. A daily salad is good.

General Guidelines for balancing Kapha



Remember that your progress toward balance and health is proportional to how well you stick to the guidelines of diet and lifestyle. Old habits sometimes die hard and your changes may be very gradual but, to achieve progress, the changes need to be made. You are in charge of your own rate of change.

If you wish to learn more about Ayurveda, see *Recommended Reading* section below. We highly recommend Dr. Lad's *Ayurveda: The Science of Self-Healing* for a conceptual understanding of Vata, Pitta, and Kapha. For guidelines and explanations about the Ayurvedic approach to food and healing, we also recommend Usha Lad and Dr. Lad's cookbook, *Ayurvedic Cooking for Self-Healing*.

Recommended Reading

Lad, Vasant. *Ayurveda: The Science of Self-Healing*. Lotus Press: Santa Fe, 1984.
Usha Lad & Dr. Vasant Lad. *Ayurvedic Cooking for Self-Healing*. The Ayurvedic Press: Albuquerque, 1994).
Morrison, Judith H. *The Book of Ayurveda: A Holistic Approach to Health and Longevity*. New York: Simon & Schuster Inc., 1995, A Fireside Book.
Svoboda, Robert E. *The Hidden Secret of Ayurveda*. Pune, India, 1980; reprint, The Ayurvedic Press: Albuquerque, 1994.
Svoboda, Robert E. *Prakruti: Your Ayurvedic Constitution*. Geocom Limited: Albuquerque, 1989.
Svoboda, Robert E. *Ayurveda: Life, Health and Longevity*. Penguin: London, 1992.
Frawley, David, and Vasant Lad. *The Yoga of Herbs*. Lotus Press: Santa Fe, 1986.
Frawley, David. *Ayurvedic Healing*. Morson Publishing: Salt Lake City, 1989.

The above books are recommended in the order of the simplest to the most complex, from those containing basic Ayurvedic knowledge to those with resource and reference information.

The Elements and Attributes of the Three Doshas

By Dr. Vasant Lad, B.M.A.&S., M.A.Sc.

VATA DOSHA Space and Air	PITTA DOSHA Fire and Water	KAPHA DOSHA Water and Earth
--	--	Heavy and Slow
Dry	Oily	Cold
Light	Sharp (penetrating)	Oily
Cold	Hot	Slimy (smooth)
Rough	Light	Dense
Subtle	Mobile	Soft
Mobile	Liquid	Static (stable)
Clear	-	Cloudy (sticky)
Dispersing (attribute, not guna)	Fleshy (attribute, not guna)	Hard, Gross (guna but not classical attribute)
Astringent, Bitter (taste)	Sour, Pungent	Sweet, Salty

Commentary by Michael Dick

What are elements and attributes and what do they have to do with the doshas?

The ancient seers asserted that only substance or matter can produce an effect. If you can experience something then this experience occurs because you have come in contact with substance or matter. These seers conceived of substance or matter as having five forms. Today we say these are the continuum between energy and mass. Ultimately everything is a form of energy; conversely, all states of mass have some form of energy. This is some of what is meant by the famous equation E = mc2 –that mass and energy are interchangeable.

The seers felt that there are five states they called Space or Ether, Air, Fire, Water, and Earth. These represent the five possible states of matter. We understand them as unique by the way we experience them; we use the terms “attribute” or “quality” to describe these states of matter. We know that fire is hot and that water and earth are cold. These attributes—hot, cold etc—describe the way we experience each of the pure types of elements. There is a set of attributes for each element. This is shown in the tables above.

The seers also declared that certain combinations of elements have unique physiological properties and functions in nature. Substances that are predominantly composed of Ether and Air have very dynamic properties and effects. These have come to be called “vata substances”. Some substances perform digesting, metabolizing and transforming functions and are called “pitta substances”. Similarly, kapha substances are composed of water and earth elements that have functions to support, lubricate, secrete etc. Knowing what elements a substance is made of is important to understanding the kinds of effects it produces. These effects are sometimes described in terms of the attributes. Thus, the elements and their attributes can help you to understand why a certain effect is produced. You can use this same logic to counteract an effect with substances or activities that contain its opposite attributes, bringing balance and health. Using the elements and their attributes in this way, we have a clearer understanding of the realm of cause and effect, anatomy and physiology, structure and function.

Guidelines for Determining Your Constitution

Instructions: To determine your constitution it is best to fill out the chart twice. First, base your choices on what is most consistent over a long period of your life (your prakruti), then fill it out a second time responding to how you have been feeling more recently (your vikruti). Sometimes it helps to have a friend ask you the questions and fill in the chart for you, as they may have insight (and impartiality) to offer. After finishing the chart each time, add up the number of marks under vata, pitta and kapha.

This will help you discover your own ratio of doshas in your prakruti and vikruti. Most people will have one dosha predominant, a few will have two doshas approximately equal and even fewer will have all three doshas in equal proportion. For instance, if your vikruti shows more pitta than your prakruti, you will want to follow a pitta-soothing regimen to try and bring your vikruti back into balance with your prakruti. If your prakruti and vikruti seem about the same, then you would choose the regimen of your strongest dosha.

OBSERVATIONS	V P K	VATA	PITTA	KAPHA
Body size	❑ ❑ ❑	Slim	Medium	Large
Body weight	❑ ❑ ❑	Low	Medium	Overweight
Chin	❑ ❑ ❑	Thin, angular	Tapering	Rounded, double
Cheeks	❑ ❑ ❑	Wrinkled, sunken	Smooth flat	Rounded, plump
Eyes	❑ ❑ ❑	Small, sunken, dry, active, black, brown, nervous	Sharp, bright, gray, green, yellow/red, sensitive to light	Big, beautiful, blue, calm, loving
Nose	❑ ❑ ❑	Uneven shape, deviated septum	Long pointed, red nose-tip	Short rounded, button nose
Lips	❑ ❑ ❑	Dry, cracked, black/brown tinge	Red, inflamed, yellowish	Smooth, oily, pale, whitish
Teeth	❑ ❑ ❑	Stick out, big, roomy, thin gums	Medium, soft, tender gums	Healthy, white, strong gums
Skin	❑ ❑ ❑	Thin, dry, cold, rough, dark	Smooth, oily, warm, rosy	Thick, oily, cool, white, pale
Hair	❑ ❑ ❑	Dry, brown, black, knotted, brittle, scarce	Straight, oily, blond, gray, red, bald	Thick, curly, oily, wavy, luxuriant
Nails	❑ ❑ ❑	Dry, rough, brittle, break easily	Sharp, flexible, pink, lustrous	Thick, oily, smooth, polished
Neck	❑ ❑ ❑	Thin, tall	Medium	Big, folded
Chest	❑ ❑ ❑	Flat, sunken	Moderate	Expanded, round
Belly	❑ ❑ ❑	Thin, flat, sunken	Moderate	Big, pot-bellied
Belly-button	❑ ❑ ❑	Small, irregular, herniated	Oval, superficial	Big, deep, round, stretched
Hips	❑ ❑ ❑	Slender, thin	Moderate	Heavy, big
Joints	❑ ❑ ❑	Cold, cracking	Moderate	Large, lubricated
Appetite	❑ ❑ ❑	Irregular, scanty	Strong, unbearable	Slow but steady
Digestion	❑ ❑ ❑	Irregular, forms gas	Quick, causes burning	Prolonged, forms mucous
Taste	❑ ❑ ❑	Sweet, sour, salty	Sweet, bitter, astringent	Bitter, pungent, astringent
Thirst	❑ ❑ ❑	Changeable	Surplus	Sparse
Elimination	❑ ❑ ❑	Constipation	Loose	Thick, oily, sluggish
Physical Activity	❑ ❑ ❑	Hyperactive	Moderate	Slow
Mental Activity	❑ ❑ ❑	Hyperactive	Moderate	Dull, slow
Emotions	❑ ❑ ❑	Anxiety, fear, uncertainty	Anger, hate, jealousy	Calm, greedy, attachment
Faith	❑ ❑ ❑	Variable	Extremist	Consistent
Intellect	❑ ❑ ❑	Quick but faulty response	Accurate response	Slow, exact
Recollection	❑ ❑ ❑	Recent good, remote poor	Distinct	Slow and sustained
Dreams	❑ ❑ ❑	Quick, active, many, fearful	Fiery, war, violence	Lakes, snow, romantic
Sleep	❑ ❑ ❑	Scanty, broken up, sleeplessness	Little but sound	Deep, prolonged
Speech	❑ ❑ ❑	Rapid, unclear	Sharp, penetrating	Slow, monotonous
Financial	❑ ❑ ❑	Poor, spends on trifles	Spends money on luxuries	Rich, good money preserver
TOTAL				

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Guidelines for Determining Your Vikruti (Current State)

Instructions: To determine your vikruti, base your choices on how you have been feeling recently. Sometimes it helps to have a friend ask you the questions and fill in the chart for you, as they may be more impartial. Add up the number of marks under vāta, pitta and kapha to calculate the ratio of doshas in your vikruti compared to your prakruti. For instance, if your prakruti is V2 P3 K1 but your vikruti shows a ratio of V2 P4 K1 this indicates high pitta.

This will help you discover your own ratio of doshas in your prakruti and vikruti. Most people will have one dosha predominant, a few will have two doshas approximately equal and even fewer will have all three doshas in equal proportion. For instance, if your vikruti shows more pitta than your prakruti, you will want to follow a pitta-soothing regimen to try and bring your vikruti back into balance with your prakruti. If your prakruti and vikruti seem about the same, then you would choose the regimen of your strongest dosha.

OBSERVATIONS	V	P	K	VATA	PITTA	KAPHA
Appearance	❑	❑	❑	Thin, bony, emaciated	Medium, intense	Large, sluggish
Weight	❑	❑	❑	Underweight	Steady	Overweight
Joints	❑	❑	❑	Cracking and popping	Tender	Swollen
Spine	❑	❑	❑	Scoliosis tendency	Kyphosis tendency	Lordosis tendency, slipped disk
Muscles	❑	❑	❑	Tremors, tics, spasms	Tenderness	Swelling
Skin	❑	❑	❑	Dark, dry, rough, scaly, liver spots	Yellow or red, rashes, pimples, acne	Pale, oily, smooth, swelling
Lymph Nodes	❑	❑	❑	Skinny	Tender, inflamed	Enlarged, congested
Veins	❑	❑	❑	Prominent, collapsed, empty	Bruises easily, moderate visibility	Full, wide, stagnant
Eyes	❑	❑	❑	Dry, restless, blinking	Red, burning, hypersensitive to light	Pale, swollen, sticky, excessive lacrimation
Ears	❑	❑	❑	Ringing (tinnitus)	Pain, infections	Clogged, discharge
Nose, Sinuses	❑	❑	❑	Dry, crusty	Red, inflamed	Congestion
Lips	❑	❑	❑	Dry, cracked	Red, inflamed	Pale, oily
Mouth	❑	❑	❑	Dry, receding gums	Red, inflamed and tender gums	Excessive salivation
Teeth	❑	❑	❑	Cavities, receding gums, cracked enamel	Yellow, wasted enamel	Sweet tooth, strong enamel
Tongue	❑	❑	❑	Dry, cracked, tremors, dark coating	Red, inflamed, yellow coating	Pale, thick white coating
Hair	❑	❑	❑	Dry, knotted, brittle	Oily, graying, bald	Oily, wavy
Nails	❑	❑	❑	Dry, rough, brittle, cracked, bitten	Soft, sharp, inflamed	Pale, thick, oily
Appetite	❑	❑	❑	Variable, anorexia nervosa	Strong, unbearable, hypoglycemia	Low, steady
Digestion	❑	❑	❑	Irregular, gas and bloating	Quick, acid indigestion	Slow, prolonged, indigestion
Metabolism	❑	❑	❑	Irregular	Hyperactive	Slow
Thirst	❑	❑	❑	Variable	Strong	Low
Elimination	❑	❑	❑	Constipation, dry, hard stools	Loose stools, diarrhea, burning	Heavy, oily stools with mucous
Energy Level	❑	❑	❑	Hyperactive, exhausts quickly	Intense, exhausts from excessive thinking	Low, exhaustion due to excess weight
Sex Drive	❑	❑	❑	Premature orgasm	Painful sex	Low libido
Liver & Spleen	❑	❑	❑	Palpable (double normal size)	Tender	Enlarged, fatty degenerative changes
Voice	❑	❑	❑	Dry, exhausted, explosive, whispering, stuttering	Sharp, penetrating, metallic	Deep, hoarse, drum-like
Speech	❑	❑	❑	Rapid, abrupt, unclear ideas	Sharp, determined, premeditated	Slow, monotonous
Breathing	❑	❑	❑	Nervous, diaphragmatic, (sympathetic nervous system)	Aggressive, intercostals, tight in chest	Slow, abdominal, apnea tendency
Allergies	❑	❑	❑	Dry wheezing, breathlessness	Hives, rashes, urticaria	Congestion, runny nose
Sleep	❑	❑	❑	Insomnia, broken	Difficult entering, insufficient	Excessive, drowsiness
Dreams	❑	❑	❑	Plenty, active, fearful	Fiery, violent	Watery, romantic
Emotions	❑	❑	❑	Anxiety, fear, loneliness	Judgment, criticism, anger, hate, jealousy	Attachment, greed, depression
Intellect	❑	❑	❑	Fast but faulty response	Abrupt but accurate response	Slow but exact response
Memory	❑	❑	❑	Recent good, remote poor	Moderate, distinct	Slow, remote very good
TOTAL						

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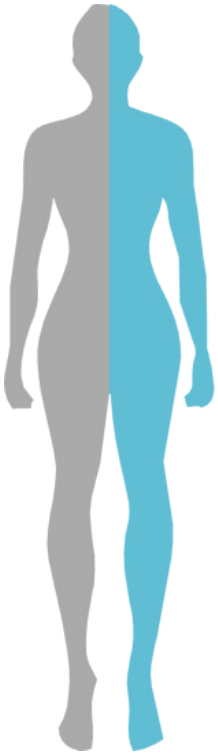
PART 3
YOGA FROM THE WEST

Anatomy

Asana and the modern body



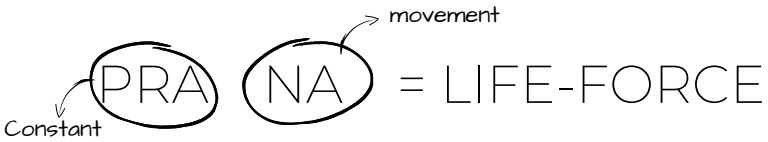
This section will focus on gaining a fundamental understanding of how āsana and pranayama relate to anatomy. To that end, we will look at how this science can help us to safely strengthen, cleanse, calm, open, and heal the body in order to prepare it to optimally pursue the outer limbs of the practice (concentration, meditation, & bliss).

Through this exploration we will better understand from a Western standpoint how the practice of asana and pranayamana, especially when practiced synergistically, can have such a profound effect on both body and mind. We will also understand how the structure and status of the human body enables or limits the expression of certain asanas, and how asana may work to change and enable the body.

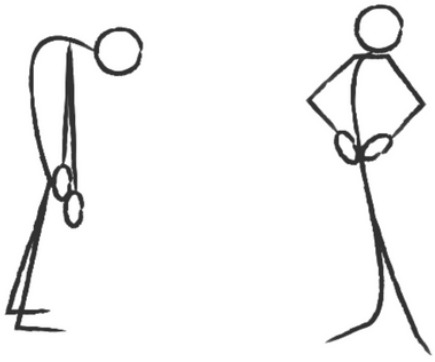
The discussion here is not intended in any way to diminish the validity or power of the place of asana and pranayama as it relates to the classical study of subtle energy, chakras, koshas, doshas, nadis, and beyond as laid out in the previous section. Nor is it intended to supersede the explanation of the rich benefits of the practice through the eyes of devotion or psychic development. This section is simply intended to provide a foundation to those who seek to understand, teach, and study from a Western as well as Eastern point of inquiry.

Prana in the Body

What is a body? How is it aligned?

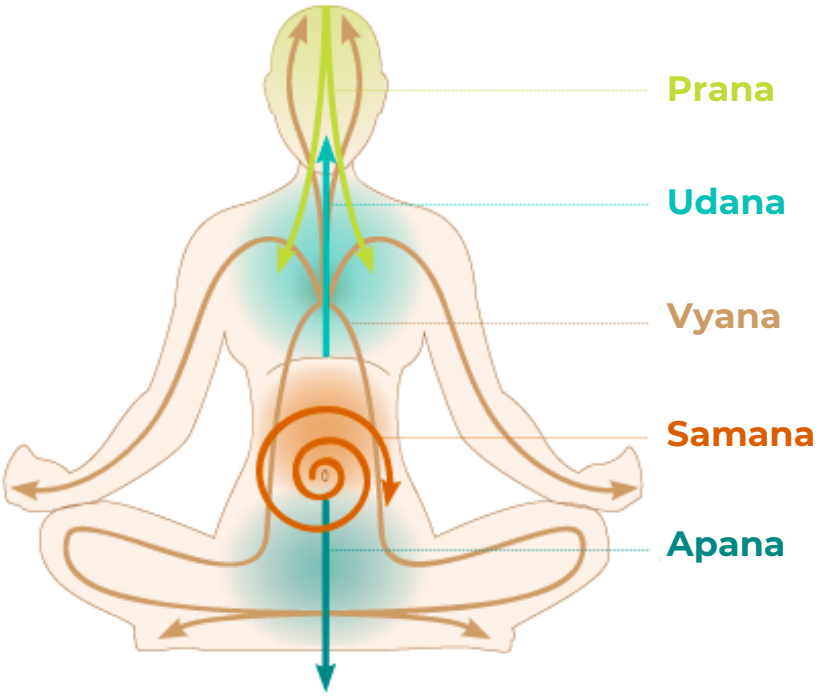


Prana can be translated from Sanskrit as “life-force energy,” “breath of life.” Prana is the primary source of our physical alignment. It regulates all of our conscious and unconscious bodily functions like our breath, digestion, blood flow, elimination, and cellular growth and healing. The flow of prana distributes its energy through the body based on the quality and capacity of the nadis energy channels and the chakras energy centers. Prana also animates and affects the quality of our thoughts, emotions, and consciousness.



Who is having the better day?

PANCHA* PRANA VAYUS



When we move Prana through the body, we instinctively realign.

Under the Skin

Bones:

Muscle:

Tendons:

Ligaments:

Fascia:

Systems:

*Pancha is a Sanskrit word that means “five.”

THE SKELETON

Axial vs Appendicular

Locations of the Body

Superior vs Inferior
Anterior vs **Posterior**
Medial vs Lateral
Proximal vs **Distal**
Ventral vs Dorsal
Superficial vs **Deep**

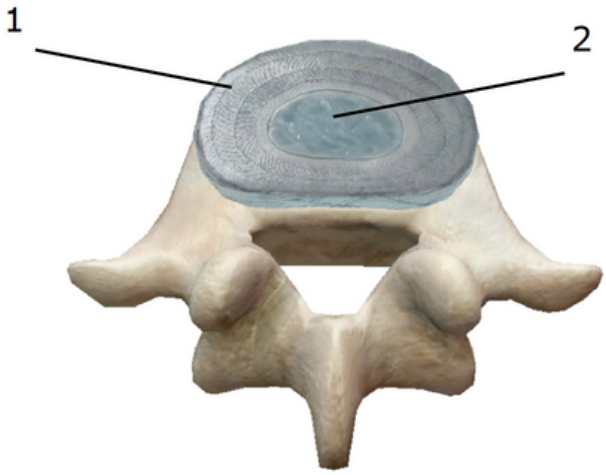
Three planes of motion

1. Frontal
2. Sagital
3. Transverse

Types of Movement

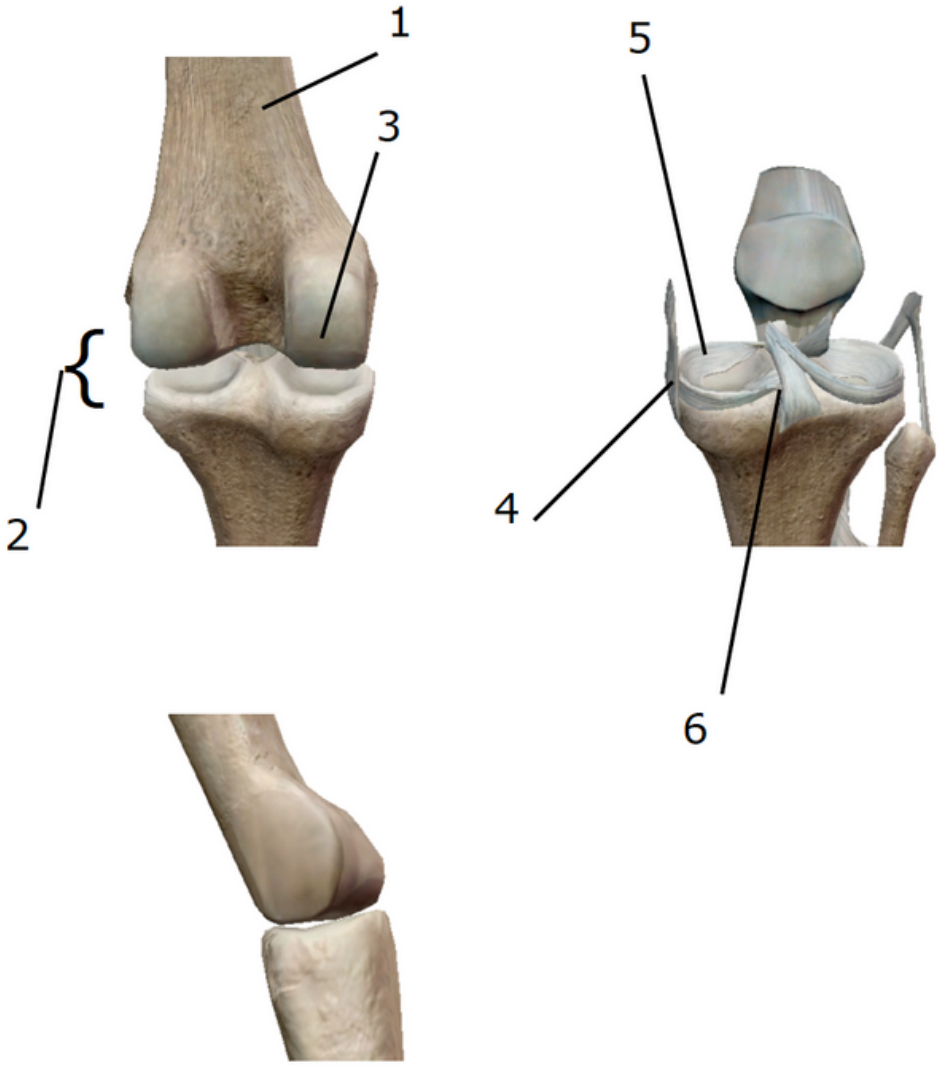
Flexion
Extension
Lateral Flexion/Extension
Abduction
Adduction
Rotation
Circumduction
Pronation - Eversion
Supination - Inversion
Plantar Flexion
Dorsiflexion
Elevation
Depression
Protraction
Retraction
Tilt

THE SPINE

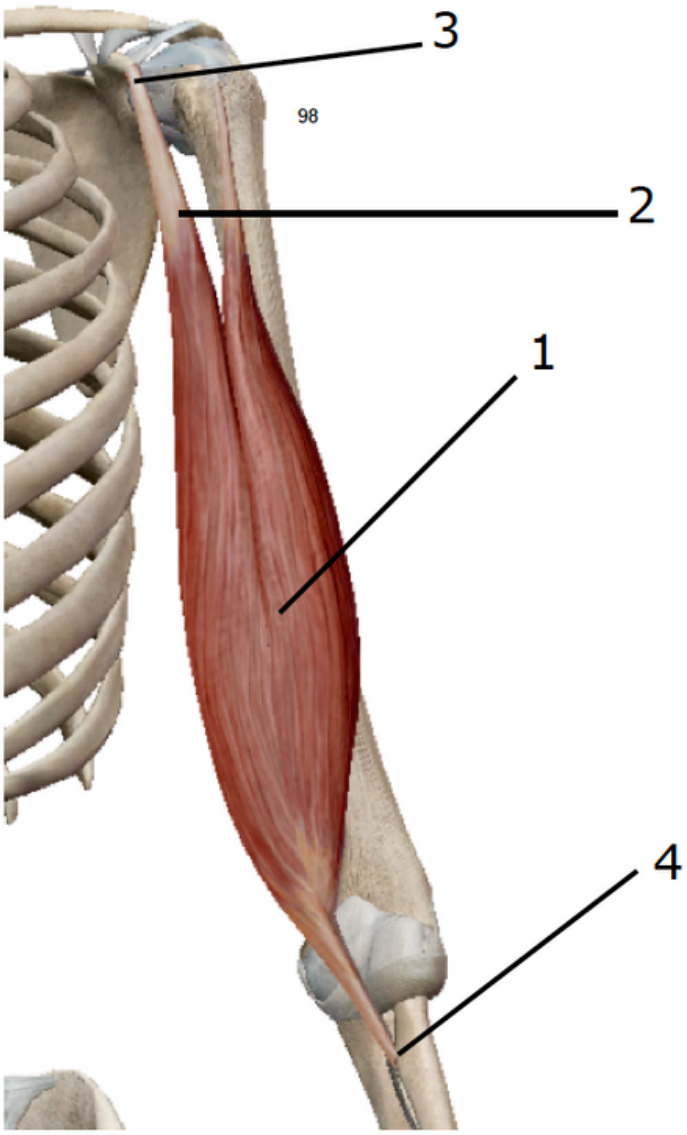


Bulging vs Herniated Disk

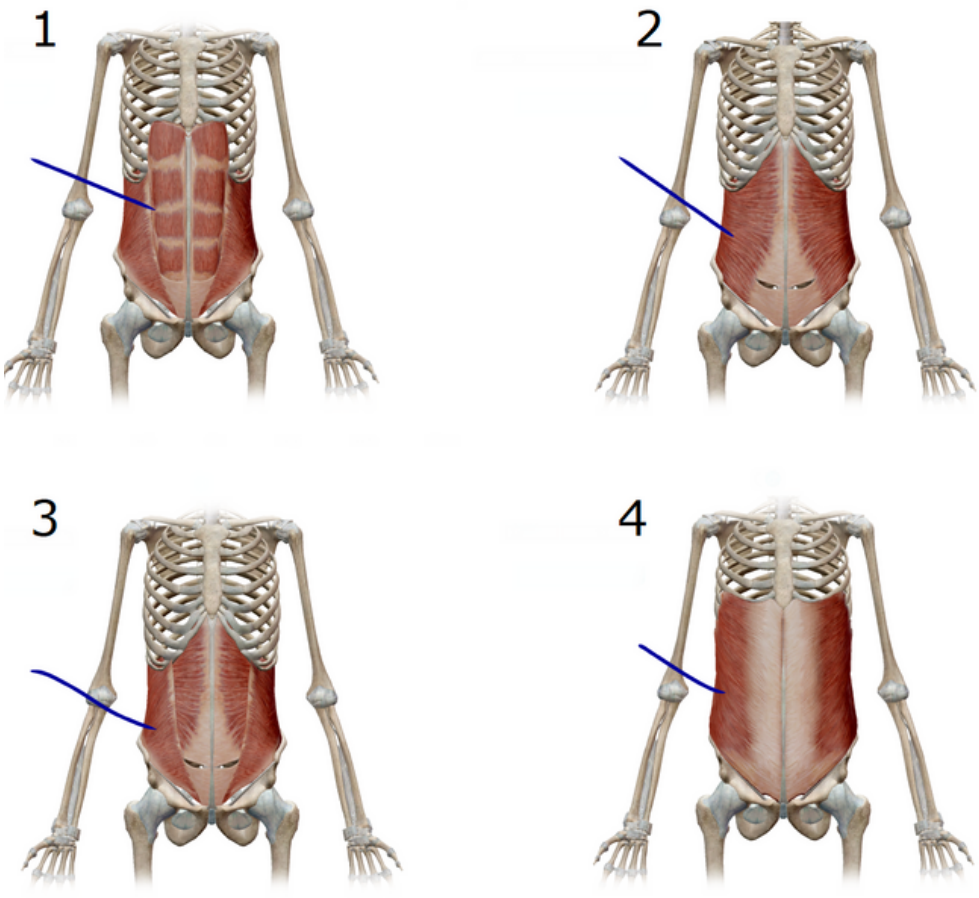
JOINTS



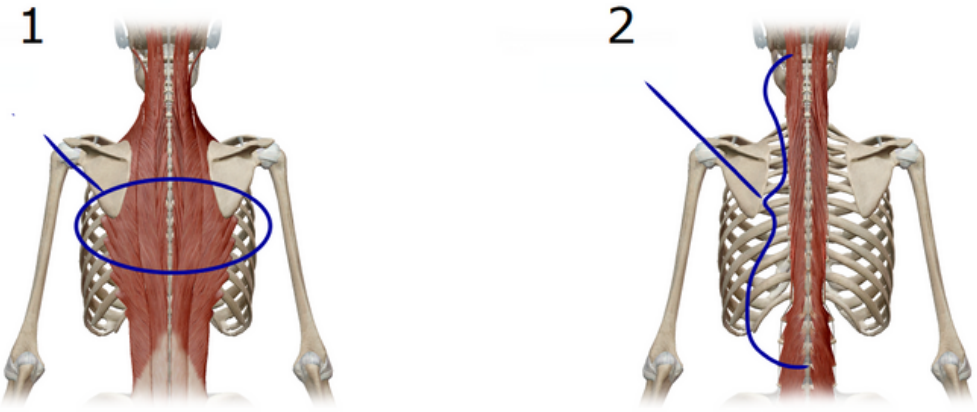
MUSCLES



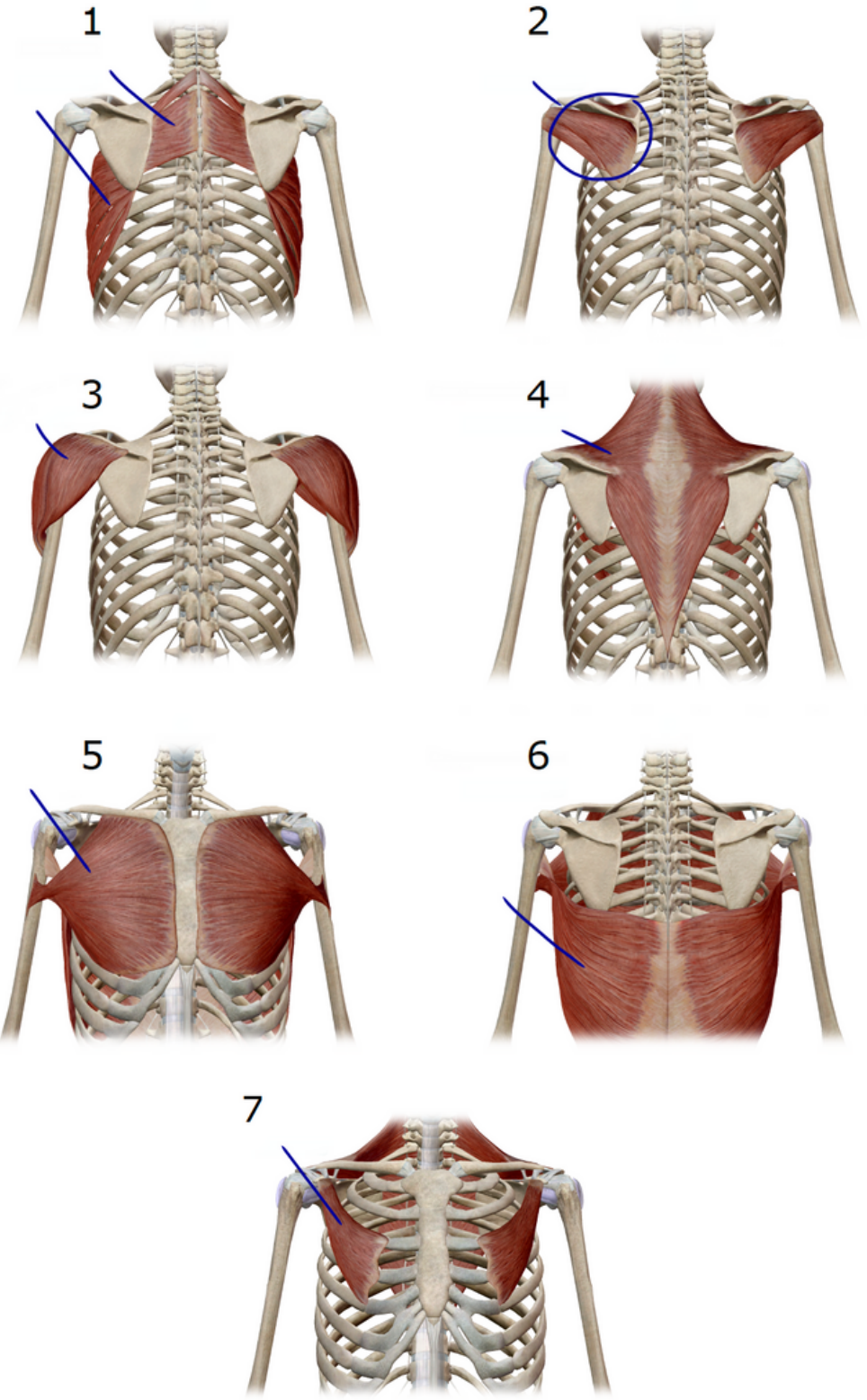
THE ABDOMINALS



THE BACK

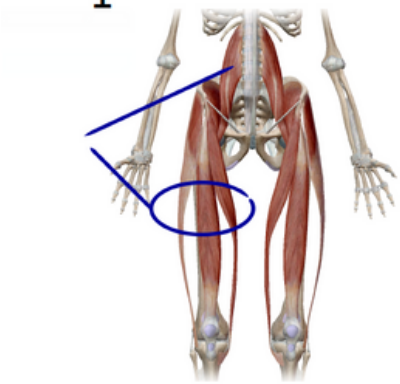


THE SHOULDER GIRDLE



THE HIPS

1



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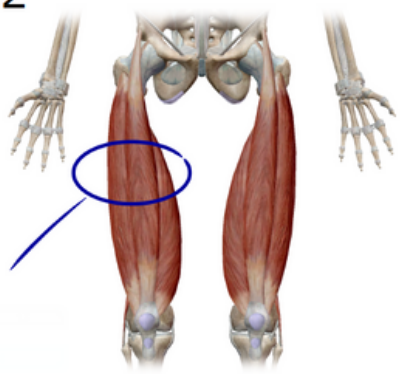

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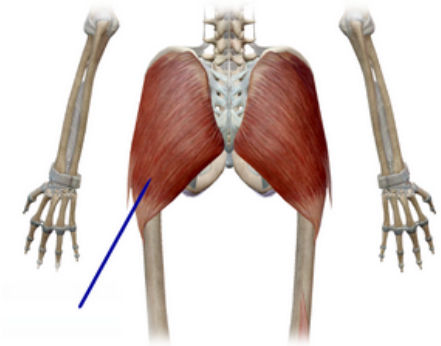

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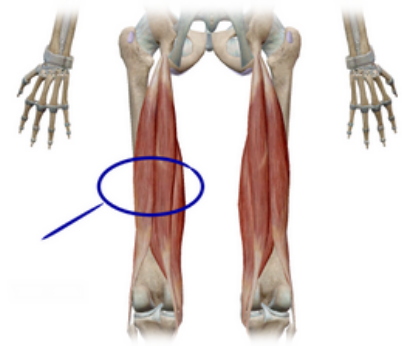

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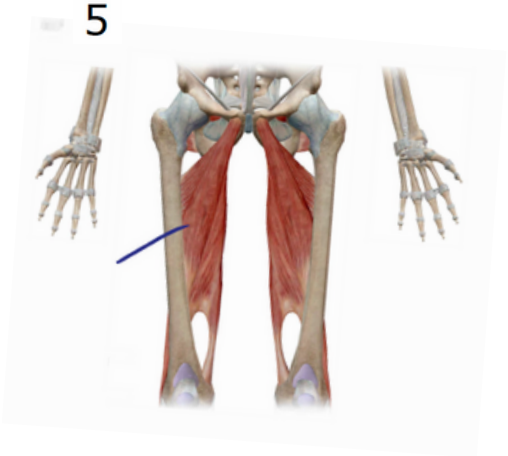

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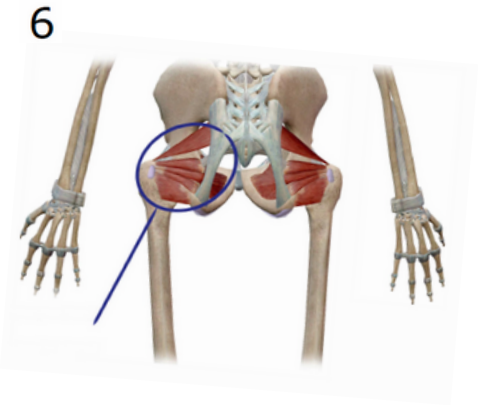

PART 4
ASANA

In this section, we divide postures into different categories and apply our knowledge of the modern body to these specific categories in order to get a better understanding of what is going on in the body while performing postures in each category. This will help deepen your understanding of the anatomical concerns, alignment points, and adjustment touch-points that are common to postures within the major categories of poses, starting with the standing poses.

ORGANIC ALIGNMENT THEORY

Aligning, Entering & Exiting Postures

Once we understand how to construct the bigger picture of the practice, we need to follow an approach to aligning the individual postures that furthers the overall purpose of the practice. To do this, we need to understand the relationship between alignment, anatomy, physiology, breathing, subtle energy, posture's purposes, and more. We have connected all of these elements in our extensive Organic Alignment Theory.

Organic Alignment Theory – Overview

With so much emphasis on the asana or "posture" element of practice these days, a great deal of time, energy and thought has been devoted to the optimal way to align the body within postures. There have evolved more than a dozen different major schools of practice, each with their own unique fundamental alignment principles. Often times one school's approach conflicts strongly, at least in language, with the principles of another school. Generally applied principles and complexity have also become the rule of the day, replacing intuition, perception, and breath and often being served up without reference to Western explanation or justification.

Organic Alignment Theory rises to the challenge of preserving and empowering the integrity of the subtle body practice, while simultaneously harmonizing it with prescriptions for alignment and movement that are defensible under the eyes of the Western exercise science microscope.

Organic Alignment Theory returns objectivity, education, safety and intuition to the process of alignment. At the same time, it provides strong Western and classical support for every principle offered. At the heart of the Organic Alignment, Theory is the understanding that intelligent and beneficial alignment for any posture should be an organic yet defensible process; a safe, dynamic, biomechanically informed and adaptive exploration that accommodates individual needs, deepens one's connection with the Self, furthers the purpose of the posture and the overall practice, inspires growth and builds upon the natural tendencies of the breath to emerge on an almost intuitive level. To allow all of this to happen, however, we need to cultivate a fairly substantial knowledge of the workings of the body as it moves through different positions.

Let's look at this broad framework in a little more detail before proceeding to specific posture categories and then to specific postures themselves:

Safety: every posture must be aligned to optimize biomechanical integrity both while in a static pose and while transitioning from one posture to another. Alignment during postural transitions is as important, if not more important, than alignment within the postures themselves. The best way to do this is to ensure that our embodiment of postures is informed by modem principles of biomechanics and kinesiology.

Informed & Purposeful: both teacher and student must know the posture's purpose or, minimally, the intent of the category of postures being offered. Only in this way can the teacher and student truly understand what is sought from each posture.

Adaptive: while it is possible to provide generalized biomechanical alignment principles for each posture, it is critical that these principles be dynamic enough to adapt to the individual needs, limitations, injuries, and abilities of the student. One day, a teacher came to us and said she was upset because she had been studying a specific school of alignment and, because of a recent unrelated injury, could not properly align the posture anymore. This person was very bright, and thoughtful and also happened to be an exquisitely accomplished asana practitioner. But somewhere along the line, her devotion to a school of alignment led her to feel like a failure for having to “mis”-align the posture to accommodate her injury. This type of dogmatic adherence to alignment without a foundation in individual intelligence is distressing. Alignment must always be adaptive and dynamic.

General Principles of Organic Alignment

- Build, cue, and adjust the pose from the ground up
- Always let safety reign over exploration or depth
- Give equal weight to the entrance and exit
- Allow the breath to govern pose intensity
- Create time for stillness and connectivity
- Make each practice a complete journey

Connected to the Five Energies of Nature

- **Earth (Ground):** grounding, finding roots, connecting, arriving
- **Water (Flow):** flowing, creating sukha (joy and ease), softening
- **Fire (Ignite):** power, finding the energetic center, core strength
- **Air(Breathe):** expanding the chest, lungs, and heart, making space for breath and prana to follow unimpeded
- **Ether (Open):** expanding, creating a powerful vision, a gaze point, internal contemplation, Samadhi, transformation

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Teaching Organic Alignment

Benefit/Purpose: the purpose of the pose
Foundation: the base, where the body meets the Earth
Set-Up: moving into the posture
Fine Alignment: refining & expanding the posture during the hold
Exit: moving safely and fluidly out of the pose

SURYA NAMASKAR
(SUN SALUTATIONS)

Surya Namaskar, or Sun Salutations, has roots in ancient practices from Bharata, the sacred name of India. There are numerous variations, but the purpose is the same. Traditionally performed during the sunrise, it is a moving prayer that activates major muscles and joints and can be performed 12 times daily to ensure vital health and spiritual well-being. Namaskar invokes a sense of having reverence or bowing down to the sun with gratitude. Surya Namaskar is based upon 12 movements that relate to the solar months and activates the inner sun.

The names are given in Sanskrit which is an ancient language that has been transliterated from the modern Hindu characters of Devanagari, which have a specific pronunciation. While you will not be required to learn the Sanskrit words for the postures, it is recommended.

For every Sanskrit word, there is a root word that you can look up in a Sanskrit dictionary. Some of these words are conveniently located in the glossary at the end of this manual or you can look them up at http://spokensanskrit.de

Benefits: while each posture in the Sun Salutation sequences has a specific benefit that will be highlighted in the detailed pages that follow, the full sequences also serve a number of bigger purposes. From a classical standpoint, the Sun Salutations are a meditative practice. Through gentle repetition of the sequences, the mind eases its way into a more centered place, leaving behind any agitations and preparing to approach the day to come in a more balanced fashion.

Biomechanics and Physiology: the Sun Salutations move all of the major joints of the body through many of their ranges of motion while using the muscles in a dynamic, rhythmic fashion. This helps lubricate and prepare the joints, increase blood flow to the muscles, warm the muscles and fascia, increase the heart and respiratory rate to deliver more oxygen to the muscles, and stimulate the nervous and endocrine systems to prepare the body for the potentially higher physical demands of the practice to come.

BREATH, MOVEMENT & SEQUENCING
SURYA NAMASKAR A (SUN SALUTATION A)

Inhale/Exhale	Tadasana
Inhale	Urdhva Hastasana
Exhale	Uttanasana
Inhale	Ardha Uttanasana
Exhale	Step back to Plank (Kumbhakasana) and drop the knees
Inhale	Kumbhakasana
Exhale	Lower modified Chaturanga Dandasana
Inhale	Lift to Bhujangasana
Or	
Exhale	Jump to Chaturanga Dandasana or step back and lower
Inhale	Urdhva Mukha Svanasana
Exhale	Press back Adho Mukha Svanasana (5 breaths)
Inhale	Look forward between the hands
Exhale	Prepare
Pause	Step or jump forward
Inhale	Lift to Ardha Uttanasana
Exhale	Uttanasana
Inhale	Urdhva Hastasana
Exhale	Tadasana

BREATH, MOVEMENT & SEQUENCING
SURYA NAMASKAR B (SUN SALUTATION B)

Inhale/Exhale	Tadasana
Inhale	Utkatasana
Exhale	Uttanasana
Inhale	Ardha Uttanasana
Exhale	Step back to Plank (Kumbhakasana) and drop the knees
Inhale	Kumbhakasana
Exhale	Lower modified Chaturanga Dandasana
Inhale	Lift to Bhujangasana
Or	
Exhale	Step through Plank or jump to Chaturanga Dandasana
Inhale	Urdhva Mukha Svanasana
Exhale	Press back Adho Mukha Svanasana (Right Side)
Inhale	Lift right leg up behind
Exhale	Step right foot to the thumb, bend the knee, drop the back heel
Inhale	Lift the arms over the head, Virabhadrasana I
Exhale/Inhale	Hands to the floor, either side of the foot
Exhale	Step back to Plank and drop the knees
Inhale	Open the chest
Exhale	Lower modified Chaturanga Dandasana
Inhale	Lift to Bhujangasana

BREATH, MOVEMENT & SEQUENCING
SURYA NAMASKAR B (SUN SALUTATION B) - Cont.

Or

Exhale	Step back to Plank, lower Chaturanga Dandasana
Inhale	Urdhva Mukha Svanasana
Exhale	Press back Adho Mukha Svanasana (Left Side)
Inhale	Lift left leg up behind
Exhale	Step left foot to the thumb, bend the knee, drop the back heel
Inhale	Lift the arms over the head, Virabhadrasana I
Exhale/Inhale	Hands to the floor, either side of the foot
Exhale	Step back to Plank and drop the knees
Inhale	Open the chest
Exhale	Lower modified Chaturanga Dandasana
Inhale	Lift to Bhujangasana

Or

Exhale	Step back to Plank, lower Chaturanga Dandasana
Inhale	Urdhva Mukha Svanasana
Exhale	Press back Adho Mukha Svanasana (5 breaths)
Inhale	Look forward between the hands
Exhale	Prepare
Pause	Step or jump forward
Inhale	Lift to Ardha Uttanasana
Exhale	Uttanasana
Inhale	Utkatasana
Exhale	Tadasana

TADASANA

Mountain Pose

Tad = Mountain | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Stand with the big toes touching, heels slightly apart, or with feet slightly apart. Connect through all four corners of the foot, and balance the weight evenly between the balls and heels of the feet. Press firmly into the ground.

Set-Up

Lift through the arches and inner ankle. Gently contract the muscles of the thigh (quads & hamstrings) and feel the knee cap rise and the knee joint stabilize. Engage the navel center, and keep the spine long and strong. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back, and draw them away from the ears. Extend the back of the neck and neutralize the chin. Gaze straight ahead.

Fine Alignment

Lengthen the body from the soles of the feet through the crown of the head. Lift from the sternum and extend the tailbone towards the floor. Reach down through the fingertips. Soften the rib cage into the torso. Breathe fully into chest.

Exit

Move in and out of this still, meditative standing pose with great awareness and consciousness.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

URDHVA HASTASANA

Upward Arms

Urdhva = Upward | *Hasta* = Hand | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Tadasana

Set-Up

Stand with the big toes touching, heels slightly apart. Connect through all four corners of the foot, and balance the weight evenly between the balls and heels of the feet. Press firmly into the ground.

Fine Alignment

Same as Tadasana. Retract the shoulder blades, turn the palms open, and gently circle the arms overhead with the palms facing each other, shoulder width apart.

Exit

Circle the arms down turning the palms in as you move through the bottom half of the motion.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

UTTANASANA

Intense Stretch Pose

Ut = Intense | *Tana* = Stretch | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Stand with the big toes touching or feet hip-width apart. Balance weight evenly between the balls and heels.

Set-Up

Draw the arches of the feet up, draw the knee caps up and contract the thighs. Draw the navel in and engage the hip flexors. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back and away from the ears. Gaze through legs. Hinge the body at the hips, tip the tailbone up and lengthen the spine. Enter into the fold consciously and soften the knees, if needed.

Fine Alignment

Reach the crown of the head down. Gently stretch the back of the body. Breathe deeply into a full and expansive chest.

Exit

On exiting, soften the knees, strengthen the abdomen and lift with the legs to avoid overexerting the lower back muscles.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

ARDHA UTTANASANA

Half Intense Stretch Pose

Ardha = *Half* | *Ut* = Intense | *Tana* = Stretch | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Stand with the big toes touching or feet hip-width apart. Connect through all four corners of the foot.

Set-Up

From Uttanasana, draw the navel in, keep the spine long and strong and the thighs engaged. Lift the upper body parallel to the floor with the hands gently supporting the shins.

Fine Alignment

Gently stretch the back of the body. Extend the crown of the head away from the tailbone and stretch the chest open. Soften the ribcage. Breathe deeply into a full and expansive chest. Keep a long neck.

Exit

When releasing from the prep into Uttanasana, be conscious to extend from the tailbone, hinging at the hips, and avoid rounding the lower back.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

KUMBHAKASANA

Plank Pose

Kumbhak = Breath retention | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Hands are shoulder-width; thumbs in line with the center of the chest, palms are flat. Line the wrist crease up with the front of the mat. Spread the fingers and press gently into the pointer and thumb. Do not collapse the wrists. Firmly press into the floor. The balls of the feet are hip-width apart.

Set-Up

Do not ever jump into Plank. Step consciously back from Uttanasana, and be sure that the shoulders are directly over the wrist. If moving forward from Adho Mukha Svanasana, be sure to keep legs firm, reaching heels back. If the load is too heavy and torso sags, drop knees.

Fine Alignment

Lengthen the body from the heels through the crown of the head. Lift from the sternum and extend the tailbone towards the heels. Spread through the fingertips. Soften the rib cage into the torso.

Exit

Lower the knees gently to the mat, keeping the navel drawn. Keep a slight pike in the hips, preparing for the next posture.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

CHATURANGA DANDASANA

Four-Limbed Stick Pose

Chaturi = Four | *Anga* = Limb | *Danda* = Stick | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Same as Plank. Hands are shoulder-width; thumbs in line with the center of the chest, palms are flat. Line the wrist crease up with the front of the mat. Spread the fingers and press gently into the pointer and thumb. Do not collapse the wrists. Firmly press into the floor. The balls of the feet are hip-width apart.

Set-Up

From Plank, press through heels or gently lower the knees to the mat for the modification. Draw the navel and ribs gently into the body. Draw the elbows in as you lower your chest to hover with elbows at right angles. Shoulders do not drop past the line of the elbow. Engage danda, with crown-head-heels in one line.

Fine Alignment

Lengthen the body from the heels through the crown of the head. Lift from the sternum and extend the tailbone towards the heels. Spread through the fingertips. Soften the rib cage into the torso. Expand the chest and avoid dipping shoulders as you lower.

Exit

See Upward-Facing Dog Set-Up.

Transition

Roll the toes under, draw the navel in, firm the thighs and lift the hips into the air, opening the shoulders into Downward Facing Dog.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

BHUJANGASANA

Cobra Pose

Bhujanga = Serpent/Snake | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Lie face down on the mat. Place the palms next to the chest with the elbows bent. Press the palms firmly into the floor, spread through the fingers, and gently press the pointer and thumb down. Firm the pelvis and lower abdomen on the floor. Engage tips of feet, shins, and pubic bone into the earth.

Fine Alignment

Gently contract the thighs and feel the knee cap rise. Reach through the toes, tops of the feet evenly pressing into the mat. Draw the navel in, firm the buttocks, and keep the spine long. Bring the shoulder blades down the back, and draw them away from the ears. Keep the elbows close to the body. Lift from the sternum and extend the tailbone towards the heels. Spread through the fingertips. Expand the chest and breathe fully into the heart center.

Exit

Roll the toes under, draw the navel in, firm the thighs and lift the hips into Downward-Facing Dog, or lie face down on the mat in prostration.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

URDHVA MUKHA SVANASANA

Upward-Facing Dog Pose

Urdhva = Upward | *Mukha* = Face | *Svana* = Dog | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Place the palms under the elbows. Line the wrist crease up with the front edge of the mat. Press the palms firmly into the floor, spread through the fingers, and gently press the pointer and thumb down. Press the tops of the feet into the floor. Do not allow the heels to sickle out to the sides.

Set-Up

Draw the kneecaps up and strengthen the thighs. Lift the torso and legs away from the floor by straightening the arms. Shoulders over wrists. Engage the navel center, and keep the spine long. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back, and draw them away from the ears. Extend the back of the neck and neutralize the chin. Gaze straight ahead.

Fine Alignment

Lengthen the body from the toes through the crown of the head. Lift from the sternum and extend the tailbone down and pubic bone forward. Spread through the fingertips. Soften the ribcage into the torso. Powerfully expand the chest and breathe fully into the heart center. Engage *uddiyana* bandha and mula bandha.

Transition

Roll the toes under, draw the navel in, firm the thighs and lift the hips into the air, opening the shoulders into Downward-Facing Dog.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

ADHO MUKHA SVANASANA

Downward-Facing Dog Pose

Adho = Downward | *Mukha* = Face | *Svana* = Dog | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

From Plank Pose, press the body into an inverted V shape. Feet are sitting bone width apart. Root the balls of feet and palms. Line the wrist crease with the front edge of the mat. Press the palms firmly into the floor, spreading through the fingers and gently pressing the pointer and thumb down. Do not collapsethe wrists.

Set-Up

From Bhujangasana, lift the hips back towards the heels, bend the knees, and lift the hips. If the hamstrings are tight, be sure to keep the knees bent, lifting from the navel center and lengthening the spine. From Urdhva Mukha Svanasana, roll over the toes and initiate the lifting of the hips with the strength of the navel center.

Fine Alignment

Contract shins and thighs, and draw the knee caps up. Draw the navel in. Rotate the upper arms out and the forearms in. Bring the shoulder blades down the back away from the ears. Gaze through the legs or to the navel. Extend the tailbone, and reach the sitting bones up and the crown of the head down. Engage your thighs and reach the heels towards the floor. Heels should be directly behind the toes, creating a slight inner spiral of the thighs. Breathe deeply into a full and expansive chest.

Exit

Soften the knees, draw the navel in and gently step one foot at a time, between the hands as you look forward

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

UTKATASANA

Fierce Pose / Chair Pose

Utkata = Fierce | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Stand with the big toes touching or feet hip-width apart. Balance weight evenly between the balls and heels of the feet.

Set-Up

Bend the knees and sit back as if sitting in a chair. Keep the knees behind the toes, aligned over the ankles. Lift the arches and inner ankle. Firmly press the knees together. Engage the abdominals and lift the pelvic floor. Keep the spine long. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back, and draw them away from the ears. Turn the palms open and bring the arms overhead with the palms facing each other externally rotating arms.

Fine Alignment

Extend the tailbone towards the floor and lengthen the lower back. Reach the arms up, lift through the sternum, opening the chest. Soften the rib cage into the torso. Breathe fully into the chest.

Exit

Stand gently, lowering the arms in preparation for the next posture.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

VIRABHADRASANA I

Warrior 1 Pose

Virabhadra = Name of Fierce Warrior | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Lunge Position, pivot the back foot, and drop the heel down to 45°. Align both heels, or allow the feet to be wider. Ground through the outer edge of the back foot. Lift the inner arch, lift the back thigh, and keep the front knee over the ankle.

Set-Up

From a lunge. Bend the front knee so that the shin is perpendicular to the floor and the thigh parallels to the floor.

Expansion

Draw the front thigh bone into the hip socket and wrap the hip back. Lift the back thigh and straighten the back knee. Engage the abdominals and lift the pelvic floor. Keep the spine long. Reach the arms up, lift through the sternum, opening the chest. Lengthen the back of the neck and neutralize the chin. Breathe into the chest. Avoid twisting the back knee while attempting to square off your hips.

Exit

When releasing the pose, slowly drop the hands to either side of the foot and connect firmly through the palms before stepping back to Plank.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

FOUNDATION STANDING POSTURES

Square Hips

Utkatasana (Fierce Pose)
Anjaneyasana (Low Lunge Pose)
Virabhadrasana I (Warrior 1 Pose)

Open Hips

Virabhadrasana II (Warrior 2 Pose)
Parsva Virabhadrasana (Side/ Peaceful Warrior Pose)
Parsvakonasana (Side Angle Pose)
Trikonasana (Triangle Pose)

Benefits

While each posture in the standing sequences has a specific benefit that will be highlighted in the detailed pages that follow, the full group of postures also serve an overall strengthening and active stretching purpose for the entire body, with particular emphasis on the lower body. They also open the energetic channels and increase the flow of energy within the body.

The standing poses build on the Sun Salutations by moving the body through fuller ranges of motion, deeper stretches, and more demanding leg-based strength postures. At the same time, they develop upper body awareness and work the stabilizing muscles of the core. Particular emphasis should be placed on maintaining proper knee alignment through the standing postures, especially when transitioning into and out of Warrior postures, to ensure the integrity of this critical joint.

It is important to have a healthy serving of Standing Poses for a well-rounded class and they should come after Surya Namaskar so that the body is warmed up. Also, as a general rule, standing poses should not be performed near the end of class, as they are too solar in nature. This will be discussed more in the next section, Forward Folds. If you can unlock and master the keys to these standing poses, all of the other postures will magically unfold effortlessly with regular and intelligent practice.

Standing poses can be organized into two main categories. The first category has squared hips with Utkatasana and Anjaneyasana. The second category has a hip opening and consists of Vira II, Parsva Vira, Parsvakonasana, and Trikonasana. When sequencing these standing postures, it is extremely important that you organize them accordingly, as going back and forth between these two categories can be very difficult, like grinding the gears of a stick shift without engaging the clutch. In other words, have fun with your sequencing, but be mindful to pair square-up standing poses with each other, and hip opening postures with one another. This will be discussed more in-depth during your sequencing lecture.

ANJANEYASANA

Crescent Lunge Pose

Anjaney = Hanuman's (Bhakti Monkey God) Mother | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Feet in a lunge, hip-width apart.

Set-Up

From Down Dog, bring the front foot just inside the same-side thumb. Bend the front knee directly over the ankle. Draw the thigh bone of the bent knee deep into the hip socket and wrap the front-leg hip back. Firm the muscles of the back thigh and rotate the back-leg hip forward. Engage the abdominals and pelvic floor. Lift the arms overhead, draw the heads of the arm bones deep into the shoulder sockets and drop the blades into the back.

Fine Alignment

Lift the back thigh up to stabilize the sacrum. Reach through the core of your back thigh to the heel. Release the hips evenly towards the floor, dropping the tailbone, and deepening the pose. Soften the back hip forward, opening the upper thigh and hip flexors. Lengthen the back of the neck and neutralize the chin.

Exit

When lifting into the pose, strengthen the abdominals. When releasing the pose, slowly drop the hands to either side of the foot and connect firmly through the palms before stepping back to Plank.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

VIRABHADRASANA II

Warrior 2 Pose

Virabhadra = Name of Fierce Warrior | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

From Downward-Facing Dog, step right foot forward between the palms. Drop the back heel to 90°. Make sure the front heel bisects the arch of the back foot. Inhale body up to stand. Hips open to the side of the mat.

Set-Up

Bend the front knee over the ankle and open the opposing hip away from that anchor, without pulling the front knee inward. Open the arms to shoulder height with palms facing down. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back and slightly depress them. Gaze to the front fingertips.

Fine Alignment

Remembering Tadasana in the torso, release the hips evenly down, drop the tailbone, and open the groin. Lengthen the spine. Reach through the fingertips. Soften the rib cage into the torso. Breathe fully.

Exit

When releasing the pose, slowly windmill the hands to either side of the foot and connect firmly through the palms before stepping back to Plank.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

PARSVA VIRABHADRASANA

Side Warrior Pose

Parsva = Side | *Virabhadra* = Name of Fierce Warrior | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Same as Warrior 2. From Downward-Facing Dog, step right foot forward between the palms. Drop the back heel to 90°. Make sure the front heel bisects the arch of the back foot. Inhale body up to stand. Hips open to the side of the mat.

Set-Up

See Warrior 2. Additionally, lift the front arm overhead and lower the backhand to rest gently on the thigh or calf. Do not place much pressure on the backhand, but rather, use it for gentle support. Expand the front side hip and fingers away from each other.

Fine Alignment

Bend deeply into the front knee steering the knee over the center of the foot, stretch the front side waist, withoutcollapsing in the back, reach thru the top arm but draw the shoulder blade down onto the back, look up or to the side.

Transition

When releasing the pose, slowly drop the hands to either side of the foot and connect firmly through the palms before stepping back to Plank.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

PARSVAKONASANA

Side Angle Pose

Parsva = Side | *Kona* = Angle | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

See Warrior 2.

Set-Up

From Parsva Virabhadrasana lift up and over and place your right forearm on the right thigh, extending through your side waist. Reach the back arm overhead, turn the pinky down and extend the arm over the ear. When transitioning from Parsva Virabhadrasana II, check in with the alignment of the hips and be sure the back hip is not shifting behind the midline of the heels. Also, pay attention to the front knee. Be sure that it has not collapsed inward.

Fine Alignment

Keep the shoulders moving down the back and lengthen the tailbone toward the back heel. Root the back edge of the back foot and stretch the body from that point through the top-hand fingertips. Gently open the chest keeping the bottom ribs soft. Breathe into the chest. If there is room, bring the hand to the inner or outer ankle for Utthita (extended) Parsvakonasana.

Exit

When transitioning back to Virabhadrasana II ground strongly through the back foot and keep the spine long as you lift with the back side body and reach through the back arm.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

TRIKONASANA

Triangle Pose

Tri = Three | *Kona* = Angle | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Front foot forward, back foot at 75°. Align the front heel with the inner arch of the back foot about 3 feet apart. Ground through the outer edge of the back foot. Front hand connects to the shin, a block, or a floor.

Set-Up

From Vira II (you may have to walk the back foot in), straighten the front knee and gently contract the quadriceps. Firm the muscles of the back leg, and lift the inner arch of the foot. Engage the abdominals. Lift the arms to shoulder height with palms facing out. Draw the arm bones into the shoulders. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back, and draw them away from the ears. Hinge sideways over the plane of the front leg. Bring the front hand to the shin or floor. Gaze to the top fingertips or straight ahead.

Fine Alignment

Draw the back hip open. Lengthen the spine. Reach the tailbone towards the back heel. Soften the rib cage into the torso. Gently rotate the chest open. Spread the arms reaching through the fingertips. Lengthen the back of the neck and neutralize the chin. Breathe fully into chest.

Exit

When transitioning back to Virabhadrasana II ground strongly through the back foot and keep the spine long as you lift with the back side body and reach through the back arm or transition to Downward Dog.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

FORWARD-BENDING POSTURES

Postures

Uttanasana (see Surya Namaskar A)
Padangusthasana
Parsvottanasana
Prasarita Padottanasana
Supta Padangusthasana
Janu Sirsasana
Paschimottanasana
Upavistha Konasana

Forward bending has the unique qualities of nurturing calming, safe energy within the body and activating the parasympathetic nervous system (PNS) or the "relaxation response" of rest and digestion.

The reason this relaxing energy is attributed to forward bends is that it emphasizes and enhances the primary curve, which is the same kind of shape found in the embryo. It's a familiar shape having practiced this way for about 9 months in the womb. In anatomical terms we call forward folds Hip flexion, also Nutation, or posterior pelvic tilt. Because the nature of forward-bending is more inward, the senses turn inward and bring us to a deeper sense of relaxation, effectively eliminating external stimulation.

In yoga, we always want to emphasize flexion primarily in the hips, with flexion following in the lumbar. Tipping the pelvic bowl forward, forward bends are performed with a lengthened, rather than rounded, lumbar spine and a very-intentional hinge at the hips. On an even subtler level, we lead the hinge by tipping the sacrum forward within the sacroiliac joint (nutation) and then tipping the entire pelvic structure forward, delivering the rotation into the hip joints themselves. This focuses the brunt of the stretch on the hamstrings and buttocks, rather than the often more “tweaked” muscles of the lower back.

Yogic forward-bending also relies on the use of the reciprocal-inhibition reflex, which releases the hamstrings and buttocks by contracting the quadriceps and hip flexors. Specific biomechanics points will be addressed in the individual posture.

Safety/Contraindications: In general, because we focus most of the stretch on the hamstrings, people with tight hamstrings will have trouble moving comfortably into a yogic forward bend without rounding the back. Two broadly applied modifications include gently bending the knees to slacken the hamstrings or using straps around the feet to draw the body in. Students with lower-back discomfort, pain, or disc injury will want to be extra-careful about not overloading the lumbar support muscles and possibly even avoiding anything other than very gentle forward bending. Reclined forward-bending, where the back is fully supported on the floor is often the best approach. More will be discussed in reference to the individual postures that follow.

PADANGUSTHASANA

Foot Big Toe Pose

Pada = Foot | *Angustha* = Big Toe | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Stand with the big toes touching or feet hip width apart. Balance weightevenly between the balls and heels.

Set-Up

Draw the arches of the feet up, draw the knee caps up and contract the thighs. Draw the navel in and engage the hip flexors. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back and away from the ears. Gaze through legs. Hinge the body at the hips, tip the tailbone up, and lengthen the spine. Enter into the fold consciously and soften the knees, if needed. Toe-lock.

Fine Alignment

Reach the crown of the head down. Gently stretch the back of the body. Draw the shoulder into the back, away from the ears, and use the arms, not the shoulders, to deepen the forward fold. Breathe deeply into a full and expansive chest.

Exit

On exiting, soften the knees, strengthen the abdomen and lift with the legs to avoid overexerting the lower back muscles. Inhale halfway, exhale and place the hands on the hips, inhale all the way up.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

PARSVOTTANASANA

Intense Side Stretch Pose

Parsva = Side | *Ut* = Intense | *Tana* = Stretch | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Stand with the feet about three feet apart. Align the inner heels, or separate feet enough for hips to square down. Turn the back toes in 60 degrees,both heels rooted to the earth.

Set-Up

Square the hips as you contract your quadriceps, drawing the front knee cap up. Slightly internally rotate both thighs; hands can cometo the floor or blocks. Join the hands behind the back and bring them to prayer or palm-to-elbows or interlace fingers. Draw the shoulder blades together and draw down. Hinge forward at the hip crease, tip the tail bone up, extend the sternum and create length through the spine without rounding the back.

Fine Alignment

Consciously square the hips as you lengthen away from them. Squeeze the shoulder blades together to expand the chest and shoulders fronts. Extend the back of the neck and neutralize the chin. Breathe deeply.

Exit

On exiting, soften the knees, strengthen the abdomen and anchor the back leg. Slowly raise the torso up.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

PRASARITA PADOTTANASANA

Wide-Legged Forward Bend Pose

Prasarita = Expanded | *Pada* = Foot | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Stand with the feet about 3 feet apart and parallel. Balance weight evenly between the balls and heels. Palms on the mat, face down, shoulder-width apart, fingertips in line with toes.

Set-Up

From standing, draw the arches of the feet up, draw the knee caps up, and contract the thighs. Draw the navel in and engage the hip flexors. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back and away from the ears. Open arms out to the side. Exhale, fold forward, placing the hands on the mat, palms down, fingers forward, shoulder-width apart. Gaze through legs. Hinge the body at the hips, tip the tailbone up and lengthen the spine. Enter into the fold consciously and soften the knees, if needed

Fine Alignment

Reach the crown of the head down. Gently stretch the back of the body. Breathe deeply into a full and expansive chest. Draw the elbows into shoulder width. Press the hands down and forward. Rock slightly out of the heels.

Exit

On exiting, soften the knees, strengthen the abdomen and lift with the legs to avoid overexerting the lower back muscles.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

SUPTA PADANGUSTHASANA

Reclined Big Toe

Supta = Reclined | *Pada* = Foot | *Angustha* = Big Toe | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Lie on back, fully extended,with head resting on floor. Deepen the back into the floor.

Set-Up (right side)

Bend right knee and toe lock big toe with right hand. Contract quadriceps, extend leg toward sky, making sure to keep left leg rooted in floor and reaching through the inner blade of the left heel and the right-leg in line with the body. Keep the tailbone lengthened. Reach the left hand down the left leg. Keep both sides of the sacrum grounded.

Fine Alignment

Gently draw the right-leg toward the head, using the arm and toe-lock. Continue to lengthen the left heel into the mat. Keep the spine long. Breathedeeply.

Exit

Soften the knee when movingout of this posture to accommodate tight hamstrings, glutei, and lower back muscles.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

JANU SIRSASANA

Head-to-Knee Pose

Janu = Knee | *Sirsa* = Head | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Sit on the floor with your legs extended. Bend one knee and allow it to fold out to the side with the sole of the foot on the opposite inner thigh. Hips are square.

Set-Up (right side)

Draw the right knee cap up, contract the thigh and flex the foot. Draw the navel in and engage the hip flexors. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back and away from the ears. Gaze over the extended leg. Hinge the body at the hips, tip the tailbone up and lengthen the spine.

Fine Alignment

Reach the crown of the head forward and place your hands around the right foot. Gently stretch the back of the body. Engage the arms to draw the body deeper into the pose. Keeping the shoulders pulled away from the ears. Breathe deeply into a full and expansive chest. Keep the shoulders parallel.

Exit

On exiting, be careful to soften the knees, strengthen the abdomen and lift by walking the hands along the floor to avoid over-exerting the lower back.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

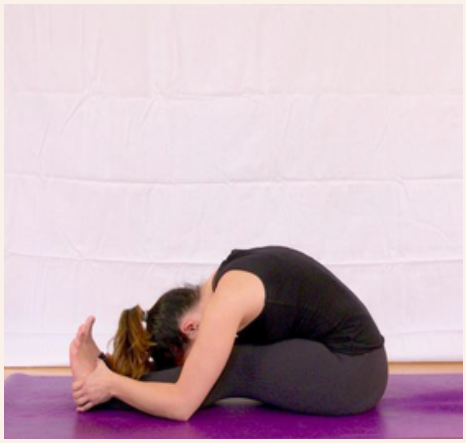
Modifications:

Bandhas:

PASCHIMOTTANASANA

Intense Western Pose

Ut = Intense | *Paschima* = West | *Asana* = Pose



TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

From Dandasana, sit on the floor with legs extended. The hips are square. Root sit bones into the floor.

Set-Up

Draw the knee caps up, contract the thighs and flex the feet. Draw the navel in and engage the hip flexors. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back and away from the ears. Hinge the body at the hips, tip the tailbone up and lengthen the spine.

Fine Alignment

Reach the crown of the head long and place your hands around your feet. Gently stretch the back of the body. Engage the arms to draw the body deeper into the pose. Keeping the shoulders pulled away from the ears. Breathe deeply into a full and expansive chest.

Exit

On exiting, be careful to soften the knees, strengthen the abdomen and lift by walking the hands along the floor to avoid over exerting the lower back..

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

UPAVISTHA KONASANA

Wide-Angle Seated Pose

Upavistha = Seated | *Kona* = Angle | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Sit on the floor with your legs extended and gently open the legs to the sides. Tip the hips gently forward. Root sit bones into the floor.

Set-Up

Draw the knee caps up, contract the thighs and flex the feet. Draw the navel in and engage the hip flexors. Bring the shoulder blades onto the back and away from the ears. Gaze through legs. Hinge the body at the hips, tip the tailbone up and lengthen the spine. Reach the crown of the head up and out and gently toe-lock your feet.

Fine Alignment

Engage the arms to draw the body deeper into the pose. Keeping the shoulders pulled away from the ears. Expand the chest and keep the spine long. Breathe deeply into a full and expansive chest.

Exit

On exiting,be careful to soften the knees, strengthen the abdomen to avoid over exerting the lower back. Avoid rounding the back, even if the chest stays high above the floor.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

TWISTING POSTURES & SEATED POSTURES

Postures

Supta Matsyendrasana
Ardha Matsyendrasana
Parivrtta Parsvakonasana
Parivrtta Trikonasana
Virasana

Benefits

General: Classically, twisting in yoga happens above the hips, which leads to a compressing and wringing quality within the cavity that houses the vital organs. Because of this, twisting postures are said to have a cleansing effect on the organs, literally wringing and flushing them from the outside-in. Twisting may also aid in digestion and constipation. It has even been argued that the compression may cause certain endocrine glands, like the adrenal cortex, which sits atop the kidney, to secrete additional hormones, balancing out the body's physiological systems (though there is no proof of this).

Key Muscles Stretched: Obliques, erectors, paraspinal, abdominals, shoulders, trapezius. IT-band

Key Muscles Strengthened: All above, plus rhomboids & hip-flexors Key Joints Articulated: Intervertebral rotation & often hip flexion

Biomechanics & Physiology: In yoga, we twist above the hips. This is accomplished by first stabilizing the hips so that they do not move, and then “stacking” the twist, vertebrae by vertebrae, from the base of the spine up to the top. Stabilizing the hips, though, can often be a challenge. When seated, we can use the floor as a brace to keep the hips from twisting along with the upper body, but when standing, we are forced to rely on our own strength, flexibility, and body awareness to accomplish the same stabilization. This is one of the reasons that poses like Revolved Triangle may feel substantially more demanding than a seated twist like Ardha Matsyendrasana.

Interestingly, too, many with the exception of some reclined twisting postures, where the muscles being stretched are relatively passive, most standing twists require that you contract the very muscles that need to be stretched to move into and deepen the twist. While this may limit the twist, it also plays a critical stabilizing role, to help limit torque on the intervertebral discs and may also trigger the clasp-knife reflex to allow the muscle to release over time.

Orientations: Seated, reclined, inverted, standing

Safety/Contraindications: Because twisting involves not just muscles, but a gentle torquing force on the intervertebral discs, extra caution should always be

SUPTA MATSYENDRASANA

Reclined Twist Pose

Supta = Reclined | *Matsyendra* = King of the Fishes | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Lie on your back, fully extended, with your head resting on the floor. Deepen the back into the floor.

Set-Up

Bend Right knee up to chest and cup outside of the knee with the left hand. Shift hips over to the side. Gaze right and draw right shoulder into the back body, rooting the shoulder into the ground.

Fine Alignment

Gently move right knee across the body to the left,twisting the torso. Use the left hand to press into the right outer knee, deepening the twist. Make sure the right shoulder remains rooted. Keep the spine long. Breathe deeply.

Exit

Ease the bent knee back to center, gently draw it in, and then release it back to the floor. Repeat on the other side.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

ARDHA MATSYENDRASANA

Half Lord of the Fishes Pose

Ardha = Half | *Matsyendra* = King of the Fishes | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Seated with left thigh outstretched, externally-rotated with the knee bent and the foot folded in toward the groin. Right foot crossed to the outside of left thigh on floor, knee straight up. Right-hand roots on the ground behind sit bones.

Set-Up

Sit tall, distributing weight evenly between both sit bones, contract hip flexors, and lengthen the spine. Hook left elbow around the right knee and draw knee upright. Press both sit bones into the ground evenly. Make sure the toe mound of the foot is grounded.

Fine Alignment

Rooting the sit bones, on the inhale lift, and lengthen the spine. On the exhale deepen the twist, drawing your right shoulder back and gazing over your back shoulder. Keep the torso vertical.

Exit

Unwind the pose slowly, giving muscles time to slowly release and re-lengthen.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

PARIVRTTA PARSVAKONASANA

Revolved Side Angle Pose

Parivrtta = Revolved | *Parsva* = Side | *Kona* = Angle | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

See Anjaneyasana – lunge stance.

Set-Up

While keeping the knee over the ankle, square the hips as you contract your quadriceps, and lengthen the back leg. Slightly internally rotate both thighs. Draw the navel in and keep the spine long. Bring hands to prayer, fold forward with a straight spine and wrap the opposite elbow around the front knee. Create a straight line from elbow to elbow and wrap the shoulder into the back.

Fine Alignment

Press the top hand into the bottom, moving the thumbs toward the sternum, deepening the twist on the exhale. Lengthen the spine and back leg with the inhale. Elongate the crown from the tail. If very open, drop the bottom hand outside the front knee to the floor and extend the top hand to the sky.

Transition

Exit by placing the palms on either side of the front foot and stepping back into Chaturanga or Downward-Facing Dog.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

PARIVRITTA TRIKONASANA

Revolved Triangle Pose

Parivrtta = English | *Tri* = Three | *Kona* = Angle | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

From Parsvotanasana, stand with your feet about 3 feet apart. Align the inner heels. Turn the back toes in 45-60°. Anchor through the outer blade of the back foot, both heels down.

Set-Up

Square the hips as you contract your quadriceps, drawing the front kneecap up. Slightly internally rotate both thighs. Extend arm diagonally across the body and opposite the front foot. Exhale and fold forward actively lowering the extendedarm to the ground with the palm on the floor outside the front foot.

Fine Alignment

Extend the top hand to the sky. Squeeze the shoulder blades together to expand the chest and shoulders fronts. Extend the back of the neck and gaze through the top hand. Breathe deeply. Continue to lengthen the spine on the inhale and deepen the twist on the exhale.

Exit

On exiting, soften the knees, strengthen the abdomen and anchor the back leg.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

VIRASANA

Hero Pose

Vira = Hero | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Shins.

Set-Up

Sitting on shins with knees together, heels outside of the hips and a block supporting your hips, draw the naval inward, bring your hands to prayer or keep them resting on thighs.

Fine Alignment

Slightly lengthen the tailbone and engage inner thighs.

Exit

Slowly fold forward to remove the block, rise to all fours or rest in child's pose.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

BACKBENDING POSTURES

Postures

Shalabhasana
Matsyasana
Setu Bhandasana
Ustrasana
Dhanurasana
Urdhva Dhanurasana

Benefits

General: Backbending is said to energize the body and make the mind more alert. Anecdotal experience seems to bear this out. The reason for this effect may be a stimulation of the energetic channels or nadis and a stimulating effect on certain chakras. See below for possible physiological explanations.

Key Muscles Stretched: Hip-flexors, abdominals, quadriceps, lats, pec minor
Key Muscles Strengthened: Quadriceps, lower back, buttocks
Key Joints Articulated: Hips, Sacroiliac, Lumbar/Cervical Vertebrae, Shoulder

Biomechanics & Physiology: All back bending involves one or both legs moving into extension and the lumbar spine moving into a certain amount of flexion or lordosis. Because, for the average person, the thoracic spine is capable of only 5 degrees of back bending, while the lumbar is capable of about 35 degrees, most back bending at the level of the spine comes from the lumbar area. This necessarily stretches the hip flexors (iliacus and psoas or iliopsoas) and lower abdominals and requires great care and significant strength to safely move into and out of the full range of backbends.

Bending the knee adds the quadriceps to the stretch and moving the arms overhead adds the lats, pectoralis minor, and rhomboid. These changes in the focus of the posture will be addressed more on the individual posture pages.

From a physiological standpoint, back bending compresses the organ cavity and may encourage hormonal secretion from certain endocrine glands. Also, from a nervous system standpoint, when the head is tipped back beyond the neutral position without support, this may trigger the sympathetic nervous system to stimulate the fight or flight response, increasing heart rate, sweat, alertness, and energy. The “exposed” nature of the body position may also trigger feelings of anxiety, vulnerability, and surrender.

Orientations: Upright (standing/kneeling), Seated, Reclined, Prone

Safety/Contraindications: Because the muscles of the core (abs & lower back) play critical support roles in back bending and they are often deconditioned and/or highly stressed, care should be taken in all back bending not to move beyond a point that these muscles can comfortably support. If a person has any pre-existing disc or back injury or pain, seek the advice of a qualified healthcare professional to aid in determining an appropriate approach to this category of poses. Always err on the side of being overly cautious, overly gentle, and increase intensity slowly and deliberately.

SHALABHASANA

Locust Pose

Shalabha = Locust | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Pelvis, lower abs.

Set-Up

Lying face down, turn the head to center, draw the shoulder blades together and down the back. Gently lift the upper and lower body, keeping the legs hip-width apart. Float the arms back and away. Pubic bone roots down.

Fine Alignment

Lengthen the body from the toes through the crown of the head. Lift from the sternum, smooth the neck and reach the crown of the head forward and upward. Expand the chest and breathe fully into the heart center. Allow the body to respond to the rhythm of the breath.

Exit

Place the hands next to the armpits and use the arms to raise and lower into the starting and ending positions.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

SETU BANDHASANA

Bridge Pose

Setu = Bridge | *Bandha* = Bind/Lock | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Feet, shoulders, back of head, upper arms, hands.

Set-Up

Lie on your back. Place heels a few inches from the buttocks. Feet hip distance apart and parallel. Lift the hips, leaving the shoulder on the ground. Reach the arms under the body, interlock the fingers and extend the arms to the floor. Walk the shoulder blades in and down the back and reach the hands gently toward the ankles. Draw the arches up and firm the thighs.

Fine Alignment

As the hips rise, lengthen the tailbone away from the torso and draw the pubic bone gently upward. Firm, but do not tense the buttocks and draw the shoulder more deeply into the back expanding the chest, and breathe fully into the heart center.

Exit

Lower gently, allowing the hands to release, the shoulders to expand and the back to roll down into the mat, inch-by-inch.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

MATSYASANA

Fish Pose

Matsya = Fish | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Glutei, forearms, hands, head, legs, heels.

Set-Up

Lie on the back, lift the hips and place the palms under the sit bones, face down. Lift your heart and slide your elbows underneath the torso. Draw the shoulder blades deeply into the back body, and walk the elbows in line with the sides of the torso.

Fine Alignment

Reach through the legs and toes. Expand the chest, release the head gently back, lengthen the neck, breathe fully into the heart center and gaze overhead.

Exit

Exhale, sliding your hands, shoulders, and elbows out and lowering your torso to the floor. Draw the legs into the body with bent knees.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

USTRASANA

Camel Pose

Ustra = Camel | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Standing on knees with shins parallel and toes pointed or toes tucked under.

Set-Up

Keep the thighs active or a slight inner spiral of the thighs. Engage the quadriceps, lengthen the tailbone and press the hands gently into the gluteus, while drawing the elbows in. Hips over knees. Release the head back only if there are no cervical issues.

Fine Alignment

Draw the shoulders deeper into the back body as you lift and lengthen the spine and expand the chest. Lift the ribs and lead the sternum toward the sky, supporting the back with the hands. If very open, move one hand at a time to cup the heels. Allow the head to gently release back and gaze up. Avoid shifting hips forward or behind knees.

Exit

Engage the navel to control the lowering and rising process. When coming out of the pose, tuck the chin, engage the thighs and core and use the arms to assist as you rise back to stand. If newer to the pose and still developing strength, gently lower your hips back into seat.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

DHANURASANA

Bow Pose

Dhanura = Bow | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Pelvis, upper-thigh, lower abs

Set-Up

From lying face-down, bend the knees and reach the hands back to cup the outsides of the ankles. Draw the shoulder blades into the back and draw the inner thighs hip-width apart. Lengthen the neck and soften the gaze forward. Keeping the knees at hip distance, press the feet into the hands, drawing the chest up. Shins move back as the heart moves forward.

Fine Alignment

Breathe fully into the heart center. Lengthen the tailbone down and draw the navel gently in to support the back. Allow the body to move gently up and down with the breath. Keep knees from playing apart.

Exit

Lower gently release the body into the floor face down and turn the head to one side.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

URDHVA DHANURASANA

Upward Bow Pose / Wheel Pose

Urdhva = English | *Dhanura* = Bow | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Feet and palms.

Set-Up

From Setu Bandhasana, lie on the back, face-up. Place heels a few inches from buttocks, hip-width apart. Place hands next to the ears, palms down, fingers facing the shoulders. Gently tuck the tailbone and lightly firm the buttocks. Point the elbows to the sky, slide the shoulder blades into the back, and press into the hands and feet lifting the body and extending both arms and legs. Keep the upper arms parallel. Place head on the earth first to adjust before going up.

Fine Alignment

Gently rotate the insides of the elbows to face each other, while pressing into the thumb and first finger. Press down with hands and feet and open the front body. Expand the ribs and chest and gaze gently downward.

Exit

Bend the elbows and legs slowly and draw the chin in toward the chest, while lowering in a controlled manner to the floor.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

HIP-OPENING POSTURES

Postures

Sukkhasana
Baddha Konasana
Eka Pada Rajakapotasana
Malasana
Utthan Pristhasana

Hip-opening in yoga is designed to create free motion and health in the critical hip joints, which often lose mobility and suppleness with age. It releases not only physical tension but also emotional tension and energetic restrictions. Similar to forward folds, they also activate the Parasympathetic Nervous System. It is common to experience emotional releases during powerful hip-opening sequences because unprocessed experiences and emotions are set to get lodged within this area.

The hips have six ranges of motion (flexion, extension, adduction, abduction, lateral and medial rotation), but when we think about hip-opening in yoga, we are usually talking about external rotation with a combination of flexion and/or abduction. The addition of the latter two will dramatically change the emphasis of the pose. External rotation with flexion, but not abduction (as in pigeon, where the line of the thigh extends straight ahead of the body) delivers much of the stretch into the piriformis, buttocks, and IT/ TFL band. Add abduction by moving the knee out to the side (as in bound angle) and the pose changes dramatically to slacken the muscles above a bit and refocus the stretch into the adductors or groin.

Safety/Contraindications

Many people have exceptionally tight muscles that limit the hip's ability to externally rotate. Driven by ego, though, many individuals will want to attempt to move deeper into hip-opening postures, i.e., get the knees closer to the ground or their front foot further out in pigeon, by trying to load the knee joint and take advantage of any slack it might have. This is a terrible idea because it places a dangerous amount of pull on the lateral collateral ligament and compresses the medial meniscus, both of which can tear. Be sure to adjust the knee angles and use any necessary props to reduce this pressure and ensure that the stretch is being delivered not into the knee, but to the muscles that support external hip rotation.

SUKKHASANA

Easy Pose

Sukkha = Easy/Light | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Sit bones, outer thighs, shins, feet.

Set-Up

Sitting with legs extended, bend both knees and fold shins onto each other with feet in line with knees.

Fine Alignment

Tip the pelvis up and slightly forward. Lift and lengthen through the spine and lay the hands over the knees. Allow the shoulders to sit gentlyinto the back.

Exit

Slowly unfold the legs and extend them forward.

Sukkhasana is a posture of ease and comfort. It can be any crossed leg that the student feels comfortable in. The spine should be straight and sitting bones grounded.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

BADDHA KONASANA

Bound Angle Pose

Baddha = Bound | *Kona* = Angle | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Sit bones and the outer edges of the feet.

Set-Up

Sitting, lengthen the spine. Tipping the pelvis slightly forward, bend the knees, draw the heels toward the groin and fold the knees out to the sides. Cup the feet with the hands. Move the shoulders into the back and engage the outer thighs and glutei to draw the knees gently toward the floor. Keeping a long spine, fold forward.

Fine Alignment

Press the feet firmly together, and continue to work your knees toward the floor. Feet should be open like the "book of life" they represent. It allows for a more externally rotated thigh and a more profound hip opening. Keeping the spine long and the shoulders retracted, hinge at the hips. Allow the spine to lengthen on the inhale and the pose to deepen on the exhale.

Exit

Draw the navel in and, using the arms to assist, move the torso back to an upright position. **Note:** This is a hip opener, not an ankle stretch!

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

EKA PADA RAJAKAPOTASANA

One-Legged King Pigeon Pose

Eka = One | *Pada* = Foot | *Raja* = King | *Kapa* = Pigeon | *Asana* = *Pose*

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Front-leg sit bone, thigh and shin, back leg thigh, shin, and toe-top.

Set-Up

From Downward-Facing Dog, sweep the right knee forward and lay it on the ground with the thigh parallel to the side of the mat with the heel in toward the groin. Lower the right hip toward the mat. Flex the front foot and keep a neutral ankle. Square the hips. Fold forward over the front knee.

Fine Alignment

Keep the back foot from sickling. Keep the weight shifted back into the hips and keep the hips balanced from side-to-side as your body releases into the pose. If very open, gently open the front knee to deepen the stretch. Do NOT do this if the sensation of stretch moves down into the knee. You may also turn the back toes under and lift the back knee.

Exit

Gently walk your hands back toward your hips, lifting the torso, while drawing the navel in to support the spine. Turn the back toe under, lift the hips and step into Down Dog.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

MALASANA

Garland Pose / Squat Pose

Mala = Garland | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Feet.

Set-Up

From Tadasana, step feet shoulder width apart and turn toes gently outward. With hands in prayer, sit gently back, lowering the hips to a deep squat. Lengthen the spine, lower the tailbone down, neutralize the chin and draw outer elbows to rest into the shins with the hands in prayer.

Fine Alignment

Keep the heart lifting and the hands moving inward, allowing gentle pressure against the legs to assist in opening the hips. Breathe deeply

Exit

Lower the hands to the floor and either forward fold or rock your weight slightly into the hands and step gently into Down Dog.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

UTTHAN PRISTHASANA

Lizard Pose

Utthan = Stretch out | *Pristha* = Back of the body | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Lunge.

Set-Up

From a low lunge, walk your foot towards the right palm, aligning the outer edge of your foot with the edge of your mat, comfortably widening your stance. Ground palms inside the right ankle. Send the left heel back and lift the left thigh up so the hips are evenly supported.

Fine Alignment

Squeeze the thighs toward the mid-line by engaging the inner thigh muscles. Lengthen your spine as you gaze down and not forward. Keep the belly from collapsing.

Exit

Slowly walk the foot back to the center, press into your palms, and pull from your belly back into Downward-Facing Dog.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

ARDHA HANUMANASANA

Half Split Pose

Ardha = Half | *Hanuman* = The Hindu monkey-god | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Low lunge.

Set-Up

From low lunge, shift the weight back placing the seat above the back knee. Extend the leading leg without locking the corresponding knee. Flex the foot and lengthen the spine

Fine Alignment

Lift the abdominal wall and pivot the leading hip back. Open the heart forward while maintaining length in the cervical spine.

Exit

Bring the weight back over the front foot to return to low lunge, and press back into Downward-Facing Dog.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

LEG BALANCING POSTURES

Postures

Vrksasana
Urdhva Prasarita Ekapadasaa
Virabhadrasana III
Ardha Chandrasana
Natarajasana Garudasana

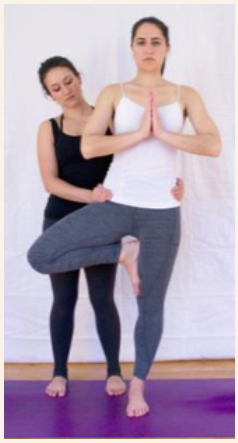
Leg balancing is about grounding and focusing. Shifting your weight into one leg is very strengthening for the ankles, knees and hips. This very challenging category of postures uses the drishti or gaze point as an essential element of the ability to cultivate the stillness needed to balance. In addition to stretching and strengthening specific parts of the body, leg balancing also challenges a person's approach to stress by placing the student in a very tenuous, high-intensity position and demanding extreme stillness and focus in order to stay there.

Safety/Contraindications: There are a number of reasons that leg balancing is so challenging for most people: (1) with only one foot on the ground, leg balancing provides the smallest foundation of any type of posture, (2) leg balancing works the deep stabilizing muscles of the hips at a level of intensity not usually experienced in daily life, (3) these postures also work muscles of the ankle and sole of the foot intensely, and (4) they demand extreme focus, a skill sorely lacking in many people in today's multi-tasking attention-challenged world.

VRKSASANA

Tree Pose

Vrksa = Tree | *Asana* = Pose



TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Tadasana.

Set-Up

Find your Drishti. From Tadasana, step feet hip-width apart. Shift the weight into the left leg, strengthen that leg and draw the arch up. Bend the right knee, turn it out to the side and place the sole of the right foot on the inner calf. If able, lift the foot up to the thigh, but not on the knee. There is a slight shift in the pelvis as it balances over one hip, but try to keep them as even as possible.

Fine Alignment

Bring the hands to prayer, lengthen the spine and activate the standing arch while relaxing the toes. Press the bent knee foot into the thigh as the thigh presses back in opposition. Keep the crown of the head rising, and recreate the feeling of Tadasana in the body.

Exit

Bend the right knee in, step it down and repeat on other side.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

URDHVA PRASARITA EKA PADASANA

Standing Split Pose

Urdhva = Upward | *Prasarita* = Expanded | *Eka* = One | *Pada* = Feet | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Standing leg, foot, and hands

Set-Up

Standing on one foot, lower hands forward to the mat and extend the non-weighted leg toward the sky, keeping the hips squared. Relax and then Engage the toes

Fine Alignment

Press into the inner blade of the standing foot. Draw the navel inward, lengthen and float the top leg up with the inhale, and draw the upper body deeper into the fold with the exhale. Wrap one or both hands around the standing ankle, if comfortable.

Exit

Slowly lift the chest and lower the leg back to the floor.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

VIRABHADRASANA III

Warrior 3 Pose

Virabhadra = Name of Fierce Warrior / *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Foot.

Set-Up

Find your Drishti. From Tadasana, step left foot 2 feet back into a very shallow Crescent Lunge with arms overhead. Soften the right knee and lean the upper body forward. Shift your weight into the right leg and step forward lifting the back leg and reaching the hands forward.

Fine Alignment

Flex the back foot, pressing the heel toward the back wall, and create a straight line from the heel to the fingers. Lower the left hip to the same plane as the right, squaring both. Lengthen with the inhales, keeping the torso from dipping.

Exit

Bend the right knee in, step gently back to a high, short crescent lunge, and then back to Tadasana. Repeat on the other side.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

ARDHA CHANDRASANA

Half Moon Pose

Ardha = Half | *Chandra* = Moon | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Foot, from Vira 2, Parsvakonasana, or possibly Trikonasana.

Set-Up

Press up to balance on your right foot, and press your right hand on a block or the floor, directly under your shoulder. The upper hip rolls on top of the right hip as you work to keep your standing leg neutral and avoid turning in the foundation foot. Avoid shifting the upper leg behind the pelvis and keep the upper leg from abducting past the top hip.

Fine Alignment

The back foot should be flexed to keep the quadriceps engaged in the upper leg. Imagine you are pressing it into a wall as you feel your crown move in the opposite direction. Focus can be down, side, or up. If you place the hand directly in front of your foot, it will make it more difficult to balance. Beginners should have a wider stance and move the bottom hand about 6-12 inches overfrom the foot to make room for the rotation of the hip.

Exit

Lead with your top arm to steer you back into Vira 2.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

NATARAJASANA

Dancer King Pose

Nata = Dancer | *Raja* = King | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Foot.

Set-Up

Find your Drishti. From Tadasana, step feet hip-width apart. Shift the weight into the left leg, strengthen that leg and draw the arch up. Bend the right knee, drawing the heel up behind you, and place your right hand around the right inner ankle. Extend your left hand to the sky. Press the foot into the hand, opening the back knee and moving the upper body forward.

Fine Alignment

Take the left thumb and the first finger to touch. Lengthen through the spine and chest. Rotate the right hip down to square with the left.

Exit

Bend the right knee in, step it down and repeat on the other side.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

GARUDASANA

Eagle Pose

Garuda = Eagle | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Foot.

Set-Up

Find your Drishti. From Tadasana, step feet hip-width apart. Shift the weight into the left leg, strengthen that leg and draw the arch up. Open the arms to the sides, then cross them over each other, left over right. Bend both elbows, lifting the forearms toward the sky with both palms facing out. If possible, draw the palms and let the right fingers catch the left palm.

Fine Alignment

Soften the left knee to 20 degrees. Lift the right leg, bend the knee and cross over the left thigh. If possible wrap the right foot around the left calf. Squeeze all joints and release into gravity, deepening the bend in the standing leg. Keep the elbows at shoulder height, keep the shoulders moving down the back, and spread the scapulas open.

Exit

Bend the right knee in, step it down, and repeaton other side.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

FOUNDATION INVERTED POSTURES

Postures

Sirsasana
Salamba Sarvangasana
Adho Mukha Vrksasana

Benefits

General: Inversions are considered among the most powerful category of asana. They are also considered among the most controversial. Inversions are generally defined as positions that place the head below the heart. A second factor is the placement of the feet. Generally, the further away from the floor the feet are, the most intense the effect of the inversion. The overall energy of this category of postures is highly focused, centered, and slightly invigorating.

Inversions are said to have powerful effects on the body's energy systems and may, in fact, produce far-ranging benefits from aiding in sleep to alleviating a variety of conditions and diseases. Headstand, the king of all asanas, is recognized as having the most powerful subtle body effects, as resting on the head strongly stimulates the crown chakra.

Biomechanics & Physiology: While certain postures that have an inversion- element to them, like Downward-Facing Dog, are generally considered safe for most people, other fuller inversions (where the feet and hips move overhead) may raise biomechanical and/or physiological concerns. The two main inversions discussed below and commonly considered the king and queen of inversions, Headstand and Shoulderstand.

Headstands require slow adaptation by the body to allow the blood pressure to stabilize gradually, thereby reducing the likelihood of a short-term increase in blood pressure in the head. They also require the development of significant upper back and shoulder strength to help share in the work of the inversion and distribute pressure away from the cervical spine. Finally, they require significant hamstring flexibility to allow the student to "walk" the hip slowly overhead in a controlled manner and lift the feet without kicking. Even when practiced in a deliberate manner and permitted time to develop the body to sustain the posture, there is still debate in the modern exercise community about whether this posture is appropriate. If a teacher chooses to teach this posture, they should make sure to become well versed in the considerations and concerns from both a modern and traditional yogic perspective. Because we consider full headstand to be an advanced posture to be practiced only by experienced students, you will only learn the considerably less demanding "prep" for a headstand in this training course.

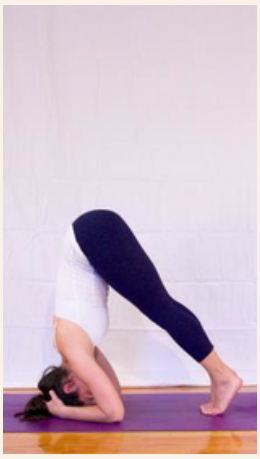
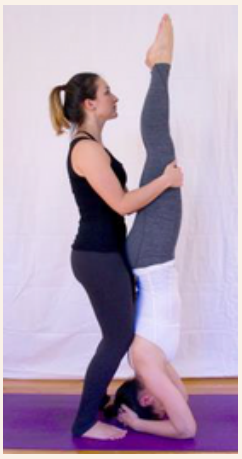
While ShoulderStand and plow raise similar issues with regard to blood pressure, the biomechanical concerns of this posture are different than in the headstand. In order to safely sustain this posture, the student must have excellent flexibility and strength in the muscles and ligaments of the upper back, shoulder and neck. Positioning the head and shoulders properly is critical in maintaining the safety of this posture and taking compressive force away from the cervical spine. Thus the recommendation for the use of blankets under the shoulders to distribute the weight back into the shoulders and away from the spine.

Regardless of the inverted posture, exceptional care must be taken in preparing the body to develop both the strength and flexibility to enter, hold and exit an inversion safely. We never kick or jar our way into any inversion, where the head or neck bears some of the weight of the inversion...EVER! We are reminded of A.G. Mohan's compelling reminder, "Our goal should not be to place our body in the position of an asana. Rather, we must seek to develop the strength and flexibility that will enable us to assume such a position. That is, the goal should not be the asana itself, but the attributes of physical fitness that are implied in the ability to assume that body position."

SIRSASANA/SIRSASANA PREP

Headstand / Headstand Prep

Sirsa = Head | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

outer hand, wrist, forearms, elbow, and crown of the head.

Set-Up

Kneeling, place your palms on opposite elbows, then lower the elbows to that to ensure proper positioning of the elbows. Cup the hands, lay them on the mat, and lay the back of the head into the cup of the hands, resting the crown of the head gently on the floor. Engage the shoulders and back, pressing the forearms into the floor to reduce pressure on the head. Turn the toes under, lift the hips and lengthen the legs. Walk the feet gently toward the head, keeping the shoulder and upper back firmly engaged and pressing into the mat to decrease pressure in the head and spine. Move slowly and deliberately, giving the body time to adapt to this inverted position. Headstand: If the foundation is stable and there are no contraindications, using uddiyana bandha move the knees into the chest, and slowly lengthen the legs overhead. Never jump or kick into this pose.

Fine Alignment

Lengthen the forearms away from the body, wrap shoulder blades on to the back, and engage upper back and chest muscles. Gently press down into the foundation. Draw the navel in to support the spine, and firm the thighs. If in the full pose, reach the legs overhead and point the toes up, remembering tadasana upside down.

Exit

Bend the knees and lower slowly back into Child's Pose.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

SALAMBA SARVANGASANA

Supported Shoulderstand Pose

Salamba = Supported | *Sarva* = All | *Anga* = Limb | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Back of the upperarms, shoulders and head.

Set-Up

Fold 2 firm yoga blankets into rectangles and lay them on the mats where the shoulder will be. Lay back, placing the shoulders and upper back on the blankets, with the blanket tops aligned an inch above the shoulder tops. Lay the arms by your sides, palms down, bend the knees in, press the hands down and begin to gently roll the knees in closer as you lift the hips toward the sky. Keep the blankets supporting the shoulders, but not the neck or head. Extend the legs, and bring the feet to the floor or a prop. Interlock the fingers, extend the arms into the mat and walk the shoulders in, taking the weight out of the head and neck. Tip the chin slightly upward to preserve the cervical curve. Bend the elbows, placing the palms into the back and, using the arms for support, gently extend one leg at a time toward the sky. Keep the weight distributed substantially back over the shoulders, instead of the head or cervical spine.

Fine Alignment

Keep a slight pike in the hips until you develop strength and flexibility and extend the body. Focus the Drishti through the feet and create a deep deliberate breath. Keep the head neutral, do not turn to either side. Ideally, the ankles, knees, and hips should be in one line.

Exit

Lower the legs, one at a time, or bend them and lower together, letting the knees come down around the ears. Lower the hands back to the mat, palms down. Lower the hips gently down, using the arms and core to control the movement.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

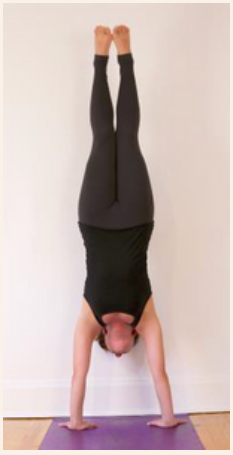
Modifications:

Bandhas:

ADHO MUKHA VRKSASANA

Handstand Pose

Adho = Downward | *Mukha* = Face | *Vrksa* = Tree | *Asana* = Pose



TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Hands/Downward-Facing Dog/Lifting one leg/Standing Split.

Set-Up

If you are unable to support a handstand in the center of the room, go over to a wall and make sure you have plenty of space, which includes being away from anyone that could crash on top of you while you are upside down, windows, sharp objects, etc. Use common sense when inverting. All of the foundational poses like Down Dog, Chaturanga, etc, should be mastered before attempting this pose. Shoulders need to be warmed up, and core and upper body strength need to be seriously prepared. Beginners should simply observe.

Fine Alignment

Facing the wall in downward dog slowly lift your right leg up, keeping the hips square. Slightly bend your opposite knee and lift from the opposite sitting bone as you gently float up and down getting a little air time.
Eventually float both feet up to the wall and scrub your feet up with your feet flexed. Gradually move one and eventually both feet away from the wall. Never kick into this pose, it should be performed with grace and control.

Exit

Downward-Facing Dog or Forward Fold.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

ARM BALANCING POSTURES & CORE

Postures

Navasana
Vasisthasana
Bakasana

Arm balancing postures are among the most challenging and complex postures in yoga. Because of their “weightless” appearance, they are also among the most dramatic. Arm balances have an energetic, yet focused energy to them. They draw upon the need to understand personal body geometry, build concentration, breath awareness, and balance, and then use all of these tools to attain the postures.

While this category requires the cultivation of calm and ability to focus, it does not require the same level of concentration as leg balancing for two reasons. One, the center of gravity in arm balances is generally substantially lower to the ground than in leg balancing, making the postures more stable. And, two, in leg balancing, we have only one foot on the ground, creating a very small base, while in arm balancing, with rare exceptions, we have two hands on the floor, creating, as the base, the entire area between the outside edges of the hands.

Arm balancing requires a combination of upper body strength and the coordination of bandhas, hip flexibility, and core strength. Arm balances are solar in nature, and cultivate confidence. Usually, beginner students will have difficulty with this category until they get strong. Anatomically men have an easier time with arm balances as the center of weight is in the upper body, and tend to have more slender hips, and women will be challenged because the center of gravity is in the hips and the fulcrum of weight needs to travel much further. Generally the longer the arms and legs in proportion to the torso, there will also be more of a challenge in terms of the actual physics.

NAVASANA

Boat Pose

Nava = Boat | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Seat.

Set-Up

From a seated position with legs extended, bend your knees and place the soles of the feet on the mat, rocking to the back of your sitting bones and balancing on your buttock. Before lifting your legs extend your crown up and back on the diagonal, by contracting the quads and abdominals. Slowly lift legs to a bent position, using the hands to press to the outer knees. If able, slowly straighten your legs as you created a "V" shape with your body, arms staying parallel to the Earth.

Fine Alignment

Draw the shoulders down the back, extend the legs, and gently draw the inner thighs toward each other.

Exit

Lower the legs, lie back and curl knees in.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

VASISTHASANA

Side Plank Pose

Vasistha = Most Excellent | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Plank.

Set-Up

From Plank Pose, widen the stance of your feet, as you lift from the navel supporting the "Danda". Keeping the tail bone extended to the heels and crown extending away from the pelvis, slowly pivot your heels to the right, pressing on to the outer blade of your right foot and the inner edge of your left foot. Stabilize your right shoulder and shift the weight of your body onto the right palm, centering the palm under the shoulder, elbow extended.

Fine Alignment

Draw both shoulders down the back and lengthen the spine. Engage the navel. Press the sole of the top foot toward the sky. Gaze up.

Exit

Plank or all 4's, then Child'sPose.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

BAKASANA

Crane Pose

Baka = Crane | *Asana* = Pose

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Hands.

Set-Up

From Malasana, place the hands on the mat, shoulder-width apart. Bend the elbows, and lift the heels and hips toward the sky. Lower the knees onto the upper arms and gently squeeze the legs inward. Rock your weight into the hands and lift the toes from the mat

Fine Alignment

Gaze slightly forward and down. Draw the navel in and engage the core strongly. Press the thumbs and first finger down to avoid collapsing the wrists.

Exit

Rock back into Malasana. Advanced – shift the weight slightly forward into the shoulders, lift the hips and step one toe down and step back or jump back into Chaturanga.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

PINCHA MAYURASANA

Forearm Stand (preparation)

Pincha = Feather | *Mayura* = Peacock | *Asana* = Seat

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Forearms, with elbows shoulder-width apart, toward the front of mat. Feet hip-width apart toward the back of mat. Seat elevated. On leg drawn up as in a Down Dog Split.

Set-Up

From Downward Facing Dog, lay forearms on the mat, keeping elbows shoulder-width apart. Palms remain flat to the floor with fingers spread, wide. Forearms parallel or bring one thumb and index finger over the same on the opposite hand, creating a 'V' shape with a forearm base. Walk feet as far forward toward elbows as possible, without shoulders moving forward of being above elbows. While looking toward fingertips, draw (rather than kick) one leg up. Using strength in the back of the body keep the leg up while rising onto the ball of the standing foot, pushing down from elbows to fingertips.

Fine Alignment

Keep the raised leg in internal rotation. Lift the navel up while continuing to look forward. Draw the shoulders down toward the hips as you rise higher on the ball of the standing foot. Keeping the "up" leg elevated, bend the standing knee to begin to explore springing up with that leg, on an exhale.

Exit

Slowly lower "up" leg, maintaining core engagement, on an exhale. Lay shins on the mat, unfold feet, and settle into child's pose, or sit upright.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

HALASANA

Plow Pose

Hala = Plow | *Asana* = Seat

TEACHING PROCESS/ALIGNMENT

Foundation

Shoulders, upper back, upper arms with hands supporting lower back, back of head.

Set-Up

Lying on your back, hug your knees into your chest, then lift your head and shoulders away from the floor and begin to rock back and forth gently. With momentum, catch hips in hands and place palms on either side of the spine with fingers outstretched, as the head settles back onto the mat. Let legs relax with bent knees being allowed to settle onto shoulders. Begin to walk hands toward shoulder blades while pressing chest to the chin, leaving jaw relaxed. Find the floor with your toes overhead, behind you, and start to press through the heels to extend legs.

Fine Alignment

Maintain relaxation in face, jaw and neck. Continue moving hands toward should blades to further straighten spine, which is ideally perpendicular to floor. Continue pressing through the heels and walking flexed toes back toward should to increase stretch in legs, rather than lifting up and tightening knees. Bind hands together and straighten arms, pressing pinky fingers into mat.

Exit

Relax legs, let knees drop toward shoulders, and return hands to the lower back to ease spine onto the mat. As legs settle toward mat, turn legs out and place the soles of feet together and let the bent knees open, with the outer blades of feet resting on the mat, as in a supine bound angle pose. Place hands on the belly, and lengthen back of the neck.

Functional Benefits

- Stretched:
- Strengthened:
- Intensity:

Subtle Energy Benefits:

Counterposes:

Preparatory Poses:

Contraindications:

Modifications:

Bandhas:

PART 5

YOGA IN THE STUDIO AND BEYOND

Planning & Sequencing,
Private Clients
and the Business of Yoga

GENERAL CONTRAINDICATIONS & PRECAUTIONS

Certain postures, *vinyasa*, or categories of postures may be modified or omitted from yoga practice to better accommodate students with certain conditions. Below is a non-exhaustive list to guide your efforts. In general, tell students NOT to do anything that causes any genuine pain or discomfort in joints or muscles and to modify postures appropriately, so as to eliminate discomfort or pain.

Yoga teachers are NOT doctors! Do not, under any circumstances, render medical advice or claim that you are qualified to do so! Medical conditions must be diagnosed and treated by qualified healthcare professionals or physicians. If you have any questions about whether anything is appropriate or not for a student, always refer them back to their physician.

Special Conditions, Illnesses, Injuries & Limitations

Sciatica

This inflammation of the sciatic nerve may come from compression at either the level of the spine or the hip. The nerve runs between the piriformis muscle and the femur, making it subject to compression when forward bending with closed legs if an individual has an overly tight piriformis muscle. Minimize time in forward-bending postures with knees close together and keep knees bent. May slightly widen stance. Once no longer symptomatic, certain backbends or hip-openers may help alleviate pressure on the sciatic nerve over time. First no pain, then minimize close-legged forward bending, pigeon/fig 4.

Hypertension (High Blood Pressure)

Avoid holding your breath or performing inverted postures. Minimally, modify inversions, if possible, to bring the head above the heart. Postures to avoid or modify include shoulder stand, plow, headstand, and handstand and modifications may also be made to partially-inverted postures, such as a Downward-Facing Dog or Wide-Legged Standing Forward Bend.

Arthritis

Very gentle, pain-free movement.

Hypotension/Low Blood Pressure

Avoid quick movement that elevates the head above the heart, which may result in loss of consciousness.

Pregnancy
First trimester – no jumping, second & third, no supine, and no direct pressure on the middle. There are many modifications that may be made as pregnancy progresses. From a modern standpoint, the practice should be adapted to comply with the guidelines for exercise during pregnancy established by the American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists (www.acog.org). To fully cover this topic is beyond the scope of this training. For those who seek to work extensively with pregnant women, we strongly recommend specialized training for prenatal yoga.

Menstruation
Do what feels appropriate to you – issue: retrograde flow.

Congestion in Head, Nose, Ears/Glaucoma or Eye Conditions

Osteoporosis
Weight-bearing element, no jumping/jarring motions, stable.

Carpal Tunnel
Pressure on the median nerve—stretch the front of hands (Prayer)

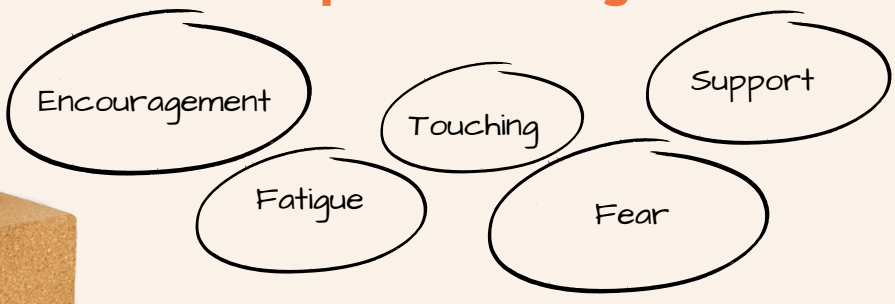
Low Back Pain
First, no pain. Keep a bend in knees during forwarding bending and try to keep the spine in the most neutral position possible. Keep abdominal muscles contracted to help support muscles in the lumbar spine.

Neck/Upper Back Pain or Condition
Avoid inverted postures. Maintain a neutral spine and head position in all postures and do not place excessive pressure or weight on the head or neck. Modify or eliminate postures to maintain a safe practice experience.

FUNDAMENTALS

In this section, we look at the unique challenges of teaching yoga, mainly asana but also basic pranayama, to absolute beginners.

Issues Specific to Beginners



Challenges Specific to Beginners

LACK OF STRENGTH	LACK OF FLEXIBILITY	TENSION
CORE	HAMSTRINGS	JAW/NECK
ARMS	SHOULDERS	SHOULDERS
LEGS	HIPS	HIPS
WRISTS	ANKLES	HANDS
ANKLES	WRISTS	FEET

Misconceptions:

Expectations:

- **Demo:** When to, when not to, and why?

- **Cues:** Actions versus making shapes

- **Props:** Use of blocks, straps, blanket, wall

VINYASA KRAMA

PRINCIPLES OF SEQUENCING FULL CLASS

Big picture purposes of the practice

Heal, strengthen and cleanse body, energy & psychic systems

Eastern Karma

Science of optimal sequencing—stages, waves, cycles—prepare and deliver an intended energetic effect optimally

Western Therapeutic

Move all parts through all ranges passively and actively, elevate core temp and heart rate, strengthen and stretch all parts of the body, increase lymphatic flow

Big Picture: How to arrange the major categories of activities within a single practice

Elements to consider including:

- Intro
- Warm Up
- Theme
- Standing Postures
- Forward Bending
- Back Bending
- Twisting
- Hip-opening
- Core
- Leg-balancing
- Arm-balancing
- Inversions
- Pranayama
- Meditation
- Chanting
- Savasana
- Discussion/scripture study
- Shape & meaning of curve
- Determining when to peak
- Considering class duration in shaping the curve
- Placing the elements under the curve to be optimally effective
- Considering the time of day and activities to follow the practice

Sequencing Specific Postures within Category Groups

- Start each sequence or category with simple postures and movement and slowly progress to increasingly complex ones
- Start each sequence or category with lower-intensity postures and movement and slowly progress to increasingly demanding ones
- Start each sequence or category with postures that do not demand substantial flexibility and movement and slowly progress to increasingly flexibility-oriented ones/variations
- Prepare the body incrementally for a more demanding “peak” postures
- Use counter & neutralizing poses and sequences
- Use highly-adaptable postures

Working with energy

- Adapting the flow on the fly to accommodate the experience and energy of the room
- Using the pace and holds to massage intensity

Sequences by Cycles Grid

	Class Preparation
Date/Time/Season	
Length	
Place	
Student/Demographic	
Practice Level	
Theme/Purpose	
Bhava (mood)	
	Class Opening
Intro	
Discussion/Reading	
Chant	
Mudra	
Pranayama	
Meditation	
	Body of Class / Asana Sequence
Warm Up	
Sun Salutations	
1st Standing Cycle Standing / Arm Balances	

Sequences by Cycles Grid (Cont'd)

	Body of Class /Asana Sequence
2nd Standing Cycle Standing Poses Leg/Arm Balances	
3rd Standing Cycle Standing Poses Leg/Arm Balances	
1st Seated Cycle Hip Openers, Backbends, Forward Bends, Twists	
2nd Seated Cycle Hip Openers, Backbends, Forward Bends, Twists	
Finishing Cycle Core, Inversion, Finishing Poses	
	Class Closing
Savasana	
Pranayama	
Meditation	
Discussion / Reading	
Mudra	
Chant	

Sequences by Category Grid

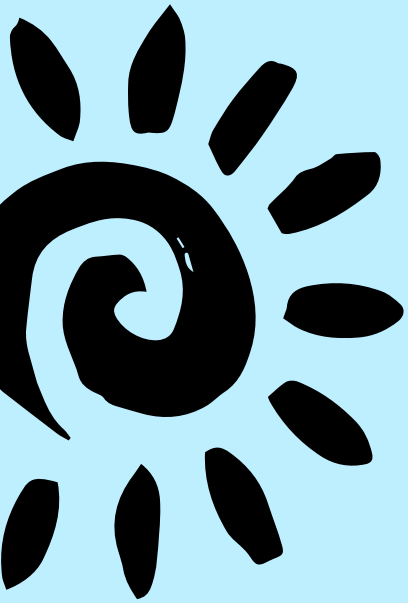
	Class Preparation
Date/Time/Season	
Length	
Place	
Student/Demographic	
Practice Level	
Theme/Purpose	
Bhava (mood)	
	Class Opening
Intro	
Discussion/Reading	
Chant	
Mudra	
Pranayama	
Meditation	
	Body of Class / Asana Sequence
Warm Up	
Sun Salutations	
Standing Postures	

Sequences by Category Grid (Cont'd)

	Body of Class /Asana Sequence
Arm Balancing	
Hip Opening	
Back Bending	
Forward Bending	
Twisting	
Core	
Inversions	
Finishing Poses	
Savasana	
	Class Closing
Pranayama	
Meditation	
Discussion / Reading	
Mudra	
Chant	

THE TEACHING PRACTICUM

A word about your practice classes



The paradox of the Teacher Training Program is that it is the outcome of your 4-week or 12-week course to be able to lead a 60 or 90-minute class. And yet, as part of the requirements of the course itself, we are asking you to do that very thing for which you are not yet fully prepared. We acknowledge this paradox and the difficulty of what we're asking of you.

It is incredibly important that, as part of your journey to become a yoga instructor, you work with real students. Just as we use our *sadhana* to embody the poses we will teach, we also need to embody the act of teaching—planning, cueing, adjusting, etc. That said, you should think of these practice classes as just that: practice. For *you*! Use these sessions to reinforce the work you have done so far in your training. Focus on those asanas that you have discussed in practicum; rehearse the cueing language or alignment techniques that have been introduced. In other words, teach what you know!

The first week, this may mean that you only teach Surya Namaskar A and B, toss in a tree pose and a forward fold, before finding your way to Savasana. That's perfectly fine!

What is most important is that you are genuinely going through the motions of teaching and letting it all sink in *for you*. And you'll be glad you had this experience when it comes time for you to teach a sample class to the group at the end of your training!

> "I've always loved when my teacher does these cool and interesting sequences, but we're not talking about sequencing for another two weeks."

So practice yogic patience and wait two weeks for your own really cool and interesting sequences! There are easily a hundred other things to focus on in preparing and delivering your class. Just as there are kramas (stages) of each asana, there are kramas in your teaching practice, and you must build a whole host of skills as you go, so don't get ahead of yourself.

> I'm going to be teaching three friends—one is pregnant, one is depressed, and one has lower back issues. I really want to make sure they receive all the specific benefits of yoga for their individual situations. How do I cater to all three of them?

Whoa. That's asking a lot of yourself! In fact, that would be a tall order for the most experienced teacher. The truth is that working with private clients takes a very specific kind of preparation and work. While it's admirable for you to want to help your friends, remember that this is the first and foremost practice for you as an aspiring teacher. Once you have mastered the fundamentals of teaching, then you can begin to look towards creating more targeted practices, but for the sake of these classes, you want to focus on reinforcing what we've been covering in class.

> I can't find anyone who will take the time to do a full practice with me.

We hate your friends! What's wrong with them? In all seriousness though, this happens from time to time, and while we don't endorse doing this every week, what about doing a couple of mini-practices? For example, perhaps you grab a different colleague at work every day and teach them a sun salutation in their cubicle. You're still gaining many of the benefits of solidifying your teaching skills—in some ways even more, since you're working with new people each time, and doing so with great frequency.

18 COMMANDMENTS OF ASSISTING

BE GENTLE 01.

Always err on the side of being too gentle with any adjustment or assist, especially for a newer teacher. It is far better to be ineffective than injurious.

LOOK, LISTEN & FEEL 02.

Before moving into an adjustment, place your hands on your student, look at their body and face and listen to their breathing for a few breath cycles in order to feel their level of muscular tension, breathing, and receptivity to touch, before deepening a posture or initiating a biomechanical adjustment.

SLOW AND EASY 03.

Apply muscular energy to your students gradually and pay close attention to how their body, breath, and facial expressions respond. If you feel any shaking, shortening of the breath, muscle spasming or tension, or anything that stops or pulls the student's body in a direction opposing an adjustment or you notice any other sign of discomfort or biomechanical danger, gradually release the adjustment to a point where the reaction eases, while supporting the student, if necessary, and ask the student if the adjustment feels all right. Fast or ballistic movement may trigger the body's myotatic reflex to sharply contract the muscle being stretched. This increases the risk of injury, especially if external energy is being applied to lengthen the same muscle.

STACK YOUR ADJUSTMENTS 04.

If you make multiple adjustments on the same student, always stack your adjustments from the floor up. This sets up the body for optimal biomechanical integrity and also lessens the likelihood that follow-on adjustments will misalign earlier adjustments. For example, in warrior postures, adjust and align from the feet up, rather than the head or arms down.

RESPECT YOUR KNOWLEDGE & ABILITIES 05.

Only provide adjustments you feel comfortable you have mastered and have been adequately trained to provide. Never experiment on a student or offer medical, rehabilitative, or chiropractic advice, unless you also hold a degree, or current license and maintain liability insurance in that field. If you are not a doctor, physical therapist, chiropractor, or another qualified healthcare provider, you are not qualified to either diagnose or treat any bodily injury, pain, and/or orthopedic conditions. If you have any questions about a student's abilities, limitations, questions, or comments about any injury, the sensation of pain, or neurological symptoms, refer them to a qualified healthcare provider.

STAY SUPPORTED 06.

Always make sure that your body weight is supported by something other than your student. This external support could be your own body, the floor, a wall, or a prop. Never lean on or apply your unsupported body weight to a student.

POSITION YOUR BODY CORRECTLY 07.

When possible and appropriate, avoid adjusting from the side.Position your body so that your hip position is mirroring your students. Adjustments may feel awkward and uneven if you lean over students to adjust. Set yourself up and adjust from a balanced perspective.

LOOK, LISTEN & FEEL 08.

If you have any questions about the integrity or intensity of an adjustment, ask your students if it feels ok, ask whether they would like you to deepen the adjustment, and then *listen* to them. Even if they verbally agree, if their body and breath tell you they are at the end of their reasonable range of motion, do not apply further muscular energy.

INSTILL CONFIDENCE 09.

When adjusting a student in a tentative standing posture, i.e., balancing or standing twists, tell the student you will not let them fall... and then keep your word. Make sure you are stable by positioning your legs perpendicular to theirs.

CUE SELF-ADJUSTMENTS FIRST 10.

Before applying hands-on adjustments, cue the student or group verbally to align the posture, starting general and getting increasingly specific. If a student does not respond to the several cues, then, consider hands-on adjustments. Allowing students to adjust themselves helps increase body awareness, facilitates mastery of asana, and decreases the risk of injury due to inappropriate adjustments or errors in assessing the student's biomechanical position or muscular range and pliability.

IMPROVISE WITH INTEGRITY 11.

When tailoring an adjustment to an individual's needs and abilities or creating a new adjustment, make sure that the adjustment preserves the yogic intent of the individual posture or general category of postures and is biomechanically safe and effective. Never apply an adjustment that exceeds either your level of training or your level of personal confidence.

QUARTERBACK ACCORDING TO SAFETY 12.

Allocate your adjustments among students by attending first to those who require realignment to maintain biomechanical integrity and lessen the risk of injury and, second, to those who might benefit from better energetic alignment or a facilitated stretch.

TWIST & BACKBEND WITH CAUTION 13.

When adjusting spinal twists or backbends, be extra careful to deepen any adjustment very gradually, if at all, and always allow the body a chance to respond before moving further.

SENSE, DEEPEN & HOLD 14.

Observe the student's breath pattern, muscular tension, and facial expression. Then increase an adjustment's muscular energy with the student's exhale and maintain position with the student's inhale. It takes a while to learn where a student's "edge" or limitation of their safe range of movement is. Signposts are a combination of the student's inability to move deeper, open more, or twist further without having to apply more than a firm, yet gentle level of muscular energy, erratic breathing, strained facial expression, or muscular shaking. Until you become comfortable determining the safe edge, always err on the side of being too gentle or not applying enough muscular energy.

BE GOOD TO YOURSELF 15.

Adjusting students is physical work and we, as teachers, are often not as warm or prepared to apply muscular energy as our students, Because of this, there is a risk of injury to our own bodies, during adjustments, if we do not assume safe biomechanical stances ourselves. An example of this would be to always bend the knees and engage the Bandhas when applying muscular energy to a student, especially if you are folding forward at the hips.

NEVER DEEPEN INTO COMPRESSION 16.

Before deepening any adjustment or applying muscular energy to any student, ask yourself (1) whether they are safely aligned from a modern biomechanics standpoint, and (2) whether their range of motion is being limited by compression(tissue/bone pressing into each other on the closing side of the body or joint) or tension (stretching of muscle/fascia on the lengthening side of the body). If the limitation is caused by compression, do not apply muscular energy to deepen the posture. It will only result in over-compression and/or discomfort. Compression-related limitations on the range of movement cannot be changed with yoga. Tension-related limitations on the range of movement, however, often can be effectively improved through regular practice.

STRETCH THE MUSCLE BELLY 17.

Never apply a deepening adjustment if the student is feeling a stretch/pain sensation predominantly in the muscle origin or insertion (often, at the joint), rather than the muscle belly. For example, if a student feels a strong sensation of stretch/pain behind the knee in a forward bend, they have already pushed beyond the safe range and are pulling on the least elastic element of the kinetic chain, thereby increasing the likelihood of injury.

TWIST & BACKBEND WITH CAUTION 18.

Be sensitive to your student's personal comfort zone. Some students do not want to be adjusted or touched. Others may be sensitive to the amount of bodily contact you apply or to the parts of your body that you use to apply contact. Be sensitive to these issues. Avoid becoming overly intimate, positioning your body in contact with any perceived erogenous zones, or applying adjustments that may be perceived as having any sexual or inappropriate intent.

TEACHING OFF THE TEACHER'S MAT

There are times when it makes sense for the teacher to teach from the teacher's mat, in front of the class, and times when the teacher should practice asana along with the class. There are also times when it is important for the teacher to step off the mat and move out into the class.

Often, new teachers get attached to standing on the teacher's mat and practicing along with the class. It becomes a safe haven for the teacher, and they have difficulty knowing when to move out into the class or where they should be in the room. Ideally, there should be a balance of teaching time from the teacher's mat, and time moving throughout the room.

It is important to get off the teacher's mat for several reasons:

- To see your students from all angles.
- To position yourself so your students can see you better.
- To look into your students' eyes and read the energy of the class.
- To get a sense of your student's strengths and limitations.
- To know if you need to modify your sequence for difficulty.
- To do hands-on assists.

Here are some suggestions for finding the balance of time on and off the teacher's mat and recommendations for when to stand in the room when you are off the mat.

- Begin class on the teacher's mat, facing your students.
- Lead chanting, pranayama, and meditation from a seated place on the teacher's mat.
- Be in the same relationship to gravity as your students. If they are sitting, you should sit. If they are kneeling, you should kneel (etc., etc., etc.). The exceptions to this are when you are walking through the room doing hands-on assists, or when your students are lying on their backs. Don't lie on your back while teaching unless your head is lifted so you can see your class.
- It is ok to stay on your mat for the warm-up.
- Once you begin to teach Surya A & B, it is time to get off the teacher mat and begin to move throughout the room observing your students. You can walk through the class, pause and observe from the back of the class, and begin to do some hands-on assists.
- When your students are in forward bends, and inversions, including downward dog, there is no need to be on the teacher mat, since they cannot see you.
- When your students are in balancing poses, stay on the teacher mat facing the class, but do not move, as your movements may disturb their balance.
- It is more difficult to assist when students are flowing through poses, although there are quick assists for the Surya Namaskar A & B series.
- When your students are in standing poses, move throughout the room so that you are facing them. If they are in open hip poses like Vira II, Trikonasana, or Prasarita Padottonasana, move to the side of the class and face them.
- When you are facing your students, you should be mirroring their poses. For example, if they are in Vira II with their left leg forward, you should stand with your right leg forward, so when they look at you it is like looking in the mirror.
- When students are seated or lying on backbends, hip openers, twists, and forward folds, you should get up and walk around the room so you can observe them from all angles and do hands-on assists.
- End class from the teacher mat facing your students.

WORKING WITH PRIVATE CLIENTS

Logistics & Policies

- Time: How long is a session?
- Fees: How do I set my fees
- Location: Where do I render services?
- Payment & cancellation policies
- Standard of care from a legal standpoint:
- Fitness vs. yoga
- American College of Sports Medicine
- Getting clients—covered in the business of yoga section

First Session/Prelim Intake Process/Forms

- Medical/exercise readiness questionnaire
  - What is it?
  - Why do you need it?
  - What are the different types?

- Waiver & Release
  - What is it?
  - Why do you need it?
  - What does it protect you from?
  - What doesn't it protect you from?

- Physicians letter
  - What is it?
  - Why do you need it?

- Lifestyle Questionnaire
  - What is it?
  - Why do you need it?

- Contract
  - Show that agrees to terms/enforce the cancellation policy

- Match the form with the purpose
  - Identify medical contraindications
  - Learn about a person's lifestyle
  - Identify stress patterns & out-of-balance areas
  - Explore the family medical history
  - Identify limitations, concerns, and desires
  - Set realistic aspirations

What Happens In The First Session & Beyond

- How does the standard of care differ from class instruction?
- Daily inquiry – how is your mind, body, what do you need?
- In the first session, be extra gentle, observe and learn about abilities/limitations
- Sensitivity to touch
- Creating therapeutic intimacy, while maintaining professional boundaries
- Absolute beginners may not flow for a while
- Teach how to modify each posture for a specific condition/ability/limitations
- Tailor to day's needs of day, body, abilities

THE BUSINESS OF YOGA

Branding

- Biz name or Personal
- Website
- Blog
- Biz cards
- Flyers

Gaining Experience

- Creating Your Resume
- Yoga Studio – sub-lists, assisting
- Other Settings: Gym, spa, school, community center
- Corporate Settings
- Volunteer organizations

Biz Essentials

- Accounting: Bookkeeping, Biz entity
- Insurance: liability
- CPR/First aid Certification
- Yoga Alliance RYT

Advertising

- Social media
- Referrals
- Facilitated referrals
- Flyers
- E-mail
- Online

Networking

- Family
- Friends
- Events
- Publicity: write articles, issue press releases, make news
- Strategic partnering: massage, nutrition, docs, hair salon, trainers
- Barter: value of yoga in trade

Pricing

- Karma Yoga
- Class Pay
- Privates, duets & groups
- Sliding scale
- First Time Offers
- Drop-ins vs courses/programs
- Benefits of pre-payment
- Cancellation policies

APPENDIX A
RESOURCES

BOOKS

REQUIRED READING

- *Bhagavad Gita*
- *Yoga Sutras of Patanjali*
- *Sonic Yoga Teacher Training Manual* (yup, that's this one)
- *The Key Muscles of Yoga: Scientific Keys, Volume 1 by Ray Long*

SUGGESTED READING

Anatomy & Physiology

- *Anatomy Trains* – Thomas W Myers
- *Science of Flexibility* – Michael J. Alter
- *Anatomy of Hatha Yoga* – David H Coulter
- *Keys to Hatha Yoga* – www.Bhandayoga.com
- *A Physiological Handbook for Teachers of Yogasana* – Mel Robin
- *Dynamic Alignment Through Imagery* – Eric Franklin
- *Awakening the Spine* – Vanda Scaravelli
- *Yoga as Medicine* – Timothy McCall

Asana

- *Light on Yoga* – BKS Iyengar
- *Yoga: The Path to Holistic Health* – BKS Iyengar
- *Ashtanga Yoga Practice Manual* – David Swenson
- *The Sivananda Yoga Companion* – Simon & Schuster
- *Asana* – Sri Dharma Mittra
- *Yoga: The Spirit and Practice of Moving into Stillness* – Erich Schiffmann
- *Jivamukti Yoga: Practices for Liberating Body and Soul* – Sharon Gannon & David Life
- *The Complete Book of Vinyasa Yoga* – Srivatsa Ramaswami
- *Relax and Renew* – Judith Lasater

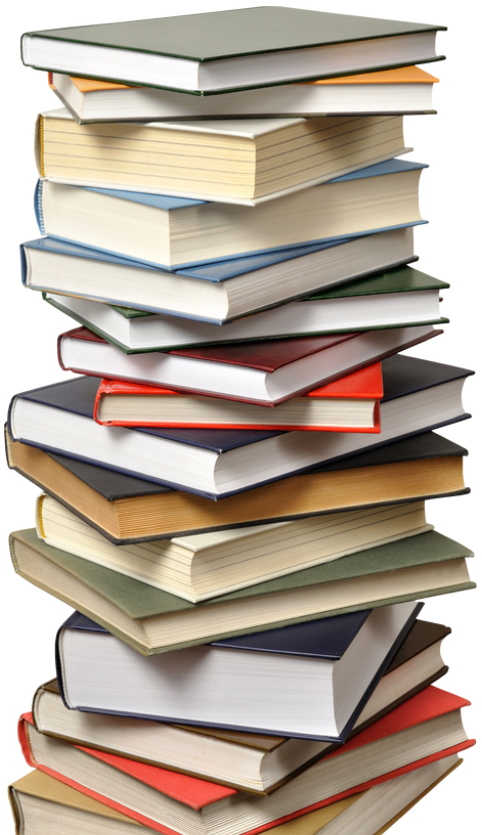
Related

- *The SecretPower of Yoga* – Nischala Joy Devi
- *Heart Of Yoga* – TKV Desikachar
- *The Deeper Dimension of Yoga* – Georg Feuerstein
- *Yoga Mala* – Sri K Pattabhi Jois
- *A Guide to the Bodhisattva Way of Life The Yoga Tradition* – Georg Feuerstein
- *Comfortable With Uncertainty* – Pema Chodron
- *When Things Fall Apart* – Pema Chodron
- *The Places That Scare You* – Pema Chodron
- *Start where You Are* – Pema Chodron
- *The Wisdom of No Escape* – Pema Chodron
- *Bringing Yoga to Life* – Donna Farhi
- *Moola Bandha The Master Key* – Swami Buddhananda
- *A Brief History of Everything* – Ken Wilber
- *Turning the Mind Into An Ally* – Sakyong Mipham
- *The Art of Happiness* – HRH Dalai Lama
- *A Short Guide to a Happy Life* – Anna Quindlen
- *Remember, Be Here Now* – Ram Dass
- *The Path of Practice: A Woman's Book of Ayurvedic Healing* – Bri Maya Tiwari
- *Living your Yoga* – Judith Lasater
- *Siddhartha* – Hermann Hesse
- *Tantric Quest: An Encounter with Absolute Love* – Daniel Odier
- *Secrets of Self-Healing* – Maoshing Ni

Poetry

- *The Enlightened Heart* – Stephen Mitchell
- *The Enlightened Mind* – Stephen Mitchell

NOTE: The Yoga Journal website (yogajournal.com) is a good resource for books as well.



FROM OUR YOGA CLASS TO YOURS

Music We Love

Chanting

Krishna Das – Live On Earth, Pilgrim Heart, One Track Heart
Jai Uttal – Live with Pagan Remixes
Deva Premal – The Essence, Love is Space
DJ Cheb i Sabbah – Shri Durga, Maha Maya (above remixed), Multicolored Chant
Chaula Hopefisher – Chants
Ravi Shankar Arjun & Jah Kind – Chants of India
The Eternal Om

Dance/Movement

Glen Velez – Rhythms of the Chakras

Asana CDs/DVDs from Shiva Rea

Yoga Shakti
Lunar Flow
Solar Flow
Drops of Nectar

Inspiring

Brent Lewis – Earth Tribe Rhythms
James Asher – Feet in The Soil Refuge
Gabrielle Roth
Ibiza Chill-Out – Volumes 1 to 7
Café del Mare – Volumes 1 & 2
Body & Soul – Play
Moby – Big Calm
Morcheeba Paul – Rhythm of the Saints
Simon Soul II – Keep on Moving Aion
Soul – Toward the Within
Dead Can Dance – Niafunke
Ali Farka Touré, Ry Cooder – Talking Timbuktu
Issa Bagayogo
Rashid Taha – Rashid (from Nigeria)
Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan w/ Michal Brook

Additional Recommendations

El Hadre
Pranayama
Rhythms of Awakening Kive Kand
Sacred Chants of Buddha
Bhagavan Das
Breath of the Heart
Kerala Dreams
Yoga Rhythms – Shiva Shakti
Seven Metals
Asana 1
Asana 2
Asana 3
Yoga Trance Dance
Eternal Om
Sacred Chants of Shiva
Shakti Rhythms
The Essence
Yoga for Music and other Joys
The Lover & The Loved
In the Glow
Rhythms of the Chakras

APPENDIX B

SAMPLE PRACTICES

LEVEL I SAMPLE
Vinyasa Practice

Gentler pace—stronger emphasis on each element, less on keeping the flow. Always cue the easiest version first, if you cue more challenging ones at all. Do not cue jump backs to Chaturanga (jump forward OK). No Binds in twisting postures— knee down in twisting crescent lunge Depending on the group, may cut some/all arm balancing. Keep back bending more basic—most people in bridge on the floor, basic cobra & bow Keep inversions to shoulder stand/plow or inversion preparations. Depending on the level of practice, adapt the complexity of postures or completely remove them. If you see many are doing a segment poorly or you want to work on bringing students to a more challenging option, use your discretion and break the flow to cue posture details.

I. WARM UP

Balasana (Child's Pose) or Tadasana (Mountain Pose)
Uttanasana (Forward bend/Ragdoll)
Adho Mukha Svanasana (Downdog / extend leg / bend knee / open / variations)
Uttanasana (Forward Bend/ Ragdoll)
Tadasana (Mountain Pose)

II. SURYA NAMASKAR A (Sun Salutation A) – 3 Times

III. SURYA NAMASKAR B (Sun Salutation B) – 3 Times

IV. SURYA NAMASKAR B – Virabhadrasana (Warrior) Series

Virabhadrasana I (Warrior 1)
Virabhadrasana II (Warrior 2)
Parsva Virabhadrasana (Reverse Warrior Pose)
Utthita Parsvakonasana (Modified Extended Side Angle Pose)
Chaturanga Dandasana (Lower Knees to Low Push Up)
Bhujangasana / Urdhva Mukha Svanasana (Cobra /Upward-Facing Dog Pose)
Adho Mukha Svanasana (Downward-Facing Dog)
Other Side

V. SURYANAMASKAR B – Trikonasana (Triangle) Series

Open to Warrior II
Utthita Trikonasana (Triangle)
Prasarita Padottanasana (Feet Spread Intense Stretch)
Parsvottanasana (Intense Side Stretch)
Parivrtta Trikonasana (Revolved Triangle Pose)
Chaturanga Dandasana (Lower knees to low push up)
Bhujangasana/Urdhva Mukha Svanasana (Cobra / Upward-Facing Dog Pose)
Adho Mukha Svanasana (Downward-Facing Dog Pose)
Other side

VI. SURYANAMASKAR B – Crescent/Twisting Series

Alanasana (Crescent Lunge)
Parivrtta Alanasana (Twisting Crescent Lunge w/ bent knee)
Chaturanga Dandasana – Lower knees to Low Push Up
Bhujangasana/Urdhva Mukha Svanasana (Cobra / Upward-Facing Dog Pose)
Adho Mukha Svanasana (Downward-Facing Dog)
Other Side

VII. LEG BALANCING – Choose 2 or 3

Vrksasana (Tree Pose)
Garudasana (Eagle Pose)
Dekasana (Airplane Pose)
Ardha Chandrasana (Half-Moon Pose)

VINYASA

VIII. ARM BALANCING

Bakasana (Crow Pose w/ modifications)
Vasisthasana (Side Plank Pose w/ modifications)

IX. INVERSION

Sirsasana Prep (Headstand Prep Pose

VINYASA

X. MAT BACK BENDING – Choose 2

Bhujangasana (Cobra Pose)
Salabhasana (Locust Pose) – Prep and variations
Dhanurasana (Bow Pose w/ modifications)
Balasana (Child's Pose)
Adho Mukha Svanasana (Downward-Facing Dog Pose)

XI. HIP OPENING SERIES

Eka Pada Rajakapotasana (Pigeon Pose)
Baddha Konasana (Bound Angle Pose)

VINYASA

XII. BACK BENDING – 2 Times

Setu Bandhasana (Bridge Pose)
Matsyendrasana (Seated or Lying Spinal Twist Pose)

XIII. CORE SERIES – 3 Times

Navasana (Boat w/modifications)
Purvottanasana (Inclined Plane Pose) or (Table modification)

XIV. SEATED FORWARD BENDING

Janu Sirsasana (Head to Knee)
Paschimottanasana (Western Forward Bend Pose)

XV. FINISHING SERIES

Halasana (Plow Pose) to Salamba Sarvangasana (Supported Shoulderstand Pose)
Matsyasana (Fish Pose)
Savasana (Corpse Pose)

Allow approx. 5 minutes for Savasana, gently guiding students to a comfortable place through verbal cues, then either playing music or allowing silence.

XVI. CLOSING

Cross Leg modification position
"Om" – 3 Times

Beginner Flow
Sample

Supported Virasana on block
Sama Vritti/equal breathing (possibly explain and) chant OM 3x Cat/cow spine
Child's pose
Roll to sit on heels: easy right/left twists

Adho Mukha Svanasana
Plank lower knees/mod.
Chatturanga Bhujangasana
(will need to spend some time with this sequence - repeat 2 or 3x)
Walk feet to front of mat for Uttanasana
Roll to stand

Tadasana
Ardha
Surya Namaskar A
Surya Namaskar A
Surya Namaskar B (optional Vinyasas)

Uttkatasana
Uttanasana
Adho Mukha Svanasana
Downward Dog split
Low lunge
Parsvottanasana w/ hands on blocks or mat
Low lunge
Crescent lunge
Virabhadrasana II Parsva Trikonasana Trikonasana
Adho Mukha Svanasana

Vrksasana

Eka Pada Raja Kapotasana (right side)

Ardha Matsyendrasana (left side)
(Repeat on other sides)

Adho Mukha Svanasana
Plank
Shalabasana

Supported Bridge with block
Setu Bandhasana
Knees to chest/happy baby

Reclined Twist
Supta Padangusthasana w/ variations
Paschimottanasana
Viparita Karani
Savasana

LEVEL I Core
Flow Sample

Seated position
Bastrikha Breath
Supported Navasana (optional Bhastrika)
Tabletop Dandasana with powerful legs
Roll down and up through core 3-6 times
Supine Easy Bridge
Happy Baby

Adho Mukha Svanasana
DD Split
Open hip Low Lunge (Anjaneyasana)
Add twisting variation
Plank cultivation
Optional vinyasa to Adho Mukha
Repeat top of the mat
Uttanasana, Rag Doll
Tadasana with integration

2x surya namaskar A 1–2x B
Uttkatasana Twist release, roll up through the core
Other side
Uttanasana Step back to Anjanyasana (high lunge)
Pause with focus on the back foot
Twist (active twist or full Parivrtta/Anjaneyasana knee up or down)
DD split and open hip
Step to Vira II
Parsva Vira
Utthitha Parsvakonasana Vira II
Prasarita paddotonasana
Goddess with Bhastrika Vira II
Windmill to Vinyasa
Top of mat & repeat other side
Hop through to sit, roll down through core
Happy Baby

Supta Bakasana (Crow cultivation on back)
Bakasana, DD

Plank control lower prone
Salabasana
Dhanurasana (focus on muscular energy and integration)

Child Pose
Thread the needle (Parivrtta, Anahatasana),
DD

Eka Pada Rajakapotasana (pigeon)
Swing leg around to Janu Sirsasana
Repeat other side
Stretch both legs out (Andasana)
Roll down and up integrating core
Bridge (Setu Bhandasana)
Supine Twist
Savasana

APPENDIX C

ESSENTIAL SANSKRIT WORDS & PHRASES

A

ABHYASA: practice; cf. *vairagya*

ACARYA (sometimes spelled Acharya in English): a preceptor, instructor; cf. guru

ADVAITA ("nonduality"): the truth and teaching that there is only One Reality (*Atman, Brahman*), especially as found in the *Upanishads*; see also Vedanta

AHAMKARA ("I-maker"): the individuation principle, or ego, which must be transcended; cf. *asmita*; see also *buddhi, manas*

AHIMSA ("non-harming"): the single most important moral discipline (*yama*)

AKASHA ("ether/space"): the first of the five material elements of which the physical universe is composed; also used to designate "inner" space, that is, the space of consciousness (called *cid-akasha*)

AMRITA ("immortal/immortality"): a designation of the deathless Spirit (*atman, purusha*); also the nectar of immortality that oozes from the psychoenergetic center at the crown of the head (see *sahasrara-chakra*) when it is activated and transforms the body into a "divine body" (*divya-deha*)

ANANDA ("bliss"): the condition of utter joy, which is an essential quality of the ultimate Reality (*tattva*)

ANGA ("limb"): a fundamental category of the yogic path, such as *asana, dharana, dhyana, niyama, pranayama, pratyahara, samadhi, yama*; also the body (*deha, sharira*)

ARJUNA ("White"): one of the five Pandava princes who fought in the great war depicted in the *Mahabharata*, disciple of the God-man Krishna whose teachings can be found in the *Bhagavad Gita*

ASANA ("seat"): a physical posture (see also *anga*, mudra); the third limb (*anga*) of Patanjali's eightfold path (*astha-anga-yoga*); originally this meant only meditation posture, but subsequently, in hatha yoga, this aspect of the yogic path was greatly developed

ASHRAMA ("that where effort is made"): a hermitage; also a stage of life, such as *brahmacharya*, householder, forest dweller, and complete renouncer (*samnyasin*)

ASHTA-ANGA-YOGA ("eight-limbed union"): the eightfold yoga of Patanjali, consisting of moral discipline (*yama*), self-restraint (*niyama*), posture (*asana*), breath control (*pranayama*), sensory inhibition (*pratyahara*), concentration (*dharana*), meditation (*dhyana*), and ecstasy (*samadhi*), leading to liberation (*kaivalya*)

ASMITA ("I-am-ness"): a concept of Patanjali's eight-limbed yoga, roughly synonymous with *ahamkara*

ATMAN ("self"): the transcendental Self, or Spirit, which is eternal and superconscious; our true nature or identity; sometimes a distinction is made between the *atman* as the individual self and the *parama-atman* as the transcendental self; see also *purusha*; cf. *brahman*

AVADHUTA ("he who has shed [everything]"): a radical type of renouncer (*samnyasin*) who often engages in unconventional behavior

AVIDYA ("ignorance"): the root cause of suffering (*duhkha*); also called *jnana*; cf. *vidya*

AYURVEDA, Ayur-veda ("life science"): one of India's traditional systems of medicine, the other being South India's Siddha medicine

B

BANDHA ("bond/bondage"): the fact that human beings are typically bound by ignorance (avidya), which causes them to lead a life governed by karmic habit rather than inner freedom generated through wisdom (vidya, jnana)

BHAGAVAD GITA ("Lord's Song"): the oldest full-fledged yoga book found embedded in the Mahabharata, containing the teachings on karma yoga (the path of self-transcending action), *samkhya* yoga (the path of discerning the principles of existence correctly), and bhakti yoga (the path of devotion), as given by the God-man Krishna to Prince Arjuna on the battlefield 3,500 years or more ago

BHAGAVATA-PURANA ("Ancient [Tradition] of the Bhagavatas"): a voluminous tenth-century scripture held sacred by the devotees of the Divine in the form of Vishnu, especially in his incarnate form as Krishna; also called Shrimad- Bhagavata

BHAKTA ("devotee"): a disciple practicing bhakti yoga

BHAKTI ("devotion/love"): the love of the bhakta toward the Divine or the guru as a manifestation of the Divine; also the love of the Divine toward the devotee

BHAKTI-SUTRA ("Aphorisms on Devotion"): an aphoristic work on devotional yoga authored by Sage Narada; another text by the same title is ascribed to Sage Shandilya

BHAKTI YOGA ("Yoga of devotion"): a major branch of the yoga tradition, utilizing the feeling capacity to connect with the ultimate Reality conceived as a supreme Person (*uttama-purusha*)

BINDU ("seed/point"): the creative potency of anything where all energies are focused; the dot (also called *tilaka*) worn on the forehead as indicative of the third eye

BODHI ("enlightenment"): the state of the awakened master, or buddha
Bodhisattva ("enlightenment being"): in Mahayana Buddhist yoga, the individual who, motivated by compassion (karuna), is committed to achieving enlightenment for the sake of all other beings

BRAHMA ("he who has grown expansive"): the Creator of the universe, the first principle (tattva) to emerge out of the ultimate Reality (brahman)

BRAHMACHARYA (from *brahma* and *acarya* "brahmic conduct"): the discipline of chastity, which produces *ojas*

BRAHMAN ("that which has grown expansive"): the ultimate Reality (cf. *atman*, *purusha*)

BRAHMANA: a brahmin, a member of the highest social class of traditional Indian society; also an early type of ritual text explicating the rituals and mythology of the four *Vedas*; cf. *Aranyaka*, *Upanishad*, *Veda*

BUDDHA ("awakened"): a designation of the person who has attained enlightenment (bodhi) and therefore inner freedom; honorific title of Gautama, the founder of Buddhism, who lived in the sixth century B.C.E.

BUDDHI ("she who is conscious, awake"): the higher mind, which is the seat of wisdom (*vidya, jnana*); cf. *manas*

C

CHAKRA ou CAKRA ("wheel"): literally, the wheel of a wagon; metaphorically, one of the psycho-energetic centers of the subtle body (*sukshma-sharira*); in Buddhist yoga, five such centers are known, while in Hindu yoga often seven or more such centers are mentioned: *mula-adhara-chakra (muladhara-chakra)* at the base of the spine, *svadhishthana-chakra* at the genitals, *manipura-chakra* at the navel, *anahata-chakra* at the heart, *vishuddha-chakra* or vishuddhi-chakra at the throat, *Ajna-chakra* in the middle of the head, and *sahasrara-chakra* at the top of the head

CIN-MUDRA ("consciousness seal"): a common hand gesture (mudra) in meditation (*dhyana*), which is formed by bringing the tips of the index finger and the thumb together, while the remaining fingers are kept straight

CIT ("consciousness"): the superconscious ultimate Reality (see atman, brahman) Citta ("that which is conscious"): ordinary consciousness, the mind, as opposed to cit

D

DARSHANA ("seeing"): vision in the literal and metaphorical sense; a system of philosophy, such as the *yoga-darshana* of Patanjali; cf. *drishti*

DEVA ("he who is shining"): a male deity, such as Shiva, Vishnu, or Krishna, either in the sense of the ultimate Reality or a high angelic being

DEVI ("she who is shining"): a female deity such as Parvati, Lakshmi, or Radha, either in the sense of the ultimate Reality (in its feminine pole) or a high angelic being

DHARANA ("holding"): concentration, the sixth limb (*anga*) of Patanjali's eight-limbed yoga

DHARMA ("bearer"): a term of numerous meanings; often used in the sense of "law," "lawfulness," "virtue," "righteousness," "norm"

DHYANA ("ideating"): meditation, the seventh limb (*anga*) of Patanjali's eight-limbed yoga

DIKSHA ("initiation"): the act and condition of induction into the hidden aspects of yoga or a particular lineage of teachers; all traditional yoga is initiatory

DRISHTI ("view/sight"): yogic gazing, such as at the tip of the nose or the spot between the eyebrows; cf. *darshana*

DUHKHA ("bad axle space"): suffering, a fundamental fact of life, caused by ignorance (avidya) of our true nature (i.e., the Self or *atman*)

G

GAYATRI-MANTRA: a famous Vedic mantra recited particularly at sunrise: *tat savitur varenyam bhargo devasya dhimahi dhiyo yo nah pracodayat*

GHERANDA-SAMHITA ("[Sage] Gheranda's Compendium"): one of three major manuals of classical hatha yoga, composed in the seventeenth century; cf. *Hatha-Yoga-Pradipika, Shiva-Samhita*

GORAKSHA ("Cow Protector"): traditionally said to be the founding adept of hatha yoga, a disciple of Matsyendra

GRANTHI ("knot"): any one of three common blockages in the central pathway (sushumna-nadi) preventing the full ascent of the serpent power (kundalini- shakti); the three knots are known as brahma-granthi (at the lowest psychoenergetic center of the subtle body), the vishnu-granthi (at the heart), and the rudra-granthi (at the eyebrow center)

GUNA ("quality"): a term that has numerous meanings, including "virtue"; often refers to any of the three primary "qualities" or constituents of nature (prakriti): tamas (the principle of inertia), rajas (the dynamic principle), and sattva (the principle of lucidity)

GURU ("he who is heavy, weighty"): a spiritual teacher; cf. acarya

GURU-BHAKTI ("teacher devotion"): a disciple's self-transcending devotion to the guru; see also bhakti

GURU-GITA ("Guru's Song"): a text in praise of the guru, often chanted in ashramas

GURU-YOGA ("Yoga [relating to] the teacher"): a yogic approach that makes the guru the fulcrum of a disciple's practice; all traditional forms of yoga contain a strong element of guru-yoga

H

HAMSA ("swan/gander"): apart from the literal meaning, this term also refers to the breath (*prana*) as it moves within the body; the individuated consciousness (*jiva*) propelled by the breath; see *jiva-atman*; see also *parama-hamsa*

HATHA YOGA ("Forceful Yoga"): a major branch of yoga, developed by Goraksha and other adepts c. 1000 C.E., emphasizing the physical aspects of the transformative path, notably postures (*asana*) and cleansing techniques (*shodhana*), but also breath control (pranayama)

HATHA-YOGA-PRADIPIKA ("Light on Hatha Yoga"): one of three classical manuals on hatha yoga, authored by Svatmarama Yogendra in the fourteenth century

HIRANYAGARBHA ("Golden Germ"): the mythical founder of yoga; the first cosmological principle (tattva) to emerge out of the infinite Reality; also called Brahma

I

IDA-NADI ("pale conduit"): the prana current or arc ascending on the left side of the central channel (*sushumna nadi*) associated with the parasympathetic nervous system and having a cooling or calming effect on the mind when activated; cf. *pingala-nadi*

ISHVARA ("ruler"): the Lord; referring either to the Creator (see *Brahma*) or, in Patanjali's yoga-darshana, to a special transcendental Self (*purusha*)

ISHVARA-PRANIDHANA ("dedication to the Lord"): in Patanjali's eight-limbed yoga one of the practices of self-restraint (*niyama*); see also bhakti yoga

J

JAINA (sometimes Jain): pertaining to the *jinas* ("conquerors"), the liberated adepts of Jainism; a member of Jainism, the spiritual tradition founded by Vardhamana Mahavira, a contemporary of Gautama the Buddha

JAPA ("muttering"): the recitation of mantras

JIVA-ATMAN, JIVATMAN ("individual self"): the individuated consciousness, as opposed to the ultimate Self (*parama-atman*)

JIVAN-MUKTA ("he who is liberated while alive"): an adept who, while still embodied, has attained liberation (*moksha*)

JIVAN-MUKTI ("living liberation"): the state of liberation while being embodied; cf. *videha-mukti*

JNANA ("knowledge/wisdom"): both worldly knowledge or world-transcending wisdom, depending on the context; see also *prajna*; cf. *avidya*

JNANA-YOGA ("Yoga of wisdom"): the path to liberation based on wisdom, or the direct intuition of the transcendental Self (*atman*) through the steady application of discernment between the Real and the unreal and renunciation of what has been identified as unreal (or inconsequential to the achievement of liberation)

K

KAIVALYA ("isolation"): the state of absolute freedom from conditioned existence, as explained in *ashta-anga-yoga*; in the nondualistic (*advaita*) traditions of India, this is usually called *moksha* or *mukti* (meaning "release" from the fetters of ignorance, or *avidya*)

KALI: a Goddess embodying the fierce (dissolving) aspect of the Divine

KALI-YUGA: the dark age of spiritual and moral decline, said to be current now; kali does not refer to the Goddess Kali but to the losing throw of a die

KAMA ("desire"): the appetite for sensual pleasure blocking the path to true bliss (*ananda*); the only desire conducive to freedom is the impulse toward liberation, called *mumukshutva*

KAPILA ("He who is red"): a great sage, the quasi-mythical founder of the Samkhya tradition, who is said to have composed the Samkhya-Sutra (which, however, appears to be of a much later date)

KARMAN, KARMA ("action"): activity of any kind, including ritual acts; said to be binding only so long as engaged in a self-centered way; the "karmic" consequence of one's actions; destiny

KARMA YOGA ("Yoga of action"): the liberating path of self-transcending actior

KARUNA ("compassion"): universal sympathy; in Buddhist yoga the complement of wisdom (*prajna*)

KHECARI-MUDRA ("space-walking seal"): the Tantric practice of curling the tongue back against the upper palate in order to seal the life energy (*prana*); see also *mudra*

KOSHA ("casing"): any one of five "envelopes" surrounding the transcendental Self (*atman*) and thus blocking its light: *anna-maya-kosha* ("envelope made of food," the physical body), *prana-maya-kosha* ("envelope made of life force"), *mano-maya-kosha* ("envelope made of mind"), *vijnana-maya-kosha* ("envelope made of consciousness"), and *ananda-maya-kosha* ("envelope made of bliss"); some older traditions regard the last kosha as identical with the Self (*atman*)

KRISHNA ("Puller"): an incarnation of God Vishnu, the God-man whose teachings can be found in the *Bhagavad Gita* and the *Bhagavata-Purana*

KUMBHAKA ("potlike"): breath retention; cf. *puraka, recaka*

KUNDALINI-SHAKTI ("coiled power"): according to Tantra and hatha yoga, the serpent power or spiritual energy, which exists in potential form at the lowest psycho-energetic center of the body (i.e., the *mula-adhara-chakra*) and which must be awakened and guided to the center at the crown (i.e., the *sahasrara- chakra*) for full enlightenment to occur

KUNDALINI-YOGA: the yogic path focusing on the kundalini process as a means of liberation

L

LAYA YOGA ("Yoga of dissolution"): an advanced form or process of Tantric yoga by which the energies associated with the various psycho-energetic centers (*chakra*) of the subtle body are gradually dissolved through the ascent of the serpent power (*kundalini-shakti*)

LINGA ("mark"): the phallus as a principle of creativity; a symbol of God Shiva; cf. *yoni*

M

MAHABHARATA ("Great Bharata"): one of India's two great ancient epics telling of the great war between the Pandavas and the Kauravas and serving as a repository for many spiritual and moral teachings

MAHATMA (from *maha-atman*, "great self"): an honorific title (meaning something like "a great soul") bestowed on particularly meritorious individuals, such as Gandhi

MAITHUNA ("twinning"): the Tantric sexual ritual in which the participants view each other as Shiva and Shakti respectively

MANAS ("mind"): the lower mind, which is bound to the senses and yields information (*vijnana*) rather than wisdom (jnana, vidya); cf. *buddhi*

MANDALA ("circle"): a circular design symbolizing the cosmos and specific to a *deity*

MANTRA (from the verbal root man "to think"): a sacred sound or phrase, such as *om*, *hum*, or *om namah shivaya*, that has a transformative effect on the mind of the individual reciting it; to be ultimately effective, a mantra needs to be given in an initiatory context (*diksha*)

MANTRA-YOGA: the yogic path utilizing mantras as the primary means of liberation

MARMAN ("lethal [spot]"): in Ayurveda and yoga, a vital spot on the physical body where energy is concentrated or blocked; cf. *granthi*

MATSYENDRA ("Lord of Fish"): an early Tantric master who founded the Yogini-Kaula school and is remembered as a teacher of Goraksha

MAYA ("she who measures"): the deluding or illusive power of the world; illusion by which the world is seen as separate from the ultimate singular Reality (*atman*)

MOKSHA ("release"): the condition of freedom from ignorance (avidya) and the binding effect of karma; also called *mukti*, *kaivalya*

MUDRA ("seal"): a hand gesture (such as *cin-mudra*) or whole-body gesture (such as *viparita-karani-mudra*); also a designation of the feminine partner in the Tantric sexual ritual

MUNI ("he who is silent"): types of ancient Indian sages and hermits

N

NADA ("sound"): the inner sound, as it can be heard through the practice of nada yoga or *kundalini yoga*

NADA-YOGA ("Yoga of the [inner] sound"): the yoga or process of producing and intently listening to the inner sound as a means of concentration and ecstatic self-transcendence

NADI ("conduit"): one of 72,000 or more subtle channels along or through which the life force (*prana*) circulates, of which the three most important ones are the *ida-nadi, pingala-nadi, and sushumna-nadi*

NADI-SHODHANA ("channel cleansing"): the practice of purifying the conduits, especially by means of breath control (*pranayama*)

NARADA: a great sage associated with music, who taught *bhakti yoga* and is attributed with the authorship of one of two Bhakti-Sutras

NATHA ("lord"): appellation of many North Indian masters of yoga, in particular, adepts of the Kanphata ("Split-ear") school allegedly founded by Goraksha

NETI-NETI ("not thus, not thus"): an *Upanishadic* expression meant to convey that the ultimate Reality is neither this nor that, that is, is beyond all description

NIRODHA ("restriction"): in Patanjali's eight-limbed yoga, the very basis of the process of concentration, meditation, and ecstasy; in the first instance, the restriction of the "whirls of the mind" (*citta-vritti*)

NIYAMA ("[self-]restraint"): the second limb of Patanjali's eightfold path, which consists of purity (*saucha*), contentment (*samtosha*), austerity (tapas), study (svadhyaya), and dedication to the Lord (*ishvara-pranidhana*)

NYASA ("placing"): the Tantric practice of infusing various body parts with life force (*prana*) by touching or thinking of the respective physical area

O

OJAS ("vitality"): the subtle energy produced through practice, especially the discipline of chastity (*brahmacharya*)

OM: the original mantra symbolizing the ultimate Reality, which is prefixed to many mantric utterances

P

PARAMA-ATMAN or *paramatman* ("supreme self"): the transcendental Self, which is singular, as opposed to the individuated self (*jiva-atman*) that exists in countless numbers in the form of living beings

PARAMA-HAMSA, *paramahansa* ("supreme swan"): an honorific title given to great adepts, such as Ramakrishna and Yogananda

PATANJALI: compiler of the Yoga Sutra, who lived c. 150 C.E.

PINGALA-NADI ("reddish conduit"): the prana current or arc ascending on the right side of the central channel (*sushumna-nadi*) and associated with the sympathetic nervous system and having an energizing effect on the mind when activated; cf. *ida-nadi*

PRAJNA ("wisdom"): the opposite of spiritual ignorance (*ajnana, avidya*); one of two means of liberation in Buddhist yoga, the other being skillful means (*upaya*), i.e., compassion (*karuna*)

PRAKRITI ("creatrix"): nature, which is multilevel and, according to Patanjali's *yoga-darshana*, consists of an eternal dimension (called pradhana or "foundation"), levels of subtle existence (called *sukshma-parvan*), and the physical or coarse realm (called *sthula-parvan*); all of nature is deemed unconscious (*acit*), and therefore it is viewed as being in opposition to the transcendental Self or Spirit (*purusha*)

PRAKRITI-LAYA ("merging into Nature"): a high-level state of existence that falls short of actual liberation (*kaivalya*); the being who has attained that state

PRANA ("life/breath"): life in general; the life force sustaining the body; the breath as an external manifestation of the subtle life force

PRANAYAMA (from *prana* and *ayama*, "life/breath extension"): breath control, the fourth limb (*anga*) of Patanjali's eightfold path, consisting of conscious inhalation (*puraka*), retention (*kumbhaka*), and exhalation (*recaka*); at an advanced state, breath retention occurs spontaneously for longer periods of time

PRASADA ("grace/clarity"): divine grace; mental clarity

PRATYAHARA ("withdrawal"): sensory inhibition, the fifth limb (*anga*) of Patanjali's eightfold path

PUJA ("worship"): ritual worship, which is an important aspect of many forms of yoga, notably *bhakti yoga* and Tantra

PURAKA ("filling in"): inhalation, an aspect of breath control (*pranayama*)

PURANA ("Ancient [History]"): a type of popular encyclopedia dealing with royal genealogy, cosmology, philosophy, and ritual; there are eighteen major and many more minor works of this nature

PURUSHA ("male"): the transcendental Self (*atman*) or Spirit, a designation that is mostly used in Samkhya and Patanjali's *yoga-darshana*

R

RADHA: the God-man Krishna's spouse; a name of the divine Mother

RAJA-YOGA ("Royal Yoga"): a late medieval designation of Patanjali's eightfold *yoga-darshana*, alsoknown as classical yoga

RAMA: an incarnation of God Vishnu preceding Krishna; the principal hero of the Ramayana

RAMAYANA ("Rama's life"): one of India's two great national epics telling the story of Rama; cf. *Mahabharata*

RECAKA ("expulsion"): exhalation, an aspect of breath control (*pranayama*)
Rig-Veda; see *Veda*

RISHI ("seer"): a category of Vedic sage; an honorific title of certain venerated masters, such as the South Indian sage Ramana, who is known as *maharshi* (from maha meaning "great" and *rishi*); cf. *muni*

S

SADHANA ("accomplishing"): spiritual discipline leading to *siddhi* ("perfection" or "accomplishment"); the term is specifically used in Tantra

SAHAJA ("together born"): a medieval term denoting the fact that the transcendental Reality and the empirical reality are not truly separate but coexist, or with the latter being an aspect or misperception of the former; often rendered as "spontaneous" or "spontaneity"; the *sahaja* state is the natural condition, that is, enlightenment or realization

SAMADHI ("putting together"): the ecstatic or unitive state in which the meditator becomes one with the object of meditation, the eighth and final limb (*anga*) of Patanjali's eightfold path; there are many types of samadhi, the most significant distinction being between *samprajnata* (conscious) and *asamprajnata* (supraconscious) ecstasy; only the latter leads to the dissolution of the karmic factors deep within the mind; beyond both types of ecstasy is enlightenment, which is also sometimes called *sahaja-samadhi* or the condition of "natural" or "spontaneous" ecstasy, where there is perfect continuity of superconscious throughout waking, dreaming, and sleeping

SAMATVA or SAMATA ("evenness"): the mental condition of harmony, balance Samkhya ("Number"): one of the main traditions of Hinduism, which is concerned with the classification of the principles (*tattva*) of existence and their proper discernment in order to distinguish between Spirit (*purusha*) and the various aspects of Nature (*prakriti*); this influential system grew out of the ancient (pre-Buddhist) Samkhya-Yoga tradition and was codified in the *Samkhya-Karika* of Ishvara Krishna (c. 350 C.E.)

SAMNYASA ("casting off"): the state of renunciation, which is the fourth and final stage of life (see *ashrama*) and consisting primarily in an inner turning away from what is understood to be finite and secondarily in an external letting go of finite things; cf. *vairagya*

SAMNYASIN ("he who has cast off"): a renouncer

SAMPRAJNATA-SAMADHI: see *Samadhi*

SAMSARA ("confluence"): the finite world of change, as opposed to the ultimate Reality (*brahman* or *nirvana*)

SAMSKARA ("activator"): the subconscious impression left behind by each act of volition, which, in turn, leads to renewed psychomental activity; the countless samskaras hidden in the depth of the mind are ultimately eliminated only in *asamprajnata-samadh*i (see *samadhi*)

SAMYAMA ("constraint"): the combined practice of concentration (*dharana*), meditation (dhyana), and ecstasy(samadhi) in regard to the same object

SAT ("being/reality/truth"): the ultimate Reality (atman or brahman)

SAT-SANGA ("true company/company of Truth"): the practice of frequenting the good company of saints, sages, Self-realized adepts, and their disciples, in whose company the ultimate Reality can be felt more palpably

SATYA ("truth/truthfulness"): truth, a designation of the ultimate Reality; also the practice of truthfulness, which is an aspect of moral discipline (*yama*)
Shakti ("power"): the ultimate Reality in its feminine aspect, or the power pole of the Divine; see also *kundalini-shakti*

SHAKTI ("power"): the ultimate Reality in its feminine aspect, or the power pole of the Divine; see also *kundalini-shakti*

SHAKTI-PATA ("descent of power"): the process of initiation, or spiritual baptism, by means of the benign transmission of an advanced or even enlightened adept (*siddha*), which awakens the *shakti* within a disciple, thereby initiating or enhancing the process of liberation

SHANKARA ("He who is benevolent"): the eighth-century adept who was the greatest proponent of nondualism (*Advaita Vedanta*) and whose philosophical school was probably responsible for the decline of Buddhism in India

SHISHYA ("student/disciple"): the initiated disciple of a guru

SHIVA ("He who is benign"): the Divine; a *deity* that has served yogis as an archetypal model throughout the ages

SHIVA-SUTRA ("Shiva's Aphorisms"): like the Yoga Sutra of Patanjali, a classical work on yoga, as taught in the Shaivism of Kashmir; authored by Vasugupta (ninth-century C.E.)

SHODHANA ("cleansing/purification"): a fundamental aspect of all yogic paths; a category of purification practices in hatha yoga

SHRADDHA ("faith"): an essential disposition on the yogic path, which must be distinguished from mere belief

SHUDDHI ("purification/purity"): the state of purity; a synonym of *shodhana Siddha* ("accomplished"): an adept, often of Tantra; if fully Self-realized, the designation *maha-siddha* or "great adept" is often used

SIDDHA-YOGA ("Yoga of the adepts"): a designation applied especially to the yoga of Kashmiri Shaivism, as taught by Swami Muktananda (twentieth century)

SIDDHI ("accomplishment/perfection"): spiritual perfection, the attainment of flawless identity with the ultimate Reality (*atman* or brahman); paranormal ability, of which the yoga tradition knows many kinds

SPANDA ("vibration"): a key concept of Kashmir's Shaivism according to which the ultimate Reality itself "quivers," that is, is inherently creative rather than static (as conceived in Advaita Vedanta)

SUSHUMNA-NADI("very gracious channel"): the central prana current or arc in or along which the serpent power (*kundalini-shakti*) must ascend toward the psychoenergetic center (*chakra*) at the crown of the head in order to attain liberation (*moksha*)

SUTRA ("thread"): an aphoristic statement; a work consisting of aphoristic statements, such as Patanjali's
Yoga Sutra or *Vasugupta's Shiva-Sutra*

SVADHYAYA ("one's own going into"): study, an important aspect of the yogic path, listed among the practices of self-restraint (*niyama*) in Patanjali's eightfold yoga; the recitation of mantras (see also *japa*)

T

TANTRA ("Loom"): a type of Sanskrit work containing Tantric teachings; the tradition of Tantrism, which focuses on the *shakti* side of spiritual life and which originated in the early post-Christian era and achieved its classical features around 1000 C.E.; Tantrism has a "right-hand" (*dakshina*) or conservative and a "left- hand" (*vama*) or unconventional/ antinomian branch, with the latter utilizing, among other things, sexual rituals

TAPAS ("glow/heat"): austerity, penance, which is an ingredient of all yogic approaches, since they all involve self-transcendence

TATTVA ("thatness"): a fact or reality; a particular category of existence such as the *ahamkara, buddhi, manas;* the ultimate Reality (see also *atman*, *brahman*)

TURIYA ("fourth"), also called *cathurtha*: the transcendental Reality, which exceeds the three conventional states of consciousness, namely waking, sleeping, and dreaming

U

UPANISHAD ("sitting near"): a type of scripture representing the concluding portion of the revealed literature of Hinduism, hence the designation Vedanta for the teachings of these sacred works; cf. *Aranyaka, Brahmana, Veda*

UPAYA ("means"): in Buddhist yoga, the practice of compassion (*karuna*); cf. *prajna*

VAIRAGYA ("dispassion"): the attitude of inner zen

APPENDIX D
CHANTS, MANTRAS & POETRY

The Sound of OM

Om - the ancient sacred syllable - may be the only mantra you'll Ever need. By Richard Rosen

Mantras, sacred chants, come in all shapes and sizes. They can be composed of sentences, single words,or even single syllables; they can be perfectly intelligible or completely mystifying (at least to the uninitiated).

Single-syllable mantras, known as the bija (seed) mantras, are the easiest to remember and recite; they're also the most powerful. It's believed that, just as a tiny seed contains a majestic tree, each bija contains vast amounts of spiritual wisdom and creative force. One of the oldest and most widely known of these seeds is "Om."

"Om" is frequently called the pranava, literally "humming," a word that derives from pranu, "to reverberate," and ultimately from the root "nu," "to praise and command," but also "to sound or shout." It is the audible expression of the transcendental, attributeless ground of reality.

Om is the "primordial seed" of the universe - this whole world, says one ancient text, "is nothing but Om." It is also considered to be the root mantra from which all other mantras emerge and to encapsulate the essence of the many thousands of versus of Hinduism's holiest texts, the Vedas.
According to the Katha Upanishad (2.15), Om is the "word which all the Vedas rehearse."

As such, Om is the meditative seed par excellence. Putanjali - who wrote the Yoga Sutra and is considered to be the father of classical yoga - taught that when we chant this sacred syllable and simultaneously contemplate the meaning of it, our consciousness becomes "one-pointed: and prepared for meditation. In a commentary on the Yoga Sutra, the ancient sage Vyasa noted that through chanting om, "the supreme soul is revealed." In a similar vein, Tibetan scholar Lama Govinda wrote that om expresses and leads to the "experience of the infinite within us." Thus, chanting om may be the easiest way to touch the Divine within your very self.

Yogis often meditate on the four "measures," or parts, of om. Though commonly spelled "O-M," the mantra actually consists of three letters, A, U, and M. (In Sanskrit, whenever an initial "A" is followed by a "U," they coalesce into a long "O" sound.) Each of these three parts has numerous metaphysical associations, which themselves serve as meditative seeds. For example, A (pronounced "ah") represents our waking state, which is also the subjective consciousness of the outer world; U (pronounced "ooh") is the dreaming state, or the consciousness of our inner world of thoughts, dreams, memories, and so on. and M is the dreamless state of deep sleep and the experience of ultimate unity.

By contemplating the meaning of each of these letters as we chant them, we are led through the three states of our ordinary consciousness to the mantra's fourth part, the anusvara (after-sound): om. The vibration slowly dissolves into silence, symbolic of the transcendent state of consciousness, equated with Brahman (the Absolute). This silence is the crown of the mantra; it is described in the Maitri Upanishad as "tranquil, soundless, fearless, sorrowless, blissful, satisfied, steadfast, immovable, immortal, unshaken, enduring."

Richard Rosen, who teaches in Oakland and Berkeley, California, has been writing for Yoga Journal since the 1970s.

CHANTS

Lokah Samastah Sukhino Bhavantu
May all being everywhere be happy & free

Om Namah Shivaaya
I bow to lord shiva, the peaceful one who is the embodiment of all that is cause by the universe

Ganesha Sharanam, Sharanam Ganesha
I take refuge in the remover of all obstacles

Jaya Jagatambe, Hey Ma Durga
Oh mother of the world I give myself to your mercy

Seeta Ram, Seeta Ram, Seeta Ram
May Ram and Sita triumph

Rama Bolo Rama Bolo, Bolo
Bolo Ram Sita Bolo Sita
Bolo Bolo Bolo Ram
Hanuman Bolo Hanuman Bolo, Bolo Bolo Ram
Rejoice and sing the names of Ram, Sita, and Hanuman

Hare Rama Hare Rama, Rama Rama Hare Hare
Hare Krishna, Hare Krishna, Krishna Krishna Hare Hare
A love dialogue between the soul (Radha) and god (Krishna)

Gopala, Gopala Devaki Nandana Gopala
We honor, Child Krishna, son of Devaki, friend of cows

Om Namo Bhagavate Vasudevaya
Invocation to Vasudeva, the one replete with divine virtues, the granter of liberation

Hari Om
Invocation to Hari, the remover of all negative karmic tendencies, enabling the soul to come face-to-face with the bliss.

Shri Ram, Jairam
Victory to lord Ram

CHANTS

Shiva Shiva Shiva Shambho, Maha Deva Shambho
The abode of joy, the highest self, the divine, he who is benevolent

Om Dum Dum Durghaya Namaha
I call the name of the fierce warrior goddess, Durga

Om Gum Ganapatayei Namaha
Om and salutations for Ganapati (Ganesha)

Nataraj, Nataraja, Jai Shiva Shankara, Nataraja
Shivaraj Shivaraja, Shambo Shankara Shivaraja
I celebrate Lord Shiva in the form of Nataraja, Lord of the dance

Shayme Radhe Radhe Shyam, Shaym Radhe Radhe Shyam
Shayme Radhe Radhe Shyam, Shaym
Radhe Shyam Hari Krishna Hari
Krishna Krishna Krishna Hari Hari Ram
Ram Hari Ram, Ram Ram Hari Hari
Radhe Krishna, Radhe Krishna
A chant to the divine masculine and Feminine Om Namanarayanaya: I chant to lord Vishnu, God of preservation, who works for the preservation of dharma or righteousness.

Ra Ma Da Sa, Sa Say So Hung
Ra = Fire
Ma = Water
Da = Earth
Sa = Air
SAY = which is the totality of experience
SO = is the personal sense of identity.
Hung = is the infinite, vibrating, and real. Hung suggests Hu, which is the life of God in everything and every being. The ng causes the sound in Hung to stimulate the divine glands. The sound of the breath is So Hung. The inhale is So and the exhale is Hung. The two qualities of So Hung together mean "I am Thou".

CHANTS

ॐ ऐं ह्रीं श्रीं
Aim, Rhim, Shrim, Klim
Goddess Mantras

Om Prana Namaha
Om Prana Pranaya Namaha
Om Prana Pranaya Namo Namaha
Om Prana Pranaya Namo Namo Namaha
Chants for Prana

Om Prana
Svaha Om
Apana Svaha
Om Vyana
Svaha Om
Samana
Svaha Om
Chants for the five Vayus

Asato Ma Sad
Gamaya Tamaso Ma
Jyotir Gamaya
Mrityor Ma Amritam
Gamaya Aumm Shanti
Shanti Shanti
Lead me from the unreal to the real. Lead me from darkness to light. Lead me from death to immortality. May there be peace everywhere.

Om Rhim Nama
Shivaya Tasmai Shri
Gurave Namaha
Blue Throat Mantra

Ong Namo, Guru Dev Namo
"I call upon Divine Wisdom".

Om Mani Padme Hum
Om to the Jewel in the lotus flower!

Chakra Bija Mantras

First Chakra at root	**LAM**
Second Chakra sacrum	**VAM**
Third Chakra above navel	**RAM**
Fourth Chakra at heart	**YAM**
Fifth Chakra at throat	**HAM**
Sixt Chakra at third eye	**OM**
Seventh Chakra at crown	**SILENT OM**

Bija Mantras for Surya Namaskar

Om Hraam
Om Hreem
Om Hroom
Om Hraim
Om Hraum
Om Hrah

Mantras for Chandra Namaskar

Om Kaamesvaryai Namaha
salutations to she who fulfills all desires
Om Bhagamalinyai Namaha
salutations to she who wears the garland of prosperity
Om Nityaklinnayai Namaha
salutations to she who is ever compassionate
Om Bherundayai Namaha
salutations to she who is fierce
Om Vahnivasinyai Namaha
salutations to she who resides in fire
Om Vajreshvaryai Namaha
salutations to she whose diamond-like vajra essence is indestructible power

Om Dutyai Namaha
salutations to she whose messenger is shiva
Om Tvaritayai Namaha
salutations to she who is ever swift
Om Kulasundaryai Namaha
salutations to she whose beauty and virtue is the essence of the kula

Om Nitayai Namaha
salutations to she who is eternal
Om Nilapatakinyai Namaha
salutations to she who is adorned with the blue flag of infinite mystery
Omvijayayai Namaha
salutations to she who is ever victorious
Om Sarvamangalayai Namaha
salutations to she who is ever auspicious
Om Jvalamalinyai Namaha
salutations to she whose essence is the fire which burns through all illusion

Mantras for Meditation

Aum: Om, the Pranava, the name of the divine universe
Sat Nam: Truth is my identity and I call upon the eternal Truth that resides in all of us
So Hum: I am all that is
Om Nama Shivaya: I bow to Lord Shiva
Om Shanti: Infinite Peace

Aum Bhur Bhuvah Svaha
Tat Savitur Varenyam
Bhargo Devasya Dimahi
Diyo yo nah Prachodayat
Gayatri Mantra
We worship the word that is present in the earth, the heavens, and that which is beyond. By meditating on the glorious power that gives us life, we ask that our minds and hearts be illuminated.

Poetry

The great sea has set me in motion,
set me adrift,
moving me like a weed in a river.

The sky and the strong wind
have moved the spirit inside me
till I am carried away
trembling with joy.
—Uvavnuk

A fish cannot drown in water,
A bird does not fall in the air,
In the fire of creation, Gold doesn't vanish:
The fire brightens.
Each creature God made must live its true nature;
How could I resist my nature? Does that live for oneness with God?
—Mechtild of Magdeburg

You are the notes, and we are the flute.
We are the mountains, you are the sounds coming down.
We are the pawns and the kings and rooks
You set out on a board: we win or we lose.
We are lions rolling and unrolling flags.
Your invisible wind carries us through the world.
—Rumi

All life being lived, who is living it then?
Is it the things themselves, or something
Waiting inside them, like an unplayed flute?
—Rainer Marie Rilke

Everything that moves, breathes, opens & closes Lives in the self.
—Mundaka Upanishad 2.7

Don't go outside your house to see the flowers.
My friend, don't bother with that excursion.
Inside your body there are flowers.
One flower has a thousand petals.
That will do for a place to sit.
Sitting there you will have a glimpse of beauty
Inside the body and out of it,
Before gardens and after gardens.
—Unknown

Your body is an ocean Rich with hidden treasures.
Open your inmost chamber And light It's lamp.
—Mirabai

Surrendering to the way things are neither rasping
or resisting Manifestations of our basic nature,
luminous, clear, awake, whole, And living beyond
time and effort. Manifest naturally when we are not
trying to get anywhere or achieve anything.
—Unknown

One feels like a fish released from a small jar into the
vast powerful Current of mother Gangas, one swims
everywhere with perfect Freedom and spontaneity,
no partitions, no boundaries.
—Bengali Saint

To my fellow swimmers, there is a river flowing now very fast
That is so great and swift that there are those who will be afraid
They will try to hold on to the shore
And they will be torn apart and suffer greatly
Know that the river has its Destination
The elders say we must let go of the shore head out into the stream
And keep our heads above water
And I say who is there with you to celebrate
At this time in history, we can take nothing personally Least of all
ourselves, for the moment that we do
Our spiritual growth and journey comes to a halt
The time of the lone wolf is over
So gather yourselves and vanish the word struggle from your vocabulary
All that we do now must be done in a sacred manner and in celebration
We are the ones we have been waiting for.
—Native American Hopi Elder

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